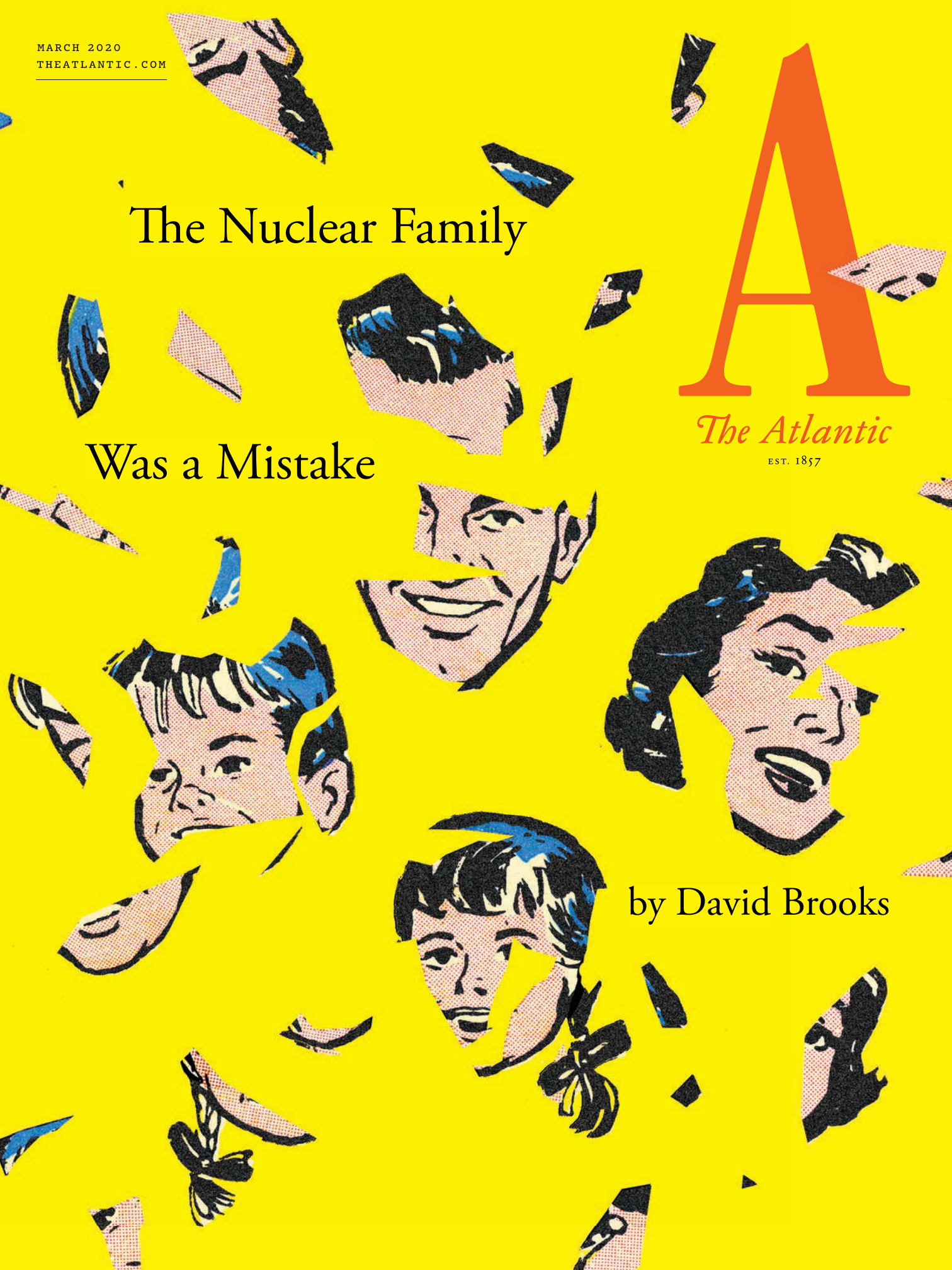


The Nuclear Family

Was a Mistake



A

The Atlantic

EST. 1857

by David Brooks

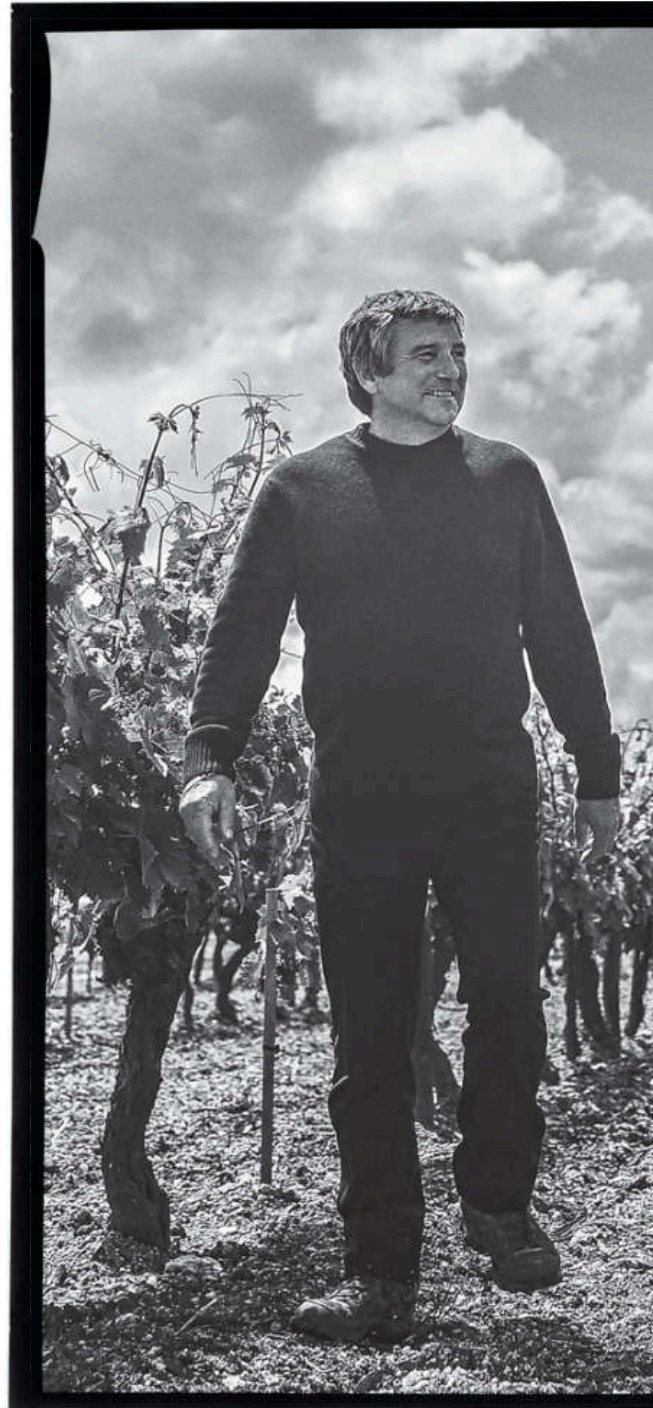


RÉMY MARTIN®

TERCET

AN INSPIRATION
FROM THREE ARTISANS

THE MASTER DISTILLER - THE WINE MASTER - THE CELLAR MASTER



NOW AVAILABLE IN: CA, FL, NY, TX, MA, IL, GA, MD, CO, WA, DC, NJ, NV, VA, SC
© 2020 E. RÉMY MARTIN & CO., RÉMY MARTIN® COGNAC FINE CHAMPAGNE TERCET, 42% ALC./VOL.,
IMPORTED BY RÉMY COINTREAU USA, INC., NEW YORK, NY. CENTAUR DESIGN® PLEASE DRINK RESPONSIBLY.



TEAM UP FOR EXCELLENCE





I FEEL LIKE A QUEEN ON THIS THRONE.

The Veil® intelligent toilet. Heated seat, warm-water cleansing and air drying take your world to the next level. Discover what you've been missing.

[KOHLER.com/IntelligentToilets](https://www.kohler.com/IntelligentToilets)

THE BOLD LOOK
OF **KOHLER**®



OF NO PARTY OR CLIQUE

VOL. 325—NO. 2

MARCH 2020

CONTENTS

Features

28

The 2020 Disinformation War

Deepfakes, anonymous text messages, Potemkin local news sites, and opposition research on reporters—a field guide to this year's election and what it could do to the country

By McKay Coppins

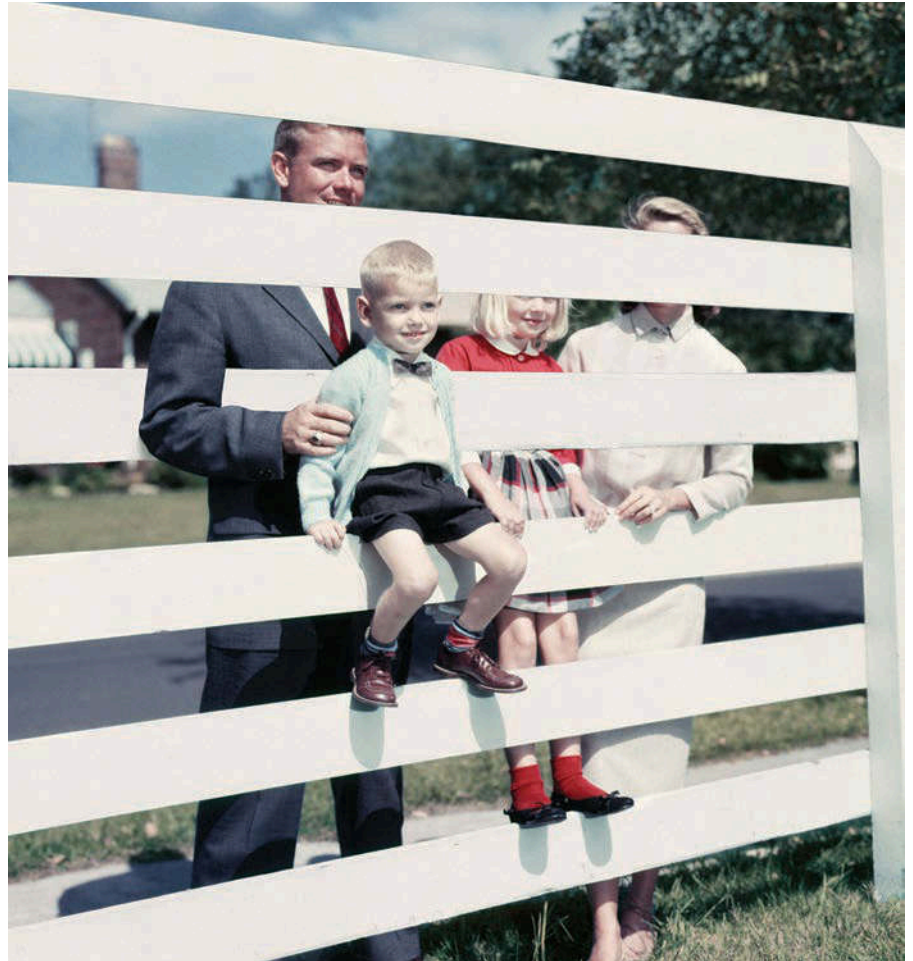
40

The Abortion Doctor and His Accuser

When a reproductive-rights activist accused one of the most respected physicians in the movement of sexually assaulting her, everyone quickly took sides. The divide exposed differences among women that are typically expressed only in private.

By Maggie Bullock

Cover Story



54

THE NUCLEAR FAMILY WAS A MISTAKE

By David Brooks

The family structure we've held up as the cultural ideal for the past half century has been a catastrophe for many. It's time to figure out better ways to live together.

ALAMY

The sheltered family of the 1950s has given way to the stressed family of every decade since.

Front

6

The Commons

Discussion & Debate

Dispatches

9

OPENING ARGUMENT

In Praise of the Herd Mentality

How the human instinct to conform could help us meet the challenge of the climate crisis

By Robert H. Frank

14

SKETCH

The Witching Hour

Juliet Diaz is at the forefront of a growing witchcraft movement.

By Bianca Bosker

18

PREDICTIONS

Can You Still Trust Nate Silver?

The leader of the data revolution believes the rest of the media is in danger of getting 2020 wrong.

By David A. Graham

22

MATERIAL WORLD

Why Restoration Hardware Sends Catalogs the Size of a Toddler

The surprising persistence of the mail-order business

By Amanda Mull

26

VIEWFINDER

Made in the U.S.A.

Objects created by American prisoners

Culture & Critics

70

OMNIVORE

The New Rules of Music Snobbery

Hulu's High Fidelity reboot captures the rise of fervent eclecticism.

By Spencer Kornhaber

72

The Mulatta Unmasks Herself to Her Husband

A poem by Shara McCallum

74

BOOKS

The Supreme Court's Enduring Bias

Siding with the powerful against the vulnerable has become the rule.

By Michael O'Donnell

78

BOOKS

The Art of Second Chances

On Emily St. John Mandel's disaster-steeped fiction

By Ruth Franklin

82

BOOKS

Abraham Lincoln's Radical Moderation

What the president understood that the zealous Republican reformers in Congress didn't

By Andrew Ferguson

Back

86

FICTION

Go, Team

A short story by Samantha Hunt

96

Ode to Cold Showers

By James Parker

On the Cover

ILLUSTRATION BY
MENDELSUND/MUNDAY

Giving A Voice To Freedom, With An Eye Toward The Future.

The story of African Americans in post-Civil War Texas comes not just from people, but from places. Preserving the state's 557 "freedom colonies" and documenting grassroots preservation practices is what moves Texas A&M University Professor Dr. Andrea Roberts, who founded the Texas Freedom Colonies Project.

She and her team partner with communities to tell their stories, preserve their heritage and protect remaining historic sites. Her research illuminates African American resilience in the past and present, while helping communities plan for brighter futures.

PRESERVATION ON EVERY FRONT.



ANDREA ROBERTS, Ph.D.

*Assistant Professor,
Urban Planning*



TEXAS A&M
UNIVERSITY

FEARLESSFRONT.COM

Behind the Cover: On this month's cover, we illustrated the ideas behind David Brooks's feature story by quite literally exploding a nuclear family. The vintage image, which conjures Bazooka Joe comics and mid-century cereal boxes, conveys a mythic familial happiness and nostalgia for the American

dream. Today, of course, that family structure and its attendant ideals are long gone for most Americans, and they're not coming back; a new approach is needed.

— Peter Mendelsund, *Creative Director*
Oliver Munday, *Senior Art Director*

THE

The Things We Can't Face

*Caitlin Flanagan
reflected in the
December issue on
what we don't talk
about when we talk
about abortion.*

is discussed. While many on the pro-life side of the argument are feeling hopeful as the judiciary becomes more conservative, I feel a growing sense of unease. The issues Ms. Flanagan so deftly points out will not be legislated away. Even if *Roe v. Wade* is overturned, the fight will rage on.

Friar Paul Schloemer
Silver Spring, Md.

CAITLIN FLANAGAN REPLIES:

I've never been more surprised—or moved—by the response to an essay I've written. I received emails from people on all sides of the abortion debate, each of them interested in having a discussion in which the full range of human emotions and experiences regarding the subject could be considered. Many anti-abortion readers were grateful to see their strongest argument advanced respectfully. And many pro-abortion-rights readers recognized themselves in the voice of a writer who has faced the whole truth about abortion, and made a firmly held decision that the procedure should remain legal.

I want to note that I received letters from readers who experienced—and were surprised by—some sense of sadness and even grief after abortions. That doesn't mean that they made the wrong decision. Only that we on the side of legal abortion could do

Letters

I read Caitlin Flanagan's essay last night; then I read it again. I have never seen my inner tumult laid out in such eloquent prose before.

The badge-wearers, sign-thrusters, and yell-louders on both sides of this fight lost me long ago, though I tip my hat to their sense of urgency. I find myself in a quieter, sadder place that doesn't marry with slogans. The costliness, the never-to-be for both woman and child, is heartbreaking. Whom shall we value? The answer is easy and impossible. Perhaps we should take a moment and mourn the tragedy of the thing.

Jamie R. Oaks
Chicago, Ill.

I am a Franciscan priest in the Roman Catholic Church who has a professional as well as personal interest in the debate over abortion. In working with pro-life groups, hearing confessions (and sometimes just hurt and anger) from women (and a few men) who have had or facilitated abortions, and trying to simply discuss the issue with friends who are pro-choice, I have long anguished over how to break through both sides and bring the subject from a place of debate to a place of understanding.

Ms. Flanagan's article has helped me tremendously down that road by articulating the pain that is so raw everywhere abortion

COMMONS



DISCUSSION
&
DEBATE

a much better job of acknowledging the full and complicated truth about the procedure, which is that for many women, abortion is the better of two bad choices.

Too Much Democracy Is Bad for Democracy

The major American parties have ceded unprecedented power to primary voters, Jonathan Rauch and Ray La Raja wrote in December. It's a radical experiment—and it's failing.

Thomas Jefferson said, “An educated citizenry is a vital requisite for our survival as a free people.” So it is disheartening to see the authors of this article support disengagement of the electorate.

If representative democracy is to be successful, then the people must be actively involved in choosing, and holding accountable, their representatives. The answer to our political woes is investment in the education of the citizenry. It is not to tell citizens to become passive players in the government—their government.

Owen Keenan
Langhorne, Pa.

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

ON THE RANCH

I have been reading *The Atlantic* since my college days, in the late 1950s and '60s, when it was *The Atlantic Monthly*. About 10 years ago, I found myself reading too much at the ranch and not doing enough work, so I quit a bunch of subscriptions and narrowed my reading list. But I still kept buying *The Atlantic*.

When I got snowed in last November, I had some time to read, and learned about the contest. My wife, Patsy, took some pictures after the snow melted, but we had no idea what the heck Instagram or a hashtag was. Grandchildren came to the rescue.

— Anthony Sanchez,
winner of the 2019 Reading
My *Atlantic* Contest
Carrizozo, N.M.



Q • & • A

In the December issue, “How to Stop a Civil War,” Adam Serwer wrote that the gravest danger to American democracy is the false promise of civility. Graeme Wood wrote about Daniel Miller, the leader of the Texas Nationalist Movement.

Q: Mr. Serwer reprises several partisan tropes. Disfranchising minority voters and attacking liberal immigration policy certainly are Republican tactics to forestall demographic irrelevance. Aren't support for Dreamer citizenship, open borders, and minimal deportation likewise Democratic tactics to accelerate demographic dominance? — Derek Ridgley, Nederland, Colo.

A: Whether or not the immigrants in question become reliable Democratic voters is within the Republican Party's ability to help decide; “open borders” as they existed for white people for most of United States history are not on the table, and deferring the deportation of undocumented immigrants does not make them eligible to cast a

ballot in federal elections. Democrats can be held accountable by the electorate for taking unpopular positions on immigration. By disenfranchising rival constituencies, the Republican Party eliminates the ability of the electorate to hold the GOP similarly responsible for its actions. — Adam Serwer

Q: Would an independent Texas issue currency? If so, trying to pay for imported goods with that currency could increase costs for Texans, because sellers would likely demand a premium for a new and untested government's issuance. — Diana Powe, Beaverton, Ore.

A: Daniel Miller hopes that Texas will issue its own currency, but he says it need not do so immediately upon independence. His “Texit” movement envisions an amicable divorce, and the new country developing monetary policy gradually, if necessary. An independent Texas could at first enter into a currency union with the remaining 49 states, then issue its own currency later, once it established the institutions necessary to manage and back its money supply. As Miller never fails to point out, much smaller economies than Texas (Australia, say) issue their own currency and do just fine. — Graeme Wood

EDITORIAL OFFICES & CORRESPONDENCE *The Atlantic* considers unsolicited manuscripts, fiction or nonfiction, and mail for the Letters column. Manuscripts will not be returned. For instructions on sending manuscripts via email, see theatlantic.com/faq. By submitting a letter, you agree to let us use it, as well as your full name, city, and state, in our magazine and/or on our website. We may edit for clarity.
CUSTOMER SERVICE & REPRINTS Please direct all subscription queries and orders to: 800-234-2411. International callers: 515-237-3670. For expedited customer service, please call between 9 a.m. and 6 p.m. ET, Monday through Friday. You may also write to: *Atlantic* Customer Care, P.O. Box 37564, Boone, IA 50037-0564. Reprint requests should be made to Sisk at 410-754-8219 or atlanticbackissue@siskfs.com. A discount rate is available for students and educators. Please visit theatlantic.com/subscribe/academic.
ADVERTISING OFFICES *The Atlantic*, 60 Madison Avenue, Suite 800, New York, NY 10010, 646-539-6700.

MORE COVERAGE TO LOVE.

**Rely on GEICO
to help you with
property and
car insurance.**

GEICO®

geico.com | 1-800-947-AUTO | Local Office

Some discounts, coverages, payment plans and features are not available in all states, in all GEICO companies, or in all situations. Homeowners, renters and condo coverages are written through non-affiliated insurance companies and are secured through the GEICO Insurance Agency, Inc. GEICO is a registered service mark of Government Employees Insurance Company, Washington, DC 20076; a Berkshire Hathaway Inc. subsidiary. GEICO Gecko image © 1999-2019. © 2019 GEICO



DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

IN PRAISE OF THE HERD MENTALITY

*How the human instinct
to conform could help
us meet the challenge of
the climate crisis*

BY ROBERT H. FRANK

“

It is worse, much worse, than you think,” reads the frightening first sentence of *The Uninhabitable Earth*, David Wallace-Wells’s comprehensive account of what researchers have discovered about our planet’s climate trajectory. The severity of the crisis, he goes on to note, has made some climatologists reluctant to describe its full extent, fearing that such candor might make the challenge we face seem hopeless. The concern is understandable:

Previous warnings of impending peril have done little to alter either individual behavior or public policy.

More than half of the carbon dioxide added to the atmosphere since the dawn of the industrial age was put there by humans after 1988, the year the climatologist James Hansen testified before Congress that a dangerous warming trend was already well under way. Worldwide, emissions continue to increase, as floods, droughts, famines, and wildfires become more frequent and more intense. This century has already been responsible for 19 of the 20 hottest years on record. According to the federal government's 2019 Arctic Report Card, rapidly melting permafrost now threatens to create feedback loops that would release much of the 1.5 trillion metric tons of carbon it holds—roughly twice the amount already circulating in the atmosphere.

Even now, there is much we could do to parry the climate threat. We could enact stiff carbon taxes and mandate an accelerated phase-out of fossil fuels. We could undertake massive investments in renewable-energy sources, launch large-scale reforestation, and alter the mix of foods we eat. We could rush to develop scalable methods of carbon capture and sequestration. Yet on all of these fronts, we are taking only minimal action. The politics around climate change remain intractable, and human nature itself seems ill-suited to the challenge: Putting off solving the problem—or hoping it will somehow just go away—is easier than confronting it. “Call me a pessimist,” Jonathan Franzen wrote in a grim

and widely read *New Yorker* essay on the climate crisis, “but I don’t see human nature fundamentally changing anytime soon.”

Having written periodically about climate issues for more than a decade, I have followed the scientific literature on the subject closely, and I understand the fatalist view that the window for an effective response is rapidly closing. But in the process, I’ve also arrived at a more hopeful perspective, one rooted in another side of human nature. Properly stoked and channeled, our instincts could help support a different trajectory.

RADICAL CHANGE CAN happen swiftly. I’m happy to report that none of my four adult sons is a smoker. But if they’d grown up when I did, I suspect that at least two of them would have taken up the habit. When my own stint as a smoker began—at age 14, in 1959—many of my friends had already been smoking for several years. My parents didn’t want me to smoke, but because they were smokers themselves, their objections rang hollow. At the time, more than half of American men and almost 30 percent of American women smoked. In some circles, it was just something that most people did.

Today, fewer than 15 percent of Americans smoke. Given the difficulty of quitting, few people imagined that such a precipitous reduction in smoking rates could occur so quickly. The decline was rooted in collective measures American society took to discourage the habit. States and the federal government raised taxes on tobacco products. In the ’50s, a pack of Camels

could be had for as little as 25 cents in some locations—about \$2.17 in today’s dollars. In many areas today, taxes have pushed that price close

EACH NEW
SOLAR
INSTALLATION
IN A
NEIGHBOR-
HOOD
CAN LEAD
TO SEVERAL
ADDITIONAL
ONES.

to \$10. In New York City, a pack of cigarettes cannot be sold legally for less than \$13. By the 1990s, many cities and states were banning smoking in restaurants, bars, and public buildings; some jurisdictions went so far as to prohibit the practice in outdoor public spaces as well.

These measures worked, but not necessarily in the way you might think. Taxes and bans made smoking more difficult and helped some people quit, yes. But far more important, these moves kick-started a virtuous cycle. One of the strongest predictors of whether someone will become a smoker is the smoking rate among his peers. With fewer people *starting* to smoke, Americans had fewer smoking peers, which reduced smoking rates still further. After carefully controlling for other factors, one study estimated that if the percentage of smokers among a teen’s close friends fell by 50 percent, the probability of her becoming (or remaining) a smoker would fall by about 25 percent.

Social scientists have demonstrated the influence of peer behavior in a host of other areas. One study, for example, found that when military families were posted to a new location where the obesity rate was 1 percent higher than average, adults in the families were 5 percent more likely to become obese during the course of their assignment there. Behavioral contagion—as the phenomenon is known—can exacerbate bullying, cheating on taxes, and problem drinking, among other harmful behaviors. But people also become more likely to exercise and eat prudently when those behaviors become more widespread among peers.

Given the power of contagion, it is astonishing that the question of how policy makers might harness this power has received so little serious attention. Even when smoking restrictions were enacted, for instance, it was primarily to protect nonsmokers from secondhand smoke. But the damage done by secondhand smoke pales in comparison with the harm caused by becoming a smoker—not just to the smoker himself, but also to his peers, who in turn become more likely to smoke.

THE BEHAVIORS THAT spawned the climate crisis are perhaps even more contagious than smoking, a fact that has gone largely unnoticed by economists and climatologists, who understand global warming as a consequence of greenhouse gases being costly to eliminate and dischargeable without penalty. This assessment leads naturally to pessimism, since the costs of carbon removal remain high and political opposition to robust taxation

remains formidable. It also overlooks contagion's potential power to help address this crisis.

We've been building bigger houses, driving heavier vehicles, commuting longer distances, staging more destination weddings, and engaging in a host of other energy-intensive activities only partly because their true costs to the planet are not fully priced in. The far more important reason we've done these things is our tendency to behave as our peers do.

The housing market provides a vivid illustration of this. Since the early 1970s, the lion's share of national income growth has accrued to the wealthy, who used some of their gains to build ever larger houses. The near-wealthy, who travel in the same social circles, also built bigger, and so on down the income ladder. Although median incomes grew little during the past half century, the median new house grew from about 1,500 square feet in 1973 to almost 2,400 square feet today. Without invoking the power of behavioral contagion, it's difficult to explain this change.

But here is the cause for hope: Where contagion creates a problem, it can also help solve it. Just as in the case of smoking, where peer effects exacerbated and then reduced the prevalence of the practice, so too could contagion help us meet the climate challenge.

Solar-panel adoption, for example, is particularly contagious. After controlling for a variety of other potentially important causal factors, one study found contagion's power in this domain to be substantial: Each new installation in a neighborhood can, over time, lead to several additional ones. (In a follow-up study,

researchers have found evidence that solar panels visible from the street exert a significantly greater peer effect than those that aren't—further suggesting

that our neighbors' behavior affects our own.) The contagion effect in solar adoption can be seen in Google's Project Sunroof, which displays aerial

photos of neighborhoods and identifies houses with solar panels by placing red dots on their roofs. Those houses tend to be near others with red dots.



There's very good reason to believe that peer effects could be similarly beneficial in other areas crucial to our climate future. Research shows that our eating habits are shaped by the habits of those around us. This effect could be harnessed to encourage people to eat healthier diets, but it could just as easily nudge people toward more environmentally sustainable ones.

Consumers are also highly sensitive to contagion when choosing which car to buy. This has led Americans to choose ever bulkier SUVs. But with the right incentives, consumers could be encouraged to make a different choice. Many states already give tax breaks to buyers of electric vehicles, but that's hardly the only way to promote change. The U.S. Department of Energy has found that when a workplace installs charging stations, its employees are 20 times as likely to choose an electric car. Practicality is surely the main reason, but the daily reminder that co-workers have gone electric could also touch off a contagion effect.

I have long shared the concern of climate advocates who warn that "conscious consumption"—voluntary individual restraint in energy usage, such as buying a Tesla or avoiding plastic water bottles—is no substitute for changes in public policy. One recent study even suggested that encouraging individual energy restraint could *diminish* support for policies like carbon taxes—perhaps by instilling the belief that personal changes reduce the need for political action.

But conscious consumption may promote progress in other ways I had not previously appreciated. Installing solar panels, adopting a more

climate-friendly diet, or buying an electric vehicle is likely to spur others to take similar steps. It might also reinforce our identity as climate advocates; in many aspects of life, small first steps can lead to larger ones. As Will Durant distilled Aristotle's wisdom about the power of habit: "We are what we repeatedly do."

EVEN WHEN EVERYONE acknowledges that a behavior causes harm, as in the smoking example, it can be hard to reach consensus on whether—and how—to respond. The difficulty may stem in part from the laudable belief that people should decide for themselves which behaviors to mimic and which to avoid. But public acknowledgment of climate change, and the risks it poses, has become more widespread among Americans. Perhaps we will be able to engineer more benign social environments with simple, targeted taxes and subsidies, calibrated to amplify contagion effects, rather than with complex, intrusive regulation.

Taxation is always controversial. But unlike prohibitions and prescriptive regulation, it shows respect for individual freedom by affording flexibility to those who would find it hardest to curtail harmful activities. We didn't outlaw smoking; we just tried to set its price closer to its full cost to society. We could take the same approach in the climate context: To diminish the American appetite for gas-guzzling vehicles, for instance, we should tax cars by fuel economy.

We could also encourage climate-friendly behavior by reducing its cost. Embedded in the 2009 stimulus bill, designed to revive the American economy after the Great Recession,

were generous subsidies for the renewable-energy industry. Those subsidies helped companies lower costs for consumers, which increased adoption rates, igniting a contagion process: Further adoption led to

CUSTOMER-COMPARISON REPORTS, ONE COMPANY BOASTS, HAVE HELPED SAVE ENOUGH ENERGY TO POWER SAN FRANCISCO'S HOMES FOR MORE THAN 10 YEARS.

greater cost reductions, which has led to still more new customers. As the climate advocate Ramez Naam writes, "Building new solar, wind, and storage is about to be cheaper than operating *existing* coal and gas power plants." Once that happens, adoption could soar.

Even leaving aside taxes and subsidies, there are ways to leverage the contagion effect. Utilities, for example, have found that customers reduce their electricity usage significantly when told how their consumption compares with that of neighbors. Opower, a home-energy-management company owned by Oracle, has helped deliver these customer-comparison reports to millions of households served by utilities around the globe; it boasts that the program has helped save enough energy to power San Francisco's homes for more than 10 years. Google Nest, the manufacturer of

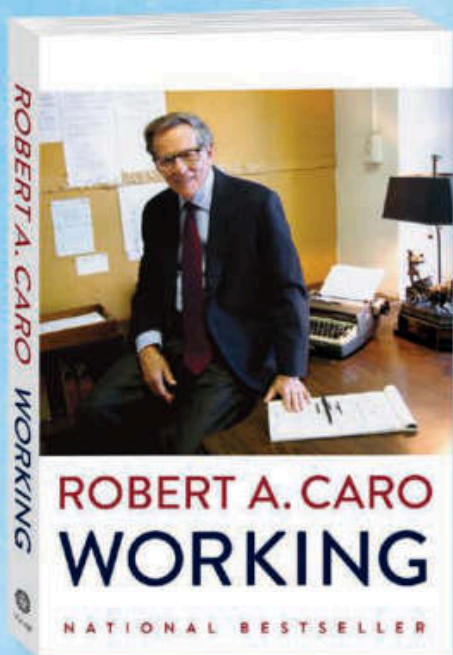
smart thermostats, has incorporated the approach into its product: It rewards customers who choose energy-efficient settings with green leaf icons (gold stars, essentially) in their monthly usage summaries, and compares the number of leaves earned with those of other Nest users in the area.

Downplaying the severity of the climate crisis would be a grave mistake. As the consensus among climatologists affirms, the threat it poses is catastrophic. Individual choices won't be enough to stave off the worst-case scenarios—significant public action is required, in the United States and across the globe. But as Gregg Easterbrook warned in these pages more than a decade ago, it can also be dangerous to portray the threat as insurmountable. Previous efforts to curtail smog, acid rain, and the use of ozone-depleting chlorofluorocarbons all seemed futile, Easterbrook noted, until we actually attacked those problems—at which point initiatives proved far more successful (and less painful) than all but the most optimistic reformers could have hoped.

As Samuel Johnson said, "To do nothing is in every man's power." But we also have the power to act, and our actions have the power to shape those of people around us. We still have time to make a difference, so why choose despair? *A*

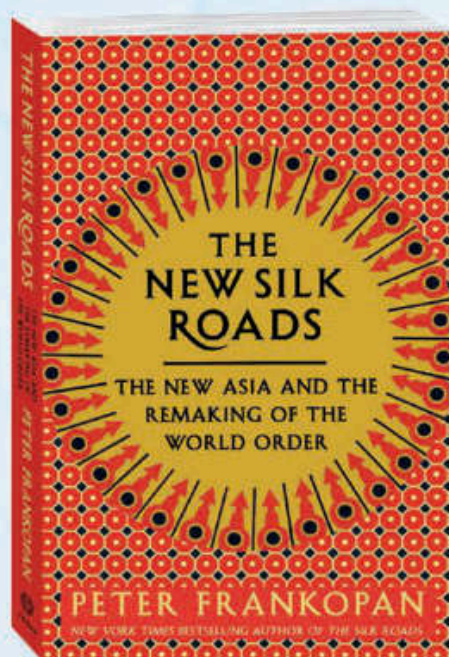
Robert H. Frank is an economics professor at Cornell University. He is the author of Under the Influence: Putting Peer Pressure to Work, from which this article is adapted.

Riveting, Illuminating, and Thought-Provoking Reading in Paperback



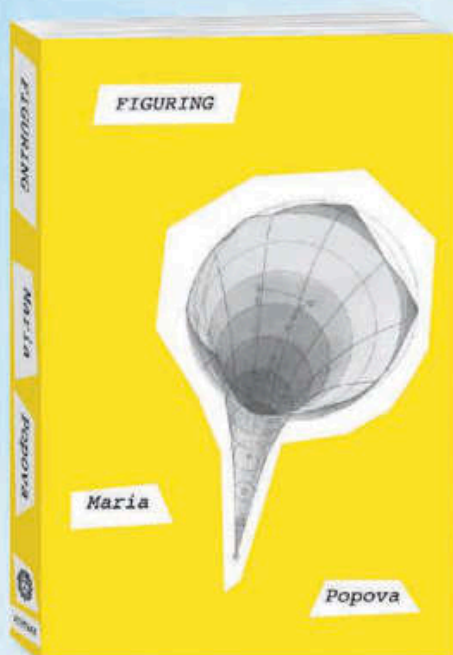
“One of the great reporters of our time and probably the greatest biographer.”

—*The Sunday Times* (London)



“A pacy, bang-up-to-date exploration of how China...is changing the way the world works.”

—*Financial Times*



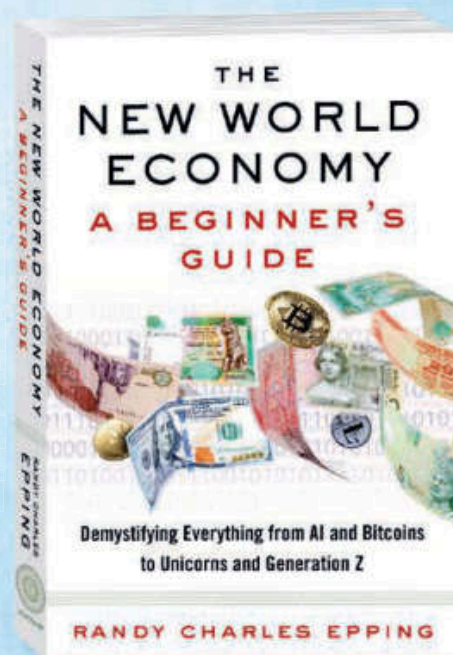
“Fascinating....

An ambitious, challenging and somewhat category-defying book.”

—*The New York Times Book Review*

How is big data changing business, politics, and our daily lives?

How can climate change be tackled in an economically sustainable way? Do trade wars actually help the domestic economy? Find out all this and more in this definitive guide to the world economy.



Also available in eBook

VINTAGE



Read excerpts, author interviews, and more at VintageAnchor.com



ANCHOR

Juliet Diaz said she was having trouble not listening to my thoughts. “Sorry, I kind of read into your head a little bit,” she told me when, for the third time that August afternoon, she answered one of my (admittedly not unpredictable) questions about her witchcraft seconds before I’d had a chance to ask it. She was drinking a homemade “grounding” tea in her apartment in a converted Victorian home in Jersey City, New Jersey, under a dream catcher and within sight of what appeared to be a human skull. We were surrounded by nearly 400 houseplants, the earthy smell of incense, and, according to Diaz, several of my ancestral spirit guides, who had followed me in. “You actually have a nun,” Diaz informed me. “I don’t know where she comes from, and I’m not going to ask her.”

Diaz describes herself as a seer capable of reading auras and connecting with “the other side”; a plant whisperer who can communicate with her succulents; and one in a long line of healers in her family, which traces its roots to Cuba and the indigenous Taíno people, who settled in parts of the Caribbean. She is also a professional witch: Diaz sells anointing oils and “intention infused” body products in her online store, instructs more than 8,900 witches enrolled in her online school, and leads witchy workshops that promise to leave attendees “feeling magical af!” In 2018, Diaz, the author of the best-selling book *Witchery: Embrace the Witch Within*, earned more than half a million dollars from her magic work and was named Best Witch—yes, there are rankings—by *Spirit Guides Magazine*.

Now 38 years old, Diaz remembers that when she was growing up, her family’s spellwork felt taboo. But over the past few years, witchcraft, long viewed with suspicion and even hostility, has transmuted into a mainstream phenomenon. The coven is the new squad: There are sea witches,

hangover cures that “adjust the vibration of alcohol so that it doesn’t add extra density and energetic ‘weight’ to your aura.” A 2014 Pew Research Center report suggested that the United States’ adult population of pagans and Wiccans was about 730,000—on par with the number of Unitarians.

SKETCH

THE WITCHING HOUR

In recent years, witchcraft has gone mainstream—and Juliet Diaz is at the forefront of the movement.

BY BIANCA BOSKER

city witches, cottage witches, kitchen witches, and influencer witches, who share recipes for moon water or dreamy photos of altars bathed in candlelight. There are witches living in Winnipeg and Indiana, San Francisco and Dubai; hosting moon rituals in Manhattan’s public parks and selling \$11.99

But Wicca represents just one among many approaches to witchery, and not all witches consider themselves pagan or Wiccan. These days, Diaz told me, “everyone calls themselves witches.”

What exactly they mean by that can vary from witch to witch. According to the

anthropologist Rodney Needham’s 1978 book, *Primordial Characters*, scholars’ working definition of a witch was, at that time, “someone who causes harm to others by mystical means.” To Diaz, a witch is “an embodiment of her truth in all its power”; among other magic practitioners, *witch* might embody a religious affiliation, political act, wellness regimen, “hot new lewk,” or some combination of the above. “I’m doing magic when I march in the streets for causes I believe in,” Pam Grossman, a witch and an author, wrote in a *New York Times* op-ed.

Casting spells and assembling altars have become quite lucrative. You can attend a fall-equinox ritual organized by Airbnb, sign up for subscription witch boxes offering the equivalent of Blue Apron for magic-making, and buy aura cleanses on Etsy. Instagram’s reigning witch influencer, Bri Luna, has more than 450,000 followers and has collaborated with Coach, Refinery29, and Smashbox, for which she recently introduced a line of cosmetics “inspired by the transformative quality of crystals.”

Many professional witches, including Diaz, can also be hired to do magic on your behalf. Diaz’s most popular offering is her Ancestral Candle Service, a \$45 ritual for manifesting intentions that I’d come to her apartment to try. (“Last month we had 4 pregnancies, 33 job promotions, 12 business startups, 12 wedding proposals! and 4 court wins,” claimed a promotional email.) Diaz—who grew up on food stamps, was homeless for parts of college, and, as an adult, sometimes skipped lunch to save up for

rent—said she has “manifested an entirely new life” from her candle work. Features of that new life include her book deal, its best-seller status, her store, and a stronger relationship with her husband. She performs up to 100 candle services each month, and said she usually sells out within a day.

GOOD LUCK TRACING the history of witches. While the idea of witches is exceptionally old—Horace’s *Satires*, already embracing the negative stereotype circa 35 B.C., describes witches with wigs and false teeth howling over dead animals—the day-to-day business of being a witch has continuously evolved, which complicates attempts to reconstruct a tidy family tree. The history of witchcraft has also long suffered from unreliable narrators. The Salem witch trials loom outsize in the American imagination, yet no official court records exist, and the accounts of the trials that did survive are, per the historian Stacy Schiff, “maddeningly inconsistent.”

More recent historians haven’t fared much better: The Wicca faith grew out of the writings of Gerald Gardner, a former customs officer whose 1954 book, *Witchcraft Today*, recounted his experience in a coven whose tenets were allegedly passed down from the Middle Ages. But scholars later concluded that they were at least in part Gardner’s invention.

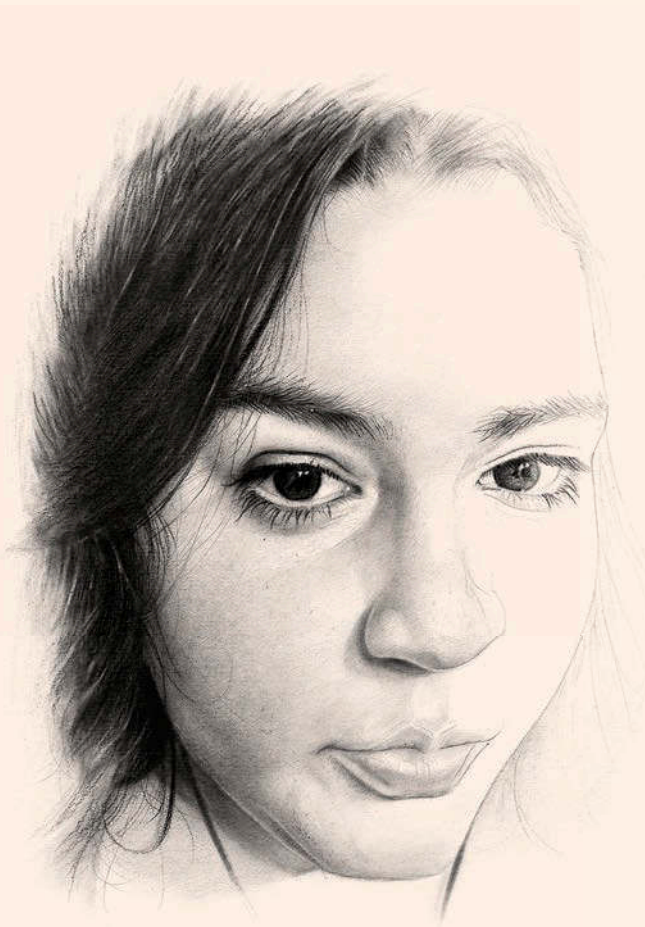
And then, no culture can claim a monopoly on witches. “There is little doubt that in every inhabited continent of the world, the majority of recorded human societies have believed in, and feared, an ability by some individuals

to cause misfortune and injury to others by non-physical and uncanny (‘magical’) means,” writes the historian Ronald Hutton, who has studied attitudes toward witches in more than 300 communities, in places such as sub-Saharan Africa and Greenland. The belief in witchcraft is so

century, as transcendentalism and the women’s-suffrage movement took hold, witches enjoyed the beginnings of a rebranding—from wicked devil-worshippers to intuitive wisewomen. Woodstock and second-wave feminism were a boon for witches, whose popularity spiked again following

unconventional sources of power—and which can be especially appealing for people who feel disenfranchised or who have grown weary of trying to enact change by working within the system. (Modern witchcraft has drawn more women than men, as well as many people of color and queer or transgender individuals; a “witch” can be any gender.) “The more frustrated people get, they do often turn to witchcraft, because they’re like, ‘Well, the usual channels are just not working, so let’s see what else is out there,’” Grossman told me. “Whenever there are events that really shake the foundations of society”—the American Civil War, turmoil in prerevolutionary Russia, the rise of Weimar Germany, England’s postwar reconstruction—“people absolutely turn towards the occult.” Trump must contend not only with the #Resistance but with the #MagicResistance, which shares guides to hexing corporations, spells to protect reproductive rights, and opportunities to join the 4,900 members of the #BindTrump Facebook group in casting spells to curb the president’s power.

Throughout history, attempts to control women have masqueraded as crackdowns on witchcraft, and for some people, simply self-identifying as a witch—a symbol of strong female power, especially in the face of the violent, misogynistic backlash that can greet it—is a form of activism. “Witchcraft is feminism, it’s inherently political,” Gabriela Herstik, a witch and an author, told *Sabat* magazine. “It’s always been about the outsider, about the woman who doesn’t do what the church or patriarchy wants.”



widespread and so enduring that one historian speculates it’s innate to being human.

In the U.S., mainstream interest in witches has occasionally waned but mostly waxed, usually in tandem with the rise of feminism and the plummeting of trust in establishment ideas. In the 19th

the Anita Hill hearings in the ’90s, and again after Donald Trump’s election and alongside the #MeToo movement.

The latest witch renaissance coincides with a growing fascination with astrology, crystals, and tarot, which, like magic, practitioners consider ways to tap into unseen,

Diaz's own history of witchcraft long predates the 2016 election. She said that she had her first vision at age 5, was taught by her mother to make potions to cure her nightmares in elementary school, and quietly used her gifts as a seer while working in crime-scene forensics after college. Ten years ago, following what she says was guidance from her ancestors' spirits, she quit her job, divorced her first husband, and threw herself full-time into working as a witch.

Diaz, a self-described "plant witch," draws extensively on Taíno traditions and herbs, jars of which occupy almost an entire room of her apartment. But the fact that there are no set criteria for being a witch is, for many, precisely the appeal. Witchcraft beckons with the promise of a spirituality that is self-determined, antipatriarchal, and flexible enough to incorporate varied cultural traditions.

Which is not to say anything goes. Although Diaz has emerged as a leading voice for an inclusive, no-wrong-answers form of witchery, she and others prick at the creeping tendency to claim the witch label without actually practicing magic. "A lot of girls, young girls, they post pictures of their house with their room with upside-down crosses, Goth clothes, with their potions. They don't even practice witchcraft, and they're like, 'Oh, I'm a witch,'" Diaz told me. "It takes away from the sacredness of the word." Diaz also says she's troubled by what she sees as the commodification of witchcraft—though, of course, she's benefited from its commercial appeal—and the cultural

appropriation that's come with it, such as white witches borrowing from indigenous or African-diasporic traditions. Palo Santo, a wood that is traditionally burned by shamans and is now a staple of yoga studios everywhere, can be purchased from Urban Outfitters, Bloomingdale's, Madewell, Anthropologie, the Whitney Museum of American Art, Crate and Barrel's CB2, and, once it's back in stock there, Goop. (In her own store, Diaz aims to source from indigenous people and sell only products she develops herself.)

Despite all this, calling oneself a witch can still be risky. Grossman told me she's received letters from numerous people who fear that if they openly embraced magic, they "would be either fired from their jobs, or have their kids taken away, or be kicked out of their families." The stakes are even higher in other parts of the world, where, per a 2009 United Nations report, being labeled a witch remains "tantamount to receiving a death sentence." Amid a rise in witchcraft-related abuse—including the case of an 8-year-old who was tortured to death in 2000—London established a police team dedicated to reducing violence targeting accused witches; by contrast, officials in Saudi Arabia established an anti-witchery unit that trains police to "scientifically battle witchcraft," which is punishable by beheading.

ON A BROCADED ottoman beside her couch, Diaz set out a tray containing the ingredients necessary for her candle ritual, which included a vial of straw-thin mouse bones ("for speed"), a snake carcass

suspended in milky liquid ("for protection"), and frankincense oil (for "opening up a portal for the candle and sending a message into the roots of the wax"). She lit a stick of Palo Santo wood and wafted its smoke over each item, carefully encircling a tall candle that she said she would "fix" with my

"WHENEVER
THERE ARE
EVENTS
THAT REALLY
SHAKE THE
FOUNDATIONS
OF SOCIETY,
PEOPLE
ABSOLUTELY
TURN TOWARDS
THE OCCULT."

intention, then burn later in the sacred area she maintains in her basement.

Diaz told me my intention should be specific, one I hadn't already made in the past 30 days, and couldn't be to make someone fall in love with me. I settled on a classic intention: money. Specifically, I was hoping to get paid for an outstanding invoice and get a friend to return money I'd lent her a year before.

"No. 1, don't loan money out," Diaz told me as she dripped frankincense oil onto the candle. "Two, always get paid up front for work that you do." She is a plant witch, but also a practical witch. When a woman messaged the community board of Diaz's online school asking for a banishment spell to expel a vet tech she thought was rough with the

cats, Diaz replied, "I would personally call inspectors and or health department." As Diaz sees it, magic is inseparable from the mundane. "I'm trying to bring awareness to [the idea] that what we think is normal is actually magical," she said. "Being on a planet that's revolving around, floating in the universe, is magical. But we're so used to these fantasies that we see on TV—you flick a wand and something just apparently happens. [People] start thinking that's what magic is, and they forget that they, themselves, are the magical beings."

Diaz finished fixing my candle and, after promising to light it soon, sent me off with instructions to complete her 13-page candle-magic workbook. I followed its directions to burn sage, express gratitude, and meditate for at least five minutes daily. Not much seemed to be happening. I tried to help the magic along by emailing, again, about the invoice and, again, about the loan.

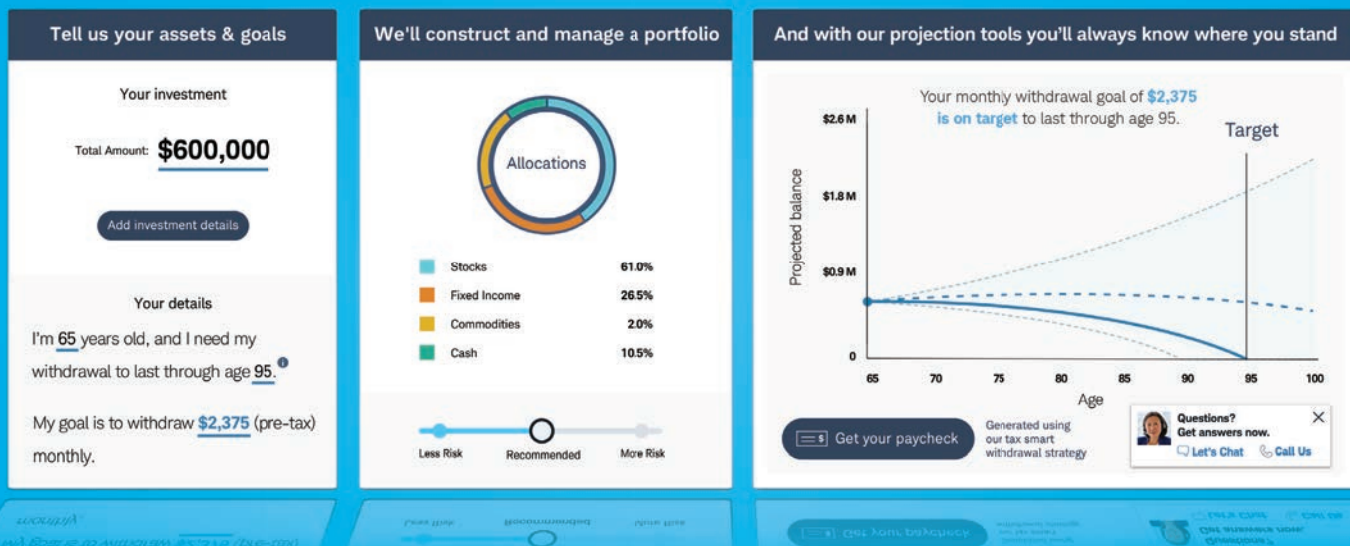
Two weeks after my visit, Diaz emailed me out of the blue: "Your candle by the way is done, it burned really well!" I was surprised to hear from her, and by her timing. Twenty minutes before, I'd found two undeposited checks misfiled among the papers on my desk, each worth more than the money I was still owed. It was a coincidence, I'm (almost) sure. But I felt, in that moment, like a disorganized, but magical, being. *A*

Bianca Bosker is a contributing writer at The Atlantic and the author of Cork Dork and Original Copies.

Introducing the modern way to pay yourself in retirement.

Schwab Intelligent Income™

A simple, modern way to generate a paycheck from your portfolio.



Plus, flexibility to **start, stop or adjust your paycheck** at any time with **no penalties**

Available with Schwab Intelligent Portfolios®, so you pay **no advisory fee or commissions**

Find out how it works at Schwab.com/IntelligentIncome



To learn more about our modern approach to wealth management, visit your local branch, call us or go to **Schwab.com**

charles
SCHWAB

Wealth Management at Charles Schwab
PLANNING | PORTFOLIO MANAGEMENT | INCOME STRATEGIES | BANKING

Own your tomorrow.

Graphics are for illustrative purposes only and not intended to represent a specific investment product.

We encourage you to read the Schwab Intelligent Portfolios Solutions™ disclosure brochure for important information, pricing, and disclosures. Before you enroll, it's important you understand any and all costs, including the role of cash and the way Schwab earns income from the cash allocation in your portfolio, which may affect performance, and how Schwab and its affiliates work together.

We can't guarantee the amount or duration of your withdrawals or any specific tax results such as meeting Required Minimum Distributions.

You may incur IRS penalties for early withdrawal of funds depending on what type of account you have.

Schwab Intelligent Income is an optional feature available with Schwab Intelligent Portfolios, which has no advisory fee and doesn't charge commissions, and Schwab Intelligent Portfolios Premium™, which offers financial planning for an initial fee of \$300 and a \$30 per month advisory fee charged quarterly after that.

Schwab Intelligent Portfolios and Schwab Intelligent Portfolios Premium are made available through Charles Schwab & Co. Inc. ("Schwab"), a dually registered investment advisor and broker dealer. Portfolio management services are provided by Charles Schwab Investment Advisory, Inc. ("CSIA"). Schwab and CSIA are subsidiaries of The Charles Schwab Corporation.

©2020 Charles Schwab & Co., Inc. All rights reserved. Member SIPC. (1219-9BYV) ADP109744-00



CAN YOU STILL TRUST NATE SILVER?

The leader of the data revolution believes he got 2016 right—and the rest of the media is in danger of getting 2020 wrong.

BY DAVID A. GRAHAM

I

In November, I visited *FiveThirtyEight*'s offices in New York on picture day. For journalists who style themselves as nerds, the formal photo shoot was a mild form of torture. Nate Silver, the site's founder, donned a blazer, forced a smile for his headshot, then snuck away to get back to work on the site's 2020 primary forecast. Though *FiveThirtyEight* now has a staff of about 35, covering sports, pop culture, and more, the site's essential element is still the elaborate models Silver himself builds to predict elections.

Silver, a former management consultant and professional poker player, got into the political-forecasting business in 2007, after growing frustrated by coverage of the Democratic primary on cable news. He could scarcely believe how bad the analysis was—based on little more than hunches and hoary wisdom, and either ignoring opinion polls or misusing them to create false narratives of momentum.

Exasperated by the guesswork of pundits, Silver championed the more objective science of polling. He aggregated polls, grading and weighting them to predict the outcome of the election—an egalitarian project that sought to replace the opinionating of insiders with quantitative analysis of voter sentiment. Silver's wonky assurance seemed of a piece with the professorial cool of Barack Obama, whose victory he predicted in 2008, and again in 2012, when *FiveThirtyEight* correctly forecast the results in every state.

Then came 2016. Like most journalists, Silver initially underestimated Donald Trump, dismissing his chances of winning the Republican nomination. It was a rare embarrassment, one that Silver attributed to losing sight of a fundamental principle: Trust the polls. Trump had consistently led in surveys of GOP voters, but Silver had succumbed to the conventional wisdom that the interloper couldn't possibly prevail.

By the eve of the general election, Silver had come to believe that Trump had a path to victory. *FiveThirtyEight* predicted that he had a 29 percent chance of winning—significantly higher than the predictions of *The New York*

Times' The Upshot (15 percent) or the Princeton Election Consortium's Sam Wang (7 percent). Ryan Grim of *HuffPost* accused Silver of inflating Trump's chances. Citing *HuffPost's* prediction that Hillary Clinton had a 98 percent chance of winning, Grim wrote that if you have faith in the numbers, "you can relax. She's got this."

She did not, in fact, have it. After Trump's victory, pollsters and prognosticators became targets of derision. Critics alleged that rapid partisan realignment, unpredictable voter turnout, and the demise of the landline had rendered poll-based predictions obsolete. Though he had been savaged days earlier for overestimating Trump's chances, Silver, as the leader of the data revolution, now absorbed criticism for its failure to foresee Trump's victory. "The entire 2016 campaign season was ... characterized by a series of spectacular Silver blunders," read a typical critique, in *Current Affairs*. It ran under the headline "Why You Should Never, Ever Listen to Nate Silver."

AS THE 2020 RACE begins in earnest, the question of whether to listen to Nate Silver returns to the fore, which is why I was visiting *FiveThirtyEight*. Silver believes he got 2016 right—it's everyone else who got it wrong, and in ways that could lead the media to get 2020 wrong as well. "I think the 2016 campaign exposed whatever your bad habits were as a newsroom," Silver told me. "But no one actually seems to have learned very many lessons in 2016."

Silver insists that polling is still up to the task of measuring voter sentiment in the

Trump era. In 2016, national polls found Clinton leading by three points on average. In fact, she won the national popular vote by about two percentage points—making those polls *more* accurate than they had been in 2012. State polls fared worse—some overestimated Clinton's support, while others underestimated it—but they weren't bad by historical standards. (Silver arrived at Trump's 29 percent chance of winning—roughly the same chance the campaign gave

"IN SOME WAYS,
POLLING IS
THE ONLY WAY
IN WHICH
THE TRUMP
PRESIDENCY
HAS BEEN
NORMAL,"
SILVER SAYS.

itself—by accounting in his model for possible variation in state polls.) Polling in the 2018 midterm elections proved highly accurate, correctly anticipating the wave of Democratic victories that handed the party control of the House of Representatives. "In some ways, polling is the only way in which the Trump presidency has been normal," Silver said.

As he sees it, the problems stem not from the polls but from how the press interprets them. During the long run-up to the 2020 primary season, he saw pundits fall into familiar traps. The same sort of commentators who expected Trump to collapse four years ago have consistently predicted a Joe Biden implosion that, as of this

writing, has yet to happen—perhaps in part because Biden's core supporters, like Trump's, are members of demographics underrepresented in the press (for Trump, non-college-educated voters and rural voters; for Biden, non-college-educated voters and black voters). Despite Biden's durable lead, the press has been quick to crown a series of front-runners in waiting, from Kamala Harris to Elizabeth Warren to Pete Buttigieg—all while largely ignoring Biden's most persistent rival for the top spot in the polls: Bernie Sanders.

To locate story lines where they don't exist, commentators seize on outlier polls, like the one from Monmouth University in August that suggested a closer race than any previous survey had. (That single snapshot was covered so breathlessly that the director of the university's polling institute took the rare step of publicly noting how much it deviated from the others.) Or pundits rely instead on what Silver described to me as "stylized facts": A strong debate performance or fundraising quarter will kick off a round of coverage of a candidate's supposed surge, even if polls don't detect much movement. It's not that these factors don't matter—they do—but Silver's work suggests that they don't matter nearly as much as most journalists imagine. By Silver's estimation, the average debate performance moves polls about as much as an average week on the trail—and, as Senator Harris can attest, even a well-received moment can take a candidate only so far.

What does this mean for coverage of the general election? Regardless of who emerges as the Democratic nominee, 2020 will have a different complexion

from 2016: Trump is now an incumbent, not a curiosity, and his opponent won't be Hillary Clinton. But a tight race with a polarized electorate offers plenty of chances to repeat common mistakes.

In Silver's view, the media were overconfident in a Clinton victory because of long-held assumptions about the mechanics of American politics. Take the "ground game"—the business of identifying voters and getting them to the polls. Some pundits initially argued that if the election was close, Clinton's superior campaign organization would put her over the top; then, after she lost, many flogged her for failing to get out the vote in key states. Yet decades of political science suggest that such tactics have a relatively minor effect on election results. Based on his analysis of late movement in the race, Silver argues that factors mostly beyond Clinton's control mattered far more than the success or failure of her canvassers in the Upper Midwest. These factors included Trump's ability to command the news cycle—Silver has found that earned media is far more valuable than the kind you can buy—and James Comey's belated reopening of the FBI investigation into Clinton's use of a private email server, which had a measurable impact on polling.

In part because of Trump's already prodigious fundraising, the old temptation to overstate the importance of the campaign war chest—and the electioneering efforts it can buy—will once again be present in 2020. As will the press's quadrennial weakness for the supposedly game-changing gaffe, another Silver *bête noire*. Obama's "lipstick on a pig" flap, Clinton's "deplorables" remark—such

moments may reveal aspects of a candidate's character, but Silver believes the media consistently exaggerate their effect on voter behavior.

On other fronts, Silver sees the press as overlearning the lessons of 2016. Journalists have obsessed over Russian interference in elections, and while foreign meddling is undoubtedly troubling, Silver sees no strong evidence that hacking or disinformation swung the 2016 result. "There's a bias toward believing in explanations that involve secrecy or things happening that are hidden," Silver said. The most important factors, he believes, are right there in the numbers.

SILVER IS NOW the elder statesman of a growing class of data-based journalists, including his frenemy Nate Cohn of The Upshot, with whom he likes to spar. Despite the beating forecasters took after 2016, quantitative analysis is better integrated into contemporary political coverage than it was before. *FiveThirtyEight's* own primary-election model is wildly complex, evidence of Silver's continued faith in the power of data. For all his success, however, Silver frets that his work is not well understood.

During my visit, the *FiveThirtyEight* staff was in the middle of a debate about how to present election forecasts so the general public can easily comprehend them. Four years ago, the site gave readers a percentage chance that each candidate would win. For the 2018 midterms, it switched to odds: Democrats had a 7-in-8 chance of taking the House; Republicans had a 4-in-5 chance of holding the Senate. Silver's hunch is that readers find odds easier to understand

than percentages, because they can imagine a series of coin flips or rolls of the dice.

Delivering forecasts in the clearest way possible is undoubtedly to the good; studies have demonstrated that the public doesn't grasp probability well. But it's hard to believe that *FiveThirtyEight* would have

SILVER'S
DEVOTION TO
QUANTITATIVE
ANALYSIS
HAS PUT HIM
AT ODDS
WITH OUR
POST-TRUTH
MOMENT.

been spared opprobrium had it predicted Trump had a 3-in-10 chance of winning. And convincing readers to trust the model again is more than just a math problem.

Silver's celebrity was never entirely a function of his accuracy. It helped that his predictions were congenial to Obama, and to liberals more generally. (Silver's name became a staple of Obama-era Democratic fundraising emails, his predictions—sunny and dire alike—invoked to persuade donors to pony up.) His own political views, however, have always tended toward the libertarian and moderate, and as Democrats have moved to the left, Silver's heresies have drawn new scrutiny. In October, he chastised "Libs" for not giving Trump credit for the death of the Islamic State's leader, Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi. "Nate Silver has been morphing before our eyes into exactly

the kind of bloviator he made his name mocking," *The New Republic* announced.

But it's Silver's devotion to quantitative analysis as much as his politics that has put him at odds with our post-truth moment. Trump's disregard for facts is singular, but the left, too, has grown more suspicious of technocrats and their pronouncements. Many liberals today see Obama as a president whose achievements were hobbled by bloodless calculations of what seemed possible. They now seek candidates who make grand ideological gestures, even if the math is fuzzy. Silver, to at least some extent, is an emblem of an era when it felt as if any problem could be solved with enough elite brainpower.

After Trump's victory, the major media organizations flagellated themselves for spending too little time with the voters who elected him. To make amends, they sent reporters to Trump country, seeking to understand the sources and strength of the president's support by lingering in Ohio diners and Pennsylvania factories. The introspection was overdue, and it tracked with Silver's long-standing belief that journalists spend too much time talking to one another. But this reporting is by definition anecdotal and, to borrow Silver's term, stylized—an implicit rejection of more analytic approaches to understanding the electorate.

For Silver, no number of dispatches from the heartland can deliver the insights that hard data can. "The impulse maybe isn't bad," he told me. "But, you know, polls are also a way of talking to voters." *A*

David A. Graham is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

PROMOTION



The Atlantic

Discover the ideas shaping history.

The Atlantic has been making sense of the world since 1857.
When you become a subscriber, you'll not only strengthen
our tradition of independent journalism—you'll also gain
unlimited access to stories that help you navigate what's ahead.

Subscribe at [TheAtlantic.com/join](https://www.theatlantic.com/join).



WHY RESTORATION HARDWARE SENDS CATALOGS THE SIZE OF A TODDLER

The surprising persistence of the mail-order business

BY AMANDA MULL

When you enter the RH (formerly Restoration Hardware) megastore in New York City's Meatpacking District, you might think it's a place to buy furniture. Technically it is, with tens of thousands of square feet filled with dining-room sets and king-size beds and couches, upholstered in shades of gray and beige and beiger, and accessorized with plush rugs and metal-armed lamps. Or maybe you'll mistake it for a hotel lobby, with its high ceilings, ample seating, and smiling concierge.

But on either side of the store's broad central path, you'll see its true spiritual, if not practical, purpose: as a temple to the high-end furniture chain's infamous "source books." On twin circular tables large enough for an extended family's Thanksgiving dinner (yours for \$7,995 each), eight different editions sit in neat stacks and offer inspiration tailored to ski chalets, beach

getaways, or nurseries for rich babies, depending on the tome. Bathed in golden light from enormous \$12,000 chandeliers, the gods of direct-mail marketing beckon enticingly from their "carbonized split bamboo" altars.

The biggest of RH's 2019 catalogs was 730 glossy pages—from a few feet away, you might think it's the September issue of *Vogue*. The company would not reveal how much it spends on the lavish compendiums, but in 2012, an industry expert estimated that they would require a multimillion-dollar budget, with each individual book costing as much as \$3 to print and ship—a figure that doesn't include the tab for photography or page design. RH's catalogs, and its price points, were similar to Pottery Barn's and Crate & Barrel's until the late aughts, when the source books and opulently appointed stores began to be introduced. Both are part of what longtime Chairman and CEO Gary Friedman has described as a strategy to

project abundance and turn the heads of wealthy customers; apparently, it's worked. In 2001, the company was teetering on the edge of bankruptcy. While there have been bumps along the way, RH's sales since then have increased dramatically, and in December its stock price hit an all-time high.

All the pageantry for catalogs might seem puzzling, given that print media and retail stores are struggling to compete with the infotainment hub of the smartphone. But although the number of catalogs mailed in America has fallen since its high of 19 billion in 2007, an estimated 11.5 billion were still sent in 2018. As retailers become ever more desperate to find ways to sell their stuff without tithing to the tech behemoths, America might be entering a golden age of the catalog.

"THE RUMORS OF my demise are greatly exaggerated," says Hamilton Davison, the executive director of the American Catalog Mailers

Association, which advocates for things like favorable postage rates and tax rules. "Isn't that what Mark Twain said?" In the late 2000s, a change in federal regulation raised mailing prices for catalogs, and as online shopping accelerated in the years afterward, a lot of companies abandoned catalogs in favor of email and social-media strategies targeting younger consumers. Those retailers included companies known for their direct-mail products, such as JCPenney, whose catalog had figured prominently in its branding since 1963 but was discontinued in 2010.

Five years later, though, the JCPenney catalog was back, in defeated recognition that the physical world still matters. "You can't make me open your email, you can't make me open your website, you can't make me go to your retail store, but you can send a large-format mail piece I have to pick up," Davison says. "It's invasive, but it's welcome." Davison has a vested interest

in the future of the format, of course, but his claims are borne out by research suggesting that even though catalogs typically arrive unbidden, consumers find them less presumptuous and irritating than marketing emails. “The internet is too much like work,” Davison says, while catalogs feel more like

play. “The internet is great if you know what you’re looking for,” he adds, “but it’s a lousy browsing vehicle.” Instead of being followed around online for days by ads for a product you already ordered (or considered and ruled out), you can peruse catalogs at your leisure and disengage fully when

you’re done. It’s so analog, it almost feels wholesome.

Around the same time that JCPenney was returning to mailboxes, catalogs began gaining favor among newer companies. “You can think about a catalog as a push versus a pull,” says Matt Krepsik, the global head of analytics for Nielsen’s

marketing-effectiveness arm. “On the internet, I just have to hope that Matt discovers my website. When I send Matt a catalog, I’m reaching out to him one-to-one.”

Another benefit: Catalog-mailers can “prospect” by sending their books to whom-ever they choose, but most



email-marketing services require retailers to gain consent from recipients. That's partly because sending marketing emails without permission is illegal in some countries and partly because it's against the rules of some internet- and email-service providers—businesses risk having everything they send algorithmically disregarded as spam.

Although the average catalog costs about a dollar per copy to produce and ship, compared with pennies per email, Krep-sik says that they're particularly effective at prompting large purchases (up to twice as expensive as those made by noncatalog shoppers) and luring back customers after first purchases. Higher receipts and consumer loyalty are exactly what a plucky upstart needs to become a standard-bearer—or for a long-standing business to fight back against Amazon.

THE STORY OF the Vermont Country Store is the opposite of the now-familiar cautionary tales of businesses too slow to cater to the desires of youth. "We were still printing a black-and-white catalog in 2000," says Eliot Orton, one of three brothers who now own the business started by their grandfather in 1946. "We slowly migrated to color, even doing a watercolor treatment to the sketches we were doing at the time." The store's catalog, sent seasonally, with special editions for the holidays, is now full of color photography, but no one would mistake it for a concession to American marketers' obsession with youth. Its comfy nightgowns, flannel bed linens, and old-school candies and baked goods are straight out of a Norman Rockwell fantasia.

Not only does the company curate its products for an older demographic, but the structure of its business, which still allows people to order by phone or send in a form with a check, could have easily become a thing of the past. A substantial number of Americans, however, still lack reliable high-speed internet or credit services, and many older

"WE SPENT THE
LAST 30 YEARS
AGONIZING
OVER WHETHER
THERE WAS
A CLIFF, AND
WHETHER THE
AUDIENCE WE
WERE SERVING
WOULD
EVAPORATE."

people just don't trust the internet, a suspicion that's arguably justified. "We spent the last 30 years agonizing over whether there was a cliff, and whether the audience we were serving would evaporate and not be replaced," Cabot Orton says. But new customers keep aging into the store's market. You don't have to be very old, after all, to grow tired of trying to keep up with technology—just ask any 30-something American still trying to decide whether to download TikTok. No one has to be taught how to flip through a catalog.

Even if the majority of a company's orders are made online, as the Vermont Country Store's now are, catalogs provide an important opportunity for businesses whose appeal goes beyond super-fast service at super-low prices. The

store is a family business whose employees, from photographers to warehouse workers, all live nearby. The brothers often turn up in the catalog, modeling plaid shirts, and everyone picks up shifts answering phones during the busy holiday season. This is a company that constantly reminds you that it's still possible to buy some of what you need from people who aren't trying to eliminate competitors or extract every last bit of value from employees or colonize the moon. That kind of context is lost entirely when a nightgown appears in Google's shopping tab, alongside less expensive alternatives from Walmart.

A HOST OF internet-first start-ups, such as the makeup brand Glossier and the menswear company Bonobos, have boarded the catalog bandwagon in the past decade. These companies had thrived on direct-to-consumer websites and social-media advertising but needed new strategies to make a more complete case for their business.

That's especially true for a very modern subgenre of company that seeks to attract socially conscious young people with a mix of activism, philanthropy, and sales. The brand Cotopaxi, which uses recycled materials to make things like backpacks and jackets, is among them. The outdoor-gear purveyor shoots its catalogs in adventure-travel spots in conjunction with local nonprofits, including, most recently, Escuela Nueva, which provides education to indigenous people and refugees in South America. The organizations receive modest grants from Cotopaxi, as well as coverage in the company's

catalog and the rights to use the material for their own fundraising. "It's hard to tell that story over [social media] sometimes," says Annie Agle, Cotopaxi's director of brand and impact. "It can feel cal- lous; there's not a lot of time, and you're fighting for attention." Catalogs, in their own way, are antiviral—they're not easily shared, and they offer depth and explanation. If the catalogs in your mailbox have started to look more like magazines, that's why.

Still, consumers worried about waste and climate change might bristle at receiving paper mail when they could be reached digitally. Agle says she understands that concern, but notes that upwards of 90 percent of an apparel company's carbon footprint happens before a garment is sewn, because the manufacture and transportation of textiles is extremely expensive and wasteful. So that, she says, is where most of Cotopaxi's efforts at waste reduction have gone.

Even if paper sent through the mail is an imperfect medium, it still might be the best way for independent businesses to avoid getting sucked into the Amazon-Google-Facebook vortex—and for internet-weary consumers to avoid seeing the whole world through the filters of the Big Three's algorithms. "Something we talk about a lot is data-privacy issues," Agle says. "Obviously electronic advertising is more sustainable, but it's not necessarily better for society." *A*

Amanda Mull is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



nolimitsware

Invent the future with a digital foundation
built on VMware.

vmware.com/possible

VMware is part of Dell Technologies.

© 2020 VMware, Inc. VMware and Realize What's Possible
are trademarks of VMware, Inc.

vmware[®]

REALIZE WHAT'S POSSIBLE.™

1.



2.



4.



5.



3.



OBJECTS COURTESY OF MMUSEUM; COLLECTED BY STEFAN RUIZ, ROBERTA RUIZ, AND GORDON STEVENSON



Made in the U.S.A.

Human lives, current events, and social issues all produce physical artifacts. Mmuseumm, an institution in New York dedicated to object journalism, collects material culture to tell stories about the modern world. The items shown here, made by inmates in the U.S. prison system, illustrate the severity of restrictions imposed on prisoners as well as the human instinct to persevere through creativity and invention.

—Alex Kalman

1. Toothbrush:

Prison officials fear that the hard handles of typical toothbrushes will be converted into weapons, so some prisoners are given a “safety fingertip toothbrush,” which lacks a handle. To make this contraband toothbrush, a commissary order form was rolled up and covered in plastic wrap, then tied to the brush head with white thread.

rubber bands, and a plastic utensil.

5. Pens: The casings on pens are removed by prison officials so that inmates can’t melt them down to make a weapon. This leaves just the inkwell, which is difficult to hold. These pens were wrapped with paper and string so they would be easier to use.

6. Tattoo gun:

Made from a pen, a motor, guitar string, wire, and tape.

7. Dice: Made from bread. The white coloring comes from mold, and the black dots were made with a felt-tip pen. Because dice are typically considered contraband, these were made small so that they would be easier to conceal from prison guards.

2. Coffee kit:

Coffee and creamer containers with a spoon.

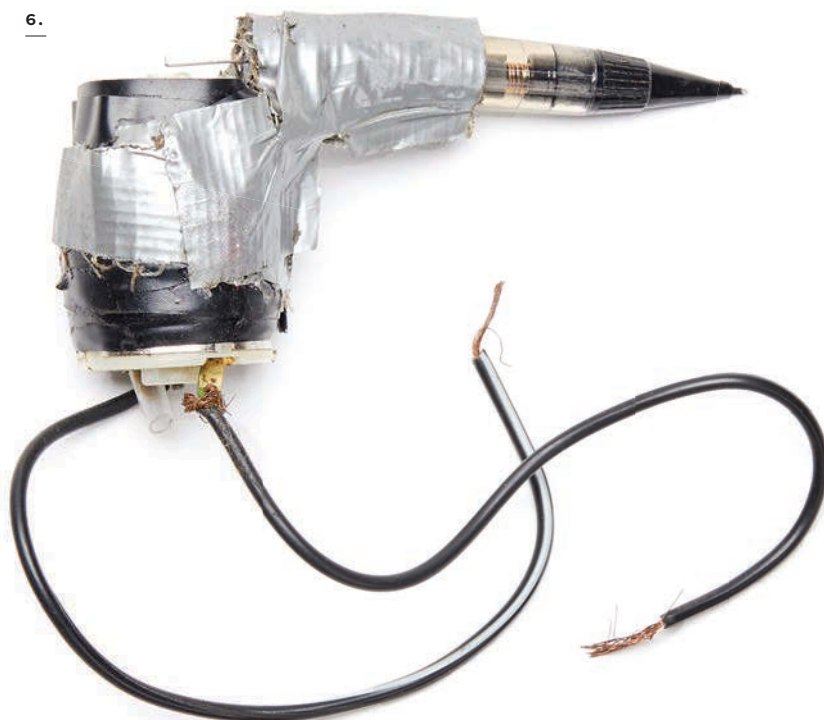
3. Weight-lifting glove:

Hand-knit using denim and material from towels.

4. Electric water heater:

Made from a piece of appliance cord, a pen clip, a razor blade,

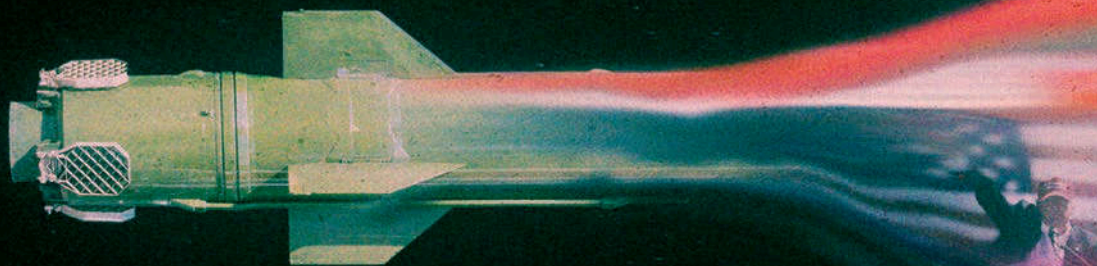
6.



7.



THE 2020 DISINFORMATION WAR



**DEEPPAKES, ANONYMOUS TEXT
MESSAGES, POTEMKIN LOCAL-NEWS
SITES, AND OPPOSITION RESEARCH
ON REPORTERS—A FIELD GUIDE
TO THIS YEAR'S ELECTION AND WHAT
IT COULD DO TO THE COUNTRY**

BY MCKAY COPPINS

Pres. Trump: Dems' impeachment vote tomorrow launches a WAR ON DEMOCRACY. Get on the list of donors I'm handed tonight. Donate NOW for a 2X-MATCH: bit.ly/2sEFn4

THIS IS A NATIONAL EMERGENCY

DO YOU WANT TO KEEP AMERICA SAFE?

Hope I'll see your name on

TEXT "MAGA" TO 88022
PRESIDENT TRUMP SEES YOUR NAME!

BUILD THE WALL SURVEY

STAND WITH PRESIDENT TRUMP
ADD YOUR NAME

TAKE THE OFFICIAL IMPEACHMENT POLL
START NOW

ADD YOUR NAME TO SUPPORT BORDER SECURITY

AMERICA'S SAFETY IS AT RISK

TEXT "TRUMP45" TO 88022



One day last fall, I sat down to create a new Facebook account. I picked a forgettable name, snapped a profile pic with my face obscured, and clicked “Like” on the official pages of Donald Trump and his reelection campaign. Facebook’s algorithm prodded me to follow Ann Coulter, Fox Business, and a variety of fan pages with names like “In Trump We Trust.” I complied. I also gave my cellphone number to the Trump campaign, and joined a handful of private Facebook groups for MAGA diehards, one of which required an application that seemed designed to screen out interlopers.

The president’s reelection campaign was then in the midst of a multimillion-dollar ad blitz aimed at shaping Americans’ understanding of the recently launched impeachment proceedings. Thousands of micro-targeted ads had flooded the internet, portraying Trump as a heroic reformer cracking down on foreign corruption while Democrats plotted a coup. That this narrative bore little resemblance to reality seemed only to accelerate its spread. Right-wing websites amplified every claim. Pro-Trump forums teemed with conspiracy theories. An alternate information ecosystem was taking shape around the biggest news story in the country, and I wanted to see it from the inside.

The story that unfurled in my Facebook feed over the next several weeks was, at times, disorienting. There were days when I would watch, live on TV, an impeachment hearing filled with damning testimony about the president’s conduct, only to look at

my phone later and find a slickly edited video—served up by the Trump campaign—that used out-of-context clips to recast the same testimony as an exoneration. *Wait*, I caught myself wondering more than once, *is that what happened today?*

As I swiped at my phone, a stream of pro-Trump propaganda filled the screen: “That’s right, the whistleblower’s own lawyer said, ‘The coup has started ...’” *Swipe*. “Democrats are doing Putin’s bidding ...” *Swipe*. “The only message these radical socialists and extremists will understand is a crushing ...” *Swipe*. “Only one man can stop this chaos ...” *Swipe, swipe, swipe*.

I was surprised by the effect it had on me. I’d assumed that my skepticism and media literacy would inoculate me against such distortions. But I soon found myself reflexively questioning *every* headline. It wasn’t that I believed Trump and his boosters were telling the truth. It was that, in this state of heightened suspicion, truth itself—about Ukraine, impeachment, or anything else—felt more and more difficult to locate. With each swipe, the notion of observable reality drifted further out of reach.

What I was seeing was a strategy that has been deployed by illiberal political leaders around the world. Rather than shutting down dissenting voices, these leaders have learned to harness the democratizing power of social media for their own purposes—jamming the signals, sowing confusion. They no longer need to silence the dissident shouting in the streets; they can use a megaphone to drown him out. Scholars have a name for this: censorship through noise.

After the 2016 election, much was made of the threats posed to American democracy by foreign disinformation. Stories of Russian troll farms and Macedonian fake-news mills loomed in the national imagination. But while these shadowy outside forces preoccupied politicians and journalists, Trump and his domestic allies were beginning to adopt the same tactics of information warfare that have kept the world’s demagogues and strongmen in power.

Every presidential campaign sees its share of spin and misdirection, but this year’s contest promises to be different. In conversations with political strategists and other experts, a dystopian picture of the general election comes into view—one shaped by coordinated bot attacks, Potemkin local-news sites, micro-targeted fearmongering, and anonymous mass texting. Both parties will have these tools at their disposal. But in the hands of a president who lies constantly, who traffics in conspiracy theories, and who readily manipulates the levers of government for his own gain, their potential to wreak havoc is enormous.

The Trump campaign is planning to spend more than \$1 billion, and it will be aided by a vast coalition of partisan media, outside political groups, and enterprising freelance operatives. These pro-Trump forces are poised to wage what could be the most extensive disinformation campaign in U.S. history. Whether or not it succeeds in reelecting the president, the wreckage it leaves behind could be irreparable.

THE DEATH STAR

The campaign is run from the 14th floor of a gleaming, modern office tower in Rosslyn, Virginia, just outside Washington, D.C. Glass-walled conference rooms look out on the Potomac River. Rows of sleek monitors line the main office space. Unlike the bootstrap operation that first got Trump elected—with its motley band of B-teamers toiling in an unfinished space in Trump Tower—his 2020 enterprise is heavily funded, technologically sophisticated, and staffed with dozens of experienced operatives. One Republican strategist referred to it, admiringly, as “the Death Star.”

Presiding over this effort is Brad Parscale, a 6-foot-8 Viking of a man with a shaved head and a triangular beard. As the digital director of Trump’s 2016 campaign, Parscale didn’t become a household name like Steve Bannon and Kellyanne Conway. But he played a crucial role in delivering Trump to the Oval Office—and his efforts will shape this year’s election.

In speeches and interviews, Parscale likes to tell his life story as a tidy rags-to-riches tale, embroidered with Trumpian embellishments. He grew up a simple “farm boy from Kansas” (read: son of an affluent lawyer from suburban Topeka) who managed to graduate from an “Ivy League” school (Trinity University, in San Antonio). After college, he went to work for a software company in California, only to watch the business collapse in the economic aftermath of 9/11 (not to mention allegations in a lawsuit that he and his parents, who owned the business, had illegally transferred company funds—claims that they disputed). Broke and desperate, Parscale took his “last \$500” (not counting the value of three rental properties he owned) and used it to start a one-man web-design business in Texas.

Parscale Media was, by most accounts, a scrappy endeavor at the outset. Hustling to drum up clients, Parscale cold-pitched shoppers in the tech aisle of a Borders bookstore. Over time, he built enough websites for plumbers and gun shops that bigger clients took notice—including the Trump Organization. In 2011, Parscale was invited to bid on designing a website for Trump International Realty. An ardent fan of *The Apprentice*, he offered to do the job for \$10,000, a fraction of the actual cost. “I just made up a price,” he later told *The Washington Post*. “I recognized that I was a nobody in San Antonio, but working for the Trumps would be everything.” The contract was his, and a lucrative relationship was born.

Over the next four years, he was hired to design websites for a range of Trump ventures—a winery, a skin-care line, and then a presidential campaign. By late 2015, Parscale—a man with no discernible politics, let alone campaign experience—was running the Republican front-runner’s digital operation from his personal laptop.

Parscale slid comfortably into Trump’s orbit. Not only was he cheap and unpretentious—with no hint of the savvy-than-thou smugness that characterized other political operatives—but he seemed to carry a chip on his shoulder that matched the candidate’s. “Brad was one of those people who wanted to prove

the establishment wrong and show the world what he was made of,” says a former colleague from the campaign.

Perhaps most important, he seemed to have no reservations about the kind of campaign Trump wanted to run. The race-baiting, the immigrant-bashing, the truth-bending—none of it seemed to bother Parscale. While some Republicans wrung their hands over Trump’s inflammatory messages, Parscale came up with ideas to more effectively disseminate them.

The campaign had little interest at first in cutting-edge ad technology, and for a while, Parscale’s most valued contribution was the merchandise page he built to sell MAGA hats. But that changed in the general election. Outgunned on the airwaves and lagging badly in fundraising, campaign officials turned to Google and Facebook, where ads were inexpensive and shock value was rewarded. As the campaign poured tens of millions into online advertising—amplifying themes such as Hillary Clinton’s criminality and the threat of radical Islamic terrorism—Parscale’s team, which was christened Project Alamo, grew to 100.

Parscale was generally well liked by his colleagues, who recall him as competent and intensely focused. “He was a get-shit-done type of person,” says A. J. Delgado, who worked with him. Perhaps just as important, he had a talent for ingratiating himself with the Trump family. “He was probably better at managing up,” Kurt Luidhardt, a consultant for the campaign, told me. He made sure to share credit for his work with the candidate’s son-in-law, Jared Kushner, and he excelled at using Trump’s digital ignorance to flatter him. “Parscale would come in and tell Trump he didn’t need to listen to the polls, because he’d crunched his data and they were going to win by six points,” one former campaign staffer told me. “I was like, ‘Come on, man, don’t bullshit a bullshitter.’” But Trump seemed to buy it. (Parscale declined to be interviewed for this story.)



AS TRUMP'S 2016 DIGITAL DIRECTOR, BRAD PARSCALE FLOODED THE INTERNET WITH THE CAMPAIGN'S MESSAGES.

James Barnes, a Facebook employee who was dispatched to work closely with the campaign, told me Parscale's political inexperience made him open to experimenting with the platform's new tools. "Whereas some grizzled campaign strategist who'd been around the block a few times might say, 'Oh, that will never work,' Brad's predisposition was to say, 'Yeah, let's try it.'" From June to November, Trump's campaign ran 5.9 million ads on Facebook, while Clinton's ran just 66,000. A Facebook executive would later write in a leaked memo that Trump "got elected because he ran the single best digital ad campaign I've ever seen from any advertiser."

Though some strategists questioned how much these ads actually mattered, Parscale was hailed for Trump's surprise victory. Stories appeared in the press calling him a "genius" and the campaign's "secret weapon," and in 2018 he was tapped to lead the entire reelection effort. The promotion was widely viewed as a sign that the president's 2020 strategy would hinge on the digital tactics that Parscale had mastered.

Through it all, the strategist has continued to show a preference for narrative over truth. Last May, Parscale regaled a crowd of donors and activists in Miami with the story of his ascent. When a *ProPublica* reporter confronted him about the many misleading details in his account, he shrugged off the fact-check. "When I give a speech, I tell it like a story," he said. "My story is my story."

DISINFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

In his book *This Is Not Propaganda*, Peter Pomerantsev, a researcher at the London School of Economics, writes about a young Filipino political consultant he calls "P." In college, P had studied the "Little Albert experiment," in which scientists conditioned a young child to fear furry animals by exposing him to loud noises every time he encountered a white lab rat. The experiment gave P an idea. He created a series of Facebook groups for Filipinos to discuss what was going on in their communities. Once the groups got big enough—about 100,000 members—he began posting local crime stories, and instructed his employees to leave comments falsely tying the grisly headlines to drug cartels. The pages lit up with frightened chatter. Rumors swirled; conspiracy theories metastasized. To many, all crimes became drug crimes.

Unknown to their members, the Facebook groups were designed to boost Rodrigo Duterte, then a long-shot presidential candidate running on a pledge to brutally crack down on drug criminals. (Duterte once boasted that, as mayor of Davao City, he rode through the streets on his motorcycle and personally executed drug dealers.) P's experiment was one plank in a larger "disinformation architecture"—which also included social-media influencers paid to mock opposing candidates, and mercenary trolls working out of former call centers—that experts say aided Duterte's rise to power. Since assuming office in 2016, Duterte has reportedly ramped up these efforts while presiding over thousands of extrajudicial killings.

The campaign in the Philippines was emblematic of an emerging propaganda playbook, one that uses new tools for the age-old

ends of autocracy. The Kremlin has long been an innovator in this area. (A 2011 manual for Russian civil servants favorably compared their methods of disinformation to "an invisible radiation" that takes effect while "the population doesn't even feel it is being acted upon.") But with the technological advances of the past decade, and the global proliferation of smartphones, governments around the world have found success deploying Kremlin-honed techniques against their own people.

In the United States, we tend to view such tools of oppression as the faraway problems of more fragile democracies. But the people working to reelect Trump understand the power of these tactics. They may use gentler terminology—*muddy the waters*; *alternative facts*—but they're building a machine designed to exploit their own sprawling disinformation architecture.

Central to that effort is the campaign's use of micro-targeting—the process of slicing up the electorate into distinct niches and then appealing to them with precisely tailored digital messages. The advantages of this approach are obvious: An ad that calls for defunding Planned Parenthood might get a mixed response from a large national audience, but serve it directly via Facebook to 800 Roman Catholic women in Dubuque, Iowa, and its reception will be much more positive. If candidates once had to shout their campaign promises from a soapbox, micro-targeting allows them to sidle up to millions of voters and whisper personalized messages in their ear.

Parscale didn't invent this practice—Barack Obama's campaign famously used it in 2012, and Clinton's followed suit. But Trump's effort in 2016 was unprecedented, in both its scale and its brazenness. In the final days of the 2016 race, for example, Trump's team tried to suppress turnout among black voters in Florida by slipping ads into their News Feeds that read, "Hillary Thinks African-Americans Are Super Predators." An unnamed campaign official boasted to *Bloomberg Businessweek* that it was one of "three major voter suppression operations underway." (The other two targeted young women and white liberals.)

The weaponization of micro-targeting was pioneered in large part by the data scientists at Cambridge Analytica. The firm began as part of a nonpartisan military contractor that used digital psyops to target terrorist groups and drug cartels. In Pakistan, it worked to thwart jihadist recruitment efforts; in South America, it circulated disinformation to turn drug dealers against their bosses.

The emphasis shifted once the conservative billionaire Robert Mercer became a major investor and installed Steve Bannon as his point man. Using a massive trove of data it had gathered from Facebook and other sources—without users' consent—Cambridge Analytica worked to develop detailed "psychographic profiles" for every voter in the U.S., and began experimenting with ways to stoke paranoia and bigotry by exploiting certain personality traits. In one exercise, the firm asked white men whether they would approve of their daughter marrying a Mexican immigrant; those who said yes were asked a follow-up question designed to provoke irritation at the constraints of political correctness: "Did you feel like you had to say that?"

Christopher Wylie, who was the director of research at Cambridge Analytica and later testified about the company to Congress, told me that "with the right kind of nudges," people who

exhibited certain psychological characteristics could be pushed into ever more extreme beliefs and conspiratorial thinking. “Rather than using data to interfere with the process of radicalization, Steve Bannon was able to invert that,” Wylie said. “We were essentially seeding an insurgency in the United States.”

Cambridge Analytica was dissolved in 2018, shortly after its CEO was caught on tape bragging about using bribery and sexual “honey traps” on behalf of clients. (The firm denied that it actually used such tactics.) Since then, some political scientists have questioned how much effect its “psychographic” targeting really had. But Wylie—who spoke with me from London, where he now works for H&M, as a fashion-trend forecaster—said the firm’s work in 2016 was a modest test run compared with what could come.

“What happens if North Korea or Iran picks up where Cambridge Analytica left off?” he said, noting that plenty of foreign actors will be looking for ways to interfere in this year’s election. “There are countless hostile states that have more than enough capacity to quickly replicate what we were able to do ... and make it much more sophisticated.” These efforts may not come only from abroad: A group of former Cambridge Analytica employees have formed a new firm that, according to the Associated Press, is working with the Trump campaign. (The firm has denied this, and a campaign spokesperson declined to comment.)

After the Cambridge Analytica scandal broke, Facebook was excoriated for its mishandling of user data and complicity in the viral spread of fake news. Mark Zuckerberg promised to do better, and rolled out a flurry of reforms. But then, last fall, he handed a major victory to lying politicians: Candidates, he said, would be allowed to continue running false ads on Facebook. (Commercial advertisers, by contrast, are subject to fact-checking.) In a speech at Georgetown University, the CEO argued that his company shouldn’t be responsible for arbitrating political speech, and that because political ads already receive so much scrutiny, candidates who choose to lie will be held accountable by journalists and watchdogs.

To bolster his case, Zuckerberg pointed to the recently launched—and publicly accessible—“library” where Facebook archives every political ad it publishes. The project has a certain democratic appeal: Why censor false or toxic content when a little sunlight can have the same effect? But spend some time scrolling through the archive of Trump reelection ads, and you quickly see the limits of this transparency.

The campaign doesn’t run just one ad at a time on a given theme. It runs hundreds of iterations—adjusting the language,

the music, even the colors of the “Donate” buttons. In the 10 weeks after the House of Representatives began its impeachment inquiry, the Trump campaign ran roughly 14,000 different ads containing the word *impeachment*. Sifting through all of them is virtually impossible.

Both parties will rely on micro-targeted ads this year, but the president is likely to have a distinct advantage. The Republican

National Committee and the Trump campaign have reportedly compiled an average of 3,000 data points on every voter in America. They have spent years experimenting with ways to tweak their messages based not just on gender and geography, but on whether the recipient owns a gun or watches the Golf Channel.

While these ads can be used to try to win over undecided voters, they’re most often deployed for fundraising and for firing up the faithful—and Trump’s advisers believe this election will be decided by mobilization, not persuasion. To turn out the base, the campaign has signaled that it will return to familiar themes: the threat of “illegal aliens”—a term Parscale has reportedly encouraged Trump to use—and the corruption of the “swamp.”

Beyond Facebook, the campaign is also investing in a texting platform that could allow it to send anonymous messages directly to millions of voters’ phones without their permis-

sion. Until recently, people had to opt in before a campaign could include them in a mass text. But with new “peer to peer” texting apps—including one developed by Gary Coby, a senior Trump adviser—a single volunteer can send hundreds of messages an hour, skirting federal regulations by clicking “Send” one message at a time. Notably, these messages aren’t required to disclose who’s behind them, thanks to a 2002 ruling by the Federal Election Commission that cited the limited number of characters available in a text.

Most experts assume that these regulations will be overhauled sometime after the 2020 election. For now, campaigns from both parties are hoovering up as many cellphone numbers as possible, and Parscale has said texting will be at the center of Trump’s reelection strategy. The medium’s ability to reach voters is unparalleled: While robocalls get sent to voicemail and email blasts get trapped in spam folders, peer-to-peer texting companies say that at least 90 percent of their messages are opened.

SHADY POLITICAL ACTORS ARE DISCOVERING HOW EASY IT IS TO WAGE AN UNTRACEABLE WHISPER CAMPAIGN BY TEXT MESSAGE.

CAMPAIGN PROPAGANDA

The Trump campaign's texts so far this cycle have focused on shouty fundraising pleas ("They have NOTHING! IMPEACHMENT IS OVER! Now let's CRUSH our End of Month Goal"). But the potential for misuse by outside groups is clear—and shady political actors are already discovering how easy it is to wage an untraceable whisper campaign by text.

In 2018, as early voting got under way in Tennessee's Republican gubernatorial primary, voters began receiving text messages attacking two of the candidates' conservative credentials. The texts—written in a conversational style, as if they'd been sent from a friend—were unsigned, and people who tried calling the numbers received a busy signal. The local press covered the smear campaign. Law enforcement was notified. But the source of the texts was never discovered.

WAR ON THE PRESS

One afternoon last March, I was on the phone with a Republican operative close to the Trump family when he casually mentioned that a reporter at *Business Insider* was about to have a very bad day. The journalist, John Haltiwanger, had tweeted something that annoyed Donald Trump Jr., prompting the coterie of friends and allies surrounding the president's son to drum up a hit piece. The story they had coming, the operative suggested to me, would demolish the reporter's credibility.

I wasn't sure what to make of this gloating—people in Trump's circle have a tendency toward bluster. But a few hours later, the operative sent me a link to a *Breitbart News* article documenting Haltiwanger's "history of intense Trump hatred." The story was based on a series of Instagram posts—all of them from before Haltiwanger started working at *Business Insider*—in which he made fun of the president and expressed solidarity with liberal protesters.

The next morning, Don Jr. tweeted the story to his 3 million followers, denouncing Haltiwanger as a "raging lib." Other conservatives piled on, and the reporter was bombarded with abusive messages and calls for him to be fired. His employer issued a statement conceding that the Instagram posts were "not appropriate." Haltiwanger kept his job, but the experience, he told me later, "was bizarre and unsettling."

The *Breitbart* story was part of a coordinated effort by a coalition of Trump allies to air embarrassing information about reporters who produce critical coverage of the president. (*The New York Times* first reported on this project last summer; since then, it's been described to me in greater detail.) According to people with knowledge of the effort, pro-Trump operatives have scraped social-media accounts belonging to hundreds of political journalists and compiled years' worth of posts into a dossier.

Often when a particular news story is deemed especially unfair—or politically damaging—to the president, Don Jr. will flag it in a text thread that he uses for this purpose. (Among those who text regularly with the president's eldest son, someone close to him told me, are the conservative activist Charlie Kirk; two GOP strategists, Sergio Gor and Arthur Schwartz; Matthew Boyle, a *Breitbart* editor; and U.S. Ambassador Richard Grenell.) Once

a story has been marked for attack, someone searches the dossier for material on the journalists involved. If something useful turns up—a problematic old joke; evidence of liberal political views—Boyle turns it into a *Breitbart* headline, which White House officials and campaign surrogates can then share on social media. (The White House has denied any involvement in this effort.)

Descriptions of the dossier vary. One source I spoke with said that a programmer in India had been paid to organize it into a searchable database, making posts that contain offensive keywords easier to find. Another told me the dossier had expanded to at least 2,000 people, including not just journalists but high-profile academics, politicians, celebrities, and other potential Trump foes. Some of this, of course, may be hyperbolic boasting—but the effort has yielded fruit.

In the past year, the operatives involved have gone after journalists at CNN, *The Washington Post*, and *The New York Times*. They exposed one reporter for using the word *fag* in college, and another for posting anti-Semitic and racist jokes a decade ago. These may not have been career-ending revelations, but people close to the project said they're planning to unleash much more opposition research as the campaign intensifies. "This is innovative shit," said Mike Cernovich, a right-wing activist with a history of trolling. "They're appropriating call-out culture."

What's notable about this effort is not that it aims to expose media bias. Conservatives have been complaining—with some merit—about a liberal slant in the press for decades. But in the Trump era, an important shift has taken place. Instead of trying to reform the press, or critique its coverage, today's most influential conservatives want to destroy the mainstream media altogether. "Journalistic integrity is dead," Boyle declared in a 2017 speech at the Heritage Foundation. "There is no such thing anymore. So everything is about weaponization of information."

It's a lesson drawn from demagogues around the world: When the press as an institution is weakened, fact-based journalism becomes just one more drop in the daily deluge of content—no more or less credible than partisan propaganda. Relativism is the real goal of Trump's assault on the press, and the more "enemies of the people" his allies can take out along the way, the better. "A culture war is a war," Steve Bannon told the *Times* last year. "There are casualties in war."

This attitude has permeated the president's base. At rallies, people wear T-shirts that read ROPE. TREE. JOURNALIST. SOME ASSEMBLY REQUIRED. A *CBS News/YouGov* poll has found that just 11 percent of strong Trump supporters trust the mainstream media—while 91 percent turn to the president for "accurate information." This dynamic makes it all but impossible for the press to hold the president accountable, something Trump himself seems to understand. "Remember," he told a crowd in 2018, "what you're seeing and what you're reading is not what's happening."

Bryan Lanza, who worked for the Trump campaign in 2016 and remains a White House surrogate, told me flatly that he sees no possibility of Americans establishing a common set of facts from which to conduct the big debates of this year's election. Nor is that his goal. "It's our job to sell our narrative louder than the media," Lanza said. "They're clearly advocating for a liberal-socialist position, and we're never going to be in concert. So the war continues."

Parscale has indicated that he plans to open up a new front in this war: local news. Last year, he said the campaign intends to train “swarms of surrogates” to undermine negative coverage from local TV stations and newspapers. Polls have long found that Americans across the political spectrum trust local news more than national media. If the campaign has its way, that trust will be eroded by November. “We can actually build up and fight with the local newspapers,” Parscale told donors, according to a recording provided by *The Palm Beach Post*. “So we’re not just fighting on Fox News, CNN, and MSNBC with the same 700,000 people watching every day.”

Running parallel to this effort, some conservatives have been experimenting with a scheme to exploit the credibility of local journalism. Over the past few years, hundreds of websites with innocuous-sounding names like the *Arizona Monitor* and *The Kalamazoo Times* have begun popping up. At first glance, they look like regular publications, complete with community notices and coverage of schools. But look closer and you’ll find that there are often no mastheads, few if any bylines, and no addresses for local offices. Many of them are organs of Republican lobbying groups; others belong to a mysterious company called Locality Labs, which is run by a conservative activist in Illinois. Readers are given no indication that these sites have political agendas—which is precisely what makes them valuable.

According to one longtime strategist, candidates looking to plant a negative story about an opponent can pay to have their desired headlines posted on some of these Potemkin news sites. By working through a third-party consulting firm—instead of paying the sites directly—candidates are able to obscure their involvement in the scheme when they file expenditures to the Federal Election Commission. Even if the stories don’t fool savvy readers, the headlines are convincing enough to be flashed across the screen in a campaign commercial or slipped into fundraising emails.

DIGITAL DIRTY TRICKS

Shortly after polls closed in Kentucky’s gubernatorial election last November, an anonymous Twitter user named @Overlordkraken1 announced to his 19 followers that he had “just shredded a box of Republican mail in ballots” in Louisville.

There was little reason to take this claim at face value, and plenty of reason to doubt it (beginning with the fact that he’d misspelled *Louisville*). But the race was tight, and as incumbent Governor Matt

Bevin began to fall behind in the vote total, an army of Twitter bots began spreading the election-rigging claim.

The original post was removed by Twitter, but by then thousands of automated accounts were circulating screenshots of it with the hashtag #StoptheSteal. Popular right-wing internet personalities jumped on the narrative, and soon the Bevin campaign was making noise about unspecified voting “irregularities.” When the race was called for his opponent, the governor refused to concede, and asked for a statewide review of the vote. (No evidence of ballot-shredding was found, and he finally admitted defeat nine days later.)

The Election Night disinformation blitz had all the markings of a foreign influence operation. In 2016, Russian trolls had worked in similar ways to contaminate U.S. political discourse—posing as Black Lives Matter activists in an attempt to inflame racial divisions, and fanning pro-Trump conspiracy theories. (They even used Facebook to organize rallies, including one for Muslim supporters of Clinton in Washington, D.C., where they got someone to hold up a sign attributing a fictional quote to the candidate: “I think Sharia law will be a powerful new direction of freedom.”)

But when Twitter employees later reviewed the activity surrounding Kentucky’s election, they concluded that the bots

were largely based in America—a sign that political operatives here were learning to mimic Russian trolling tactics.

Of course, dirty tricks aren’t new to American politics. From Lee Atwater and Roger Stone to the crooked machine Democrats of Chicago, the country has a long history of underhanded operatives smearing opponents and meddling in elections. And, in fact, Samuel Woolley, a scholar who studies digital propaganda, told me that the first documented deployment of politicized Twitter bots was in the U.S. In 2010, an Iowa-based conservative group set up a small network of automated accounts with names like @BrianD82 to promote the idea that Martha Coakley, a Democrat running for Senate in Massachusetts, was anti-Catholic.

Since then, the tactics of Twitter warfare have grown more sophisticated, as regimes around the world experiment with new ways to deploy their cybermilitias. In Mexico, supporters of then-President Enrique Peña Nieto created “sock puppet” accounts to pose as protesters and sabotage the opposition movement. In

**PARSCALE HAS
SAID THE
CAMPAIGN
INTENDS TO
TRAIN “SWARMS
OF SURROGATES”
TO UNDERMINE
COVERAGE
FROM LOCAL
TV STATIONS AND
NEWSPAPERS.**

Azerbaijan, a pro-government youth group waged coordinated harassment campaigns against journalists, flooding their Twitter feeds with graphic threats and insults. When these techniques prove successful, Woolley told me, Americans improve upon them. “It’s almost as if there’s a Columbian exchange between developing-world authoritarian regimes and the West,” he said.

Parscale has denied that the campaign uses bots, saying in a *60 Minutes* interview, “I don’t think [they] work.” He may be right—it’s unlikely that these nebulous networks of trolls and bots could swing a national election. But they do have their uses. They can simulate false consensus, derail sincere debate, and hound people out of the public square.

According to one study, bots accounted for roughly 20 percent of all the tweets posted about the 2016 election during one five-week period that year. And Twitter is already infested with bots that seem designed to boost Trump’s reelection prospects. Regardless of where they’re coming from, they have tremendous potential to divide, radicalize, and stoke hatred that lasts long after the votes are cast.

Rob Flaherty, who served as the digital director for Beto O’Rourke’s presidential campaign, told me that Twitter in 2020 is a “hall of mirrors.” He said one mysterious account started a viral rumor that the gunman who killed seven people in Odessa, Texas, last summer had a BETO bumper sticker on his car. Another masqueraded as an O’Rourke supporter and hurled racist invective at a journalist. Some of these tactics echoed 2016, when Russian agitators posed as Bernie Sanders supporters and stirred up anger toward Hillary Clinton.

Flaherty said he didn’t know who was behind the efforts targeting O’Rourke, and the candidate dropped out before they could make a real difference. “But you can’t watch this landscape and not get the feeling that someone’s fucking with something,” he told me. Flaherty has since joined Joe Biden’s campaign, which has had to contend with similar distortions: Last year, a website resembling an official Biden campaign page appeared on the internet. It emphasized elements of the candidate’s legislative record likely to hurt him in the Democratic primary—opposition to same-sex marriage, support for the Iraq War—and featured video clips of his awkward encounters with women. The site quickly became one of the most-visited Biden-related sites on the web. It was designed by a Trump consultant.

FIGHTING FIRE WITH FIRE

As the president’s reelection machine ramps up, Democratic strategists have found themselves debating an urgent question: Can they defeat the Trump coalition without adopting its tactics?

On one side of this argument is Dmitri Mehlhorn, a consultant notorious for his willingness to experiment with digital subterfuge. During Alabama’s special election in 2017, Mehlhorn helped fund at least two “false flag” operations against the Republican Senate candidate, Roy Moore. For one scheme, faux Russian Twitter bots followed the candidate’s account to make it look like the Kremlin was backing Moore. For another, a fake social-media campaign, dubbed “Dry Alabama,” was designed to

link Moore to fictional Baptist teetotalers trying to ban alcohol. (Mehlhorn has claimed that he was unaware of these efforts and does not support the use of misinformation.)

When *The New York Times* uncovered the second plot, one of the activists involved, Matt Osborne, contended that Democrats had no choice but to employ such unscrupulous techniques. “If you don’t do it, you’re fighting with one hand tied behind your back,” Osborne said. “You have a moral imperative to do this—to do whatever it takes.”

Others have argued that this is precisely the wrong moment for Democrats to start abandoning ideals of honesty and fairness. “It’s just not in my values to go out there making shit up and tricking voters,” Flaherty told me. “I know there’s this whole fight-fire-with-fire contingent, but generally when you ask them what they mean, they’re like, ‘Lie!’” Some also note that the president has already handed them plenty of ammunition. “I don’t think the Democratic campaign is going to need to make stuff up about Trump,” Judd Legum, the author of a progressive newsletter about digital politics, told me. “They can stick to things that are true.”

One Democrat straddling these two camps is a young, tech-savvy strategist named Tara McGowan. Last fall, she and the former Obama adviser David Plouffe launched a political-action committee with a pledge to spend \$75 million attacking Trump online. At the time, the president’s campaign was running more ads on Facebook and Google than the top four Democratic candidates combined. McGowan’s plans to return fire included such ads, but she also had more creative—and controversial—measures in mind.

For example, she established a media organization with a staff of writers to produce left-leaning “hometown news” stories that can be micro-targeted to persuadable voters on Facebook without any indication that they’re paid for by a political group. Though she insists that the reporting is strictly factual, some see the enterprise as a too-close-for-comfort co-opting of right-wing tactics.

When I spoke with McGowan, she was open about her willingness to push boundaries that might make some Democrats queasy. As far as she was concerned, the “super-predator” ads Trump ran to depress black turnout in 2016 were “fair game” because they had some basis in fact. (Clinton did use the term in 1996, to refer to gang members.) McGowan suggested that a similar approach could be taken with conservatives. She ruled out attempts to misinform Republicans about when and where to vote—a tactic Mehlhorn reportedly considered, though he later said he was joking—but said she would pursue any strategy that was “in the bounds of the law.”

“We are in a radically disruptive moment right now,” McGowan told me. “We have a president that lies every day, unabashedly ... I think Trump is so desperate to win this election that he will do anything. There will be no bar too low for him.”

This intraparty split was highlighted last year when state officials urged the Democratic National Committee to formally disavow the use of bots, troll farms, and “deepfakes” (digitally manipulated videos that can, with alarming precision, make a person appear to do or say anything). Supporters saw the proposed pledge as a way of contrasting their party’s values with those of the GOP. But after months of lobbying, the committee refused to adopt the pledge.

Meanwhile, experts worried about domestic disinformation are looking to other countries for lessons. The most successful recent example may be Indonesia, which cracked down on the problem after a wave of viral lies and conspiracy theories pushed by hard-line Islamists led to the defeat of a popular Christian Chinese candidate for governor in 2016. To prevent a similar disruption in last year's presidential election, a coalition of journalists from more than two dozen top Indonesian news outlets worked together to identify and debunk hoaxes before they gained traction online. But while that may sound like a promising model, it was paired with aggressive efforts by the state to monitor and arrest purveyors of fake news—an approach that would run afoul of the First Amendment if attempted in the U.S.

Richard Stengel, who served as the undersecretary of state for public diplomacy under President Obama, spent almost three years trying to counter digital propaganda from the Islamic State and Russia. By the time he left office, he told me, he was convinced that disinformation would continue to thrive until big tech companies were forced to take responsibility for it. Stengel has proposed amending the 1996 Communications Decency Act, which shields online platforms from liability for messages posted by third parties. Companies such as Facebook and Twitter, he believes, should be required by law to police their platforms for disinformation and abusive trolling. "It's not going to solve the whole problem," he told me, "but it's going to help with volume."

There is one other case study to consider. During the Ukrainian revolution in 2014, pro-democracy activists found that they could defang much of the false information about their movement by repeatedly exposing its Russian origins. But this kind of transparency comes with a cost, Stengel observed. Over time, alertness to the prevalence of propaganda can curdle into paranoia. Russian operatives have been known to encourage such anxiety by spreading rumors that exaggerate their own influence. Eventually, the fear of covert propaganda inflicts as much damage as the propaganda itself.

Once you internalize the possibility that you're being manipulated by some hidden hand, nothing can be trusted. Every dissenting voice on Twitter becomes a Russian bot, every uncomfortable headline a false flag, every political development part of an ever-deepening conspiracy. By the time the information ecosystem collapses under the weight of all this cynicism, you're too vigilant to notice that the disinformationists have won.

POWERS OF INCUMBENCY

If there's one thing that can be said for Brad Parscale, it's that he runs a tight ship. Unauthorized leaks from inside the campaign are rare; press stories on palace intrigue are virtually nonexistent. When the staff first moved into its new offices last year, journalists were periodically invited to tour the facility—but Parscale put an end to the practice: He didn't want them glimpsing a scrap of paper or a whiteboard scribble that they weren't supposed to see.

Notably, while the Trump White House has endured a seemingly endless procession of shake-ups, the Trump reelection campaign has seen very little turnover since Parscale took charge. His

staying power is one reason many Republicans—inside the organization or out—hesitate to talk about him on the record. But among allies of the president, there appears to be a growing skepticism.

Former colleagues began noticing a change in Parscale after his promotion. Suddenly, the quiet guy with his face buried in a laptop was wearing designer suits, tossing out MAGA hats at campaign rallies, and traveling to Europe to speak at a political-marketing conference. In the past few years, Parscale has bought a BMW, a Range Rover, a condo, and a \$2.4 million waterfront house in Fort Lauderdale, Florida. "He knows he has the confidence of the family," one former colleague told me, "which gives him more swagger." When the U.K.'s *Daily Mail* ran a story spotlighting Parscale's spending spree, he attempted deflection through flattery. "The president is an excellent businessman," he told the tabloid, "and being associated with him for years has been extremely beneficial to my family."

But according to a former White House official with knowledge of the incident, Trump was irritated by the coverage, and the impression it created that his campaign manager was getting rich off him. For a moment, Parscale's standing appeared to be in peril, but then Trump's attention was diverted by the G7 summit in France, and he never returned to the issue. (A spokesperson for the campaign disputed this account.)

Some Republicans worry that for all Parscale's digital expertise, he doesn't have the vision to guide Trump to reelection. The president is historically unpopular, and even in red states, he has struggled to mobilize his base for special elections. If Trump's message is growing stale with voters, is Parscale the man to help overhaul it? "People start to ask the question—you're building this apparatus, and that's great, but what's the overarching narrative?" said a former campaign staffer.

But whether Trump finds a new narrative or not, he has something this time around that he didn't have in 2016—the powers of the presidency. While every commander in chief looks for ways to leverage his incumbency for reelection, Trump has shown that he's willing to go much further than most. In the run-up to the 2018 midterm elections, he seized on reports of a migrant caravan traveling to the U.S. from Central America to claim that the southern border was facing a national-security crisis. Trump warned of a coming "invasion" and claimed, without evidence, that the caravan had been infiltrated by gang members.

Parscale aided this effort by creating a 30-second commercial that interspersed footage of Hispanic migrants with clips of a convicted cop-killer. The ad ended with an urgent call to action: STOP THE CARAVAN. VOTE REPUBLICAN. In a final maneuver before the election, Trump dispatched U.S. troops to the border. The president insisted that the operation was necessary to keep America safe—but within weeks the troops were quietly called back, the "crisis" having apparently ended once votes were cast. Skeptics were left to wonder: If Trump is willing to militarize the border to pick up a few extra seats in the midterms, what will he and his supporters do when his reelection is on the line?

It doesn't require an overactive imagination to envision a worst-case scenario: On Election Day, anonymous text messages direct voters to the wrong polling locations, or maybe even circulate rumors of security threats. Deepfakes of the Democratic nominee

using racial slurs crop up faster than social-media platforms can remove them. As news outlets scramble to correct the inaccuracies, hordes of Twitter bots respond by smearing and threatening reporters. Meanwhile, the Trump campaign has spent the final days of the race pumping out Facebook ads at such a high rate that no one can keep track of what they're injecting into the bloodstream.

After the first round of exit polls is released, a mysteriously sourced video surfaces purporting to show undocumented immigrants at the ballot box. Trump begins retweeting rumors of voter fraud and suggests that Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers should be dispatched to polling stations. ARE ILLEGALS STEALING THE ELECTION? reads the Fox News chyron. ARE RUSSIANS BEHIND FALSE VIDEOS? demands MSNBC.

The votes haven't even been counted yet, and much of the country is ready to throw out the result.

NOTHING IS TRUE

There is perhaps no better place to witness what the culture of disinformation has already wrought in America than a Trump campaign rally. One night in November, I navigated through a parking-lot maze of folding tables covered in MAGA merch and entered the BancorpSouth Arena in Tupelo, Mississippi. The election was still a year away, but thousands of sign-waving supporters had crowded into the venue to cheer on the president in person.

Once Trump took the stage, he let loose a familiar flurry of lies, half-lies, hyperbole, and nonsense. He spun his revisionist history of the Ukraine scandal—the one in which Joe Biden is the villain—and claimed, falsely, that the Georgia Democrat Stacey Abrams wanted to “give illegal aliens the right to vote.” At one point, during a riff on abortion, Trump casually asserted that “the governor of Virginia executed a baby”—prompting a woman in the crowd to scream, “Murderer!”

This incendiary fabrication didn't seem to register with my companions in the press pen, who were busy writing stories and shooting B-roll. I opened Twitter, expecting to see a torrent of fact-checks laying out the truth of the case—that the governor had been answering a hypothetical question about late-term abortion; that a national firestorm had ensued; that there were certainly different ways to interpret his comments but that not even the most ardent anti-abortion activist thought the governor of Virginia had personally “executed a baby.”

But Twitter was uncharacteristically quiet (apparently the president had said this before), and the most widely shared tweet I found on the subject was from his own campaign, which had

blasted out a context-free clip of the governor's abortion comments to back up Trump's smear.

After the rally, I loitered near one of the exits, chatting with people as they filed out of the arena. Among liberals, there is a comforting caricature of Trump supporters as gullible personality cultists who have been hypnotized into believing whatever their leader says. The appeal of this theory is the implication that the spell can be broken, that truth can still triumph over lies, that someday everything could go back to normal—if only these vot-

ers were exposed to the facts. But the people I spoke with in Tupelo seemed to treat matters of fact as beside the point.

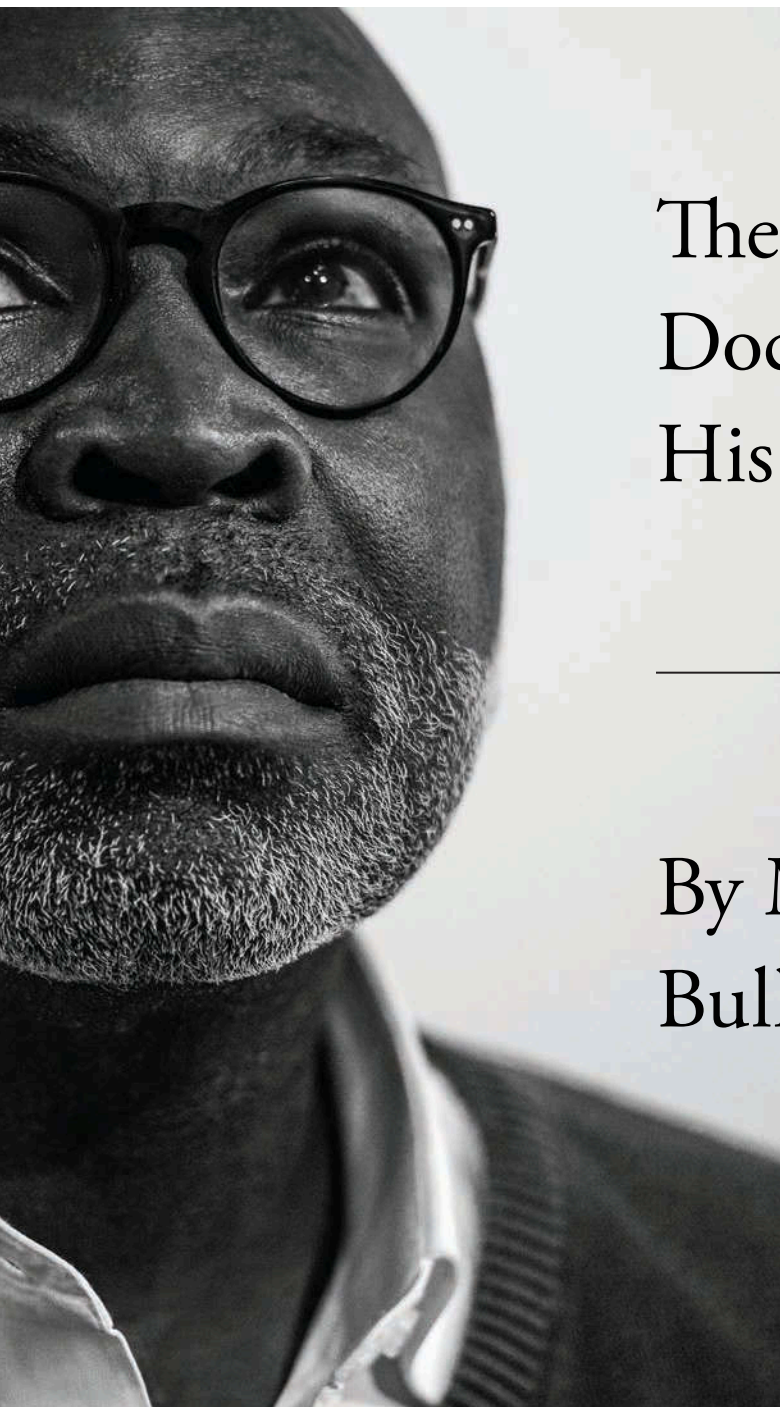
One woman told me that, given the president's accomplishments, she didn't care if he “fabricates a little bit.” A man responded to my questions about Trump's dishonest attacks on the press with a shrug and a suggestion that the media “ought to try telling the truth once in a while.” Tony Willnow, a 34-year-old maintenance worker who had an American flag wrapped around his head, observed that Trump had won because he said things no other politician would say. When I asked him if it mattered whether those things were true, he thought for a moment before answering. “He tells you what you want to hear,” Willnow said. “And I don't know if it's true or not—but it sounds good, so fuck it.”

The political theorist Hannah Arendt once wrote that the most successful totalitarian leaders of the 20th century

instilled in their followers “a mixture of gullibility and cynicism.” When they were lied to, they chose to believe it. When a lie was debunked, they claimed they'd known all along—and would then “admire the leaders for their superior tactical cleverness.” Over time, Arendt wrote, the onslaught of propaganda conditioned people to “believe everything and nothing, think that everything was possible and that nothing was true.”

Leaving the rally, I thought about Arendt, and the swaths of the country that are already gripped by the ethos she described. Should it prevail in 2020, the election's legacy will be clear—not a choice between parties or candidates or policy platforms, but a referendum on reality itself. *A*

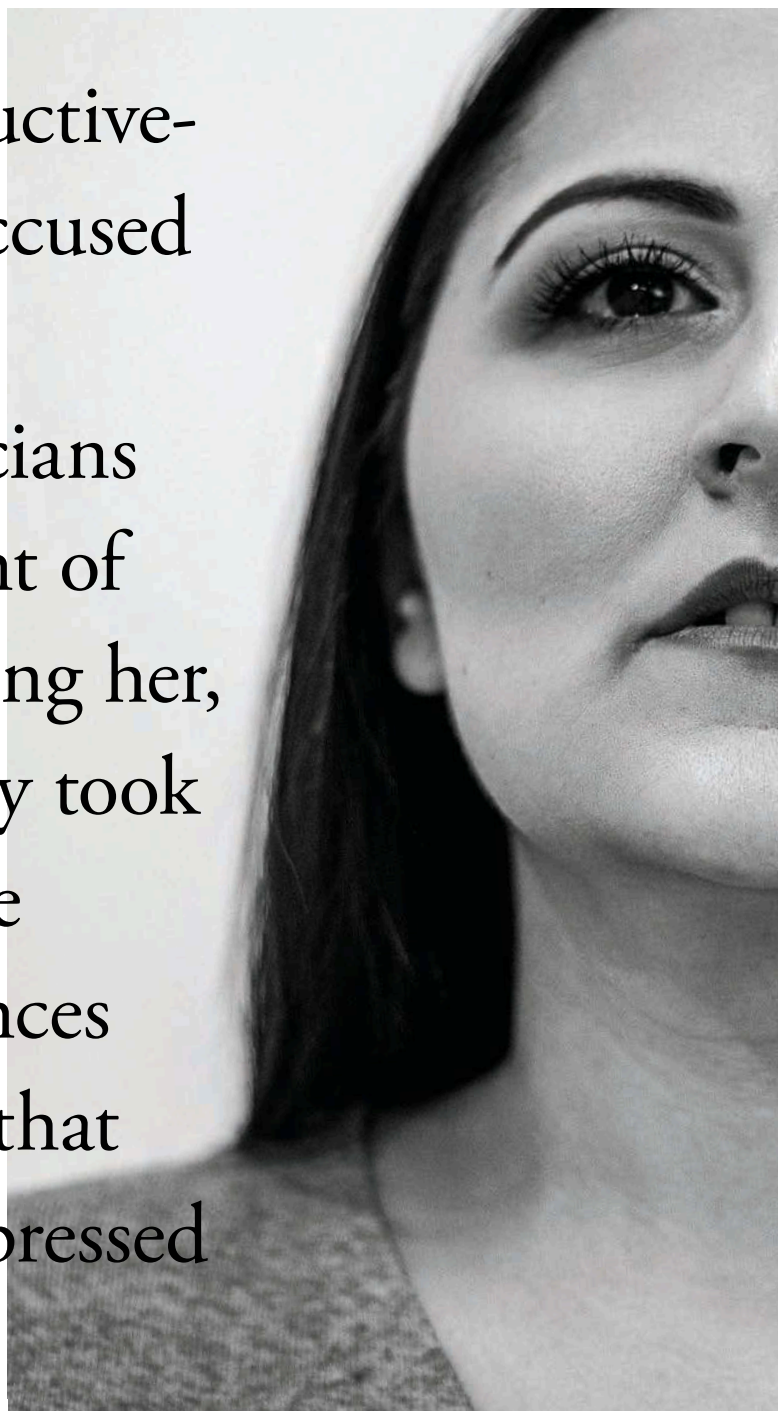
McKay Coppins is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



The Abortion Doctor and His Accuser

By Maggie
Bullock

When a reproductive-rights activist accused one of the most respected physicians in the movement of sexually assaulting her, everyone quickly took sides. The divide exposed differences among women that are typically expressed only in private.





On a 92-degree morning in September, three clinic escorts gathered in the meager shade of a tree outside the Alabama Women's Center for Reproductive Alternatives. They arrive here at 8:30 a.m. on the dot, regular as clock-punchers, on the three days a week the Huntsville clinic is open to perform abortions. The women and girls arrive dressed for comfort in sweatpants and shower slides, carrying pillows from home or holding the hand of a partner or friend. The escorts, meanwhile, wear brightly colored vests and wield giant umbrellas to block the incoming patients from the sight, if not the sound, of the other group that comes here like clockwork: the protesters.

Sometimes there are as many as a dozen. This day there were four: one woman, three men, all white. Four doesn't sound like that many until you're downwind of them maniacally hollering: *Mommy, don't kill me! You're lynching your black baby! They rip their arms and legs off! They suffer! They torture them!*

But escorts are made of stern stuff. Josie, with her short snow-white ponytail and T-shirt spangled with buttons (FEARLESS FLAWLESS FEMINIST, ABORTION IS NORMAL), doesn't get paid to defend, as she puts it, "these patients, these doctors, this staff." Nevertheless, that's her job. Among those Josie has sworn to protect is Willie Parker, an ob-gyn who has worked here for the past several years and who, until recently, was a hero of the reproductive-rights movement.

Last fall, while trying to defend Parker—not in this parking lot, but in the no-less-divisive wilds of Facebook message boards—Josie got dragged into a dispute that has shaken the reproductive-rights movement, from its uppermost reaches to its grassroots volunteers. One of Josie's fellow escorts was called "trash" after she spoke up for Parker; others were told they didn't deserve to be escorts. The people hurling the insults were not pro-lifers but fellow abortion-rights foot soldiers: How dare Josie—how dare anyone—not believe Candice?

On March 25, 2019, the activist Candice Russell posted a 3,300-word essay on the website Medium titled "To All the Women Whose Names I Don't Know, About the Pain We Share, the Secrets

We Keep, and the Silence That Shouldn't Have Been Asked For.” In prose that was by turns confusing and moving, Russell wrote that after a year and a half of casual texting and a handful of face-to-face meetups, she and Parker had met for dinner in Dallas in October 2016. She got drunk, while he, she discovered partway through the evening, stuck to tonic water and lime. Then they went back to his hotel room, where she continued to drink, and they had sex.

Russell did not write that she'd told Parker she didn't want to sleep with him, but she strongly implied that, having downed “four martinis and an entire bottle of wine,” she was inebriated beyond any practical ability to consent. And, in a sweeping accusation that extended far beyond what had happened between the two of them in that hotel room, she called him a “predator.” She'd gradually learned, she wrote, that the way he'd treated her was part of a pattern. Rumors about his behavior swirled in “whispers [that] had become so loud they were more like shouts”—and unnamed movement leaders were refusing to expose him.

Russell did not report Parker to the police, and unlike, say, the cases of Matt Lauer at NBC or even Al Franken in the Senate, a workplace investigation was never on the table: The activist and the doctor operated in the same sphere, but they weren't colleagues. Instead, the case of Russell versus Parker has been battled out largely on message boards and in closed-door conversations within the insular, impassioned realm of abortion rights, among people, mostly women, for whom the cause of bodily autonomy was a calling long before the dawn of the #MeToo movement. Yet its tentacles stretch much further, bringing into the open generational and, to an extent, racial divisions in our rapidly shifting views on sexual assault—the kinds of questions and doubts that are typically expressed only in private. How does alcohol figure into culpability? What constitutes appropriate sexual behavior when one person has more power than the other? And perhaps most crucial, how absolute is the duty to believe women—the rallying cry of #MeToo?

That the saga of Candice Russell and Willie Parker is set in the abortion-rights world heightens the stakes, and not just for the two of them. Sooner rather than later, one of the recent spate of state laws prohibiting abortion after six weeks' gestation may have its intended consequence: provoking a ruling by the right-leaning Supreme Court that could further erode, if not eliminate, the rights enshrined in *Roe v. Wade*. Within the reproductive-justice movement, talk of a post-*Roe* America is not an *if* but a *when*—planning is well under way for how to help women in red states get abortions when the procedure is no longer federally protected. Indeed, with only one abortion clinic per state in six states, you could argue that many Americans are already living in a post-*Roe* reality. All of which makes Russell's allegation against Parker a potential chink in the armor of the movement itself—one that could, as an activist put it, “reify the narrative that ‘abortionists abuse women’ simply by providing abortions.”

This isn't just a theory. Three days after Russell's essay was published, Life Dynamics, a Texas group known for sending “spies for life” into abortion clinics to try to dig up information that might be used to close them down, revealed the allegations against Parker, claiming on Twitter that it had proof that “thousands of

One anti-abortion group reveled in the allegations against Parker: “Thousands of women have been sexually assaulted or raped by abortionists.”

women have been sexually assaulted or raped by abortionists. Some of the abortionists that we documented are still working!”

More recently, Gloria Gray, the owner of a Tuscaloosa, Alabama, clinic where Parker worked last fall, told me that one of her regular protesters had begun making the baseless charge that she was employing a “sexual molester” who'd “fondled patients.”

WILLIE PARKER AND CANDICE RUSSELL met in 2015, at the Hartford, Connecticut, airport, after attending the annual Civil Liberties and Public Policy conference. The bald-headed, then-52-year-old Parker, who wears round, black-framed glasses and a silver hoop in one ear, had been a featured speaker. The Latina Russell was, at age 32, a “scholarship kid,” as she jokingly puts it—a freelance writer and fledgling activist allowed to attend for free. As she recalls, she sat down at the gate, plunked down her bag, and accidentally bumped Parker. As the two chatted, other conference attendees kept interrupting to take selfies with him.

It would be hard to overstate Parker's prominence within the reproductive-rights movement at the time. He was its most visible male figurehead—indeed, its only one. A black, devoutly Christian ob-gyn born and raised in Birmingham, Alabama, Parker spent the first half of his career refusing to perform abortions. Then, in 2003, at the age of 41, he had what he has described as a “come-to-Jesus moment.” He radically reversed course, becoming not just an abortion provider but, you might say, *the* abortion provider: a traveling doctor who—eschewing the bullet-proof vest favored by some in his high-risk profession—zigzags across the Deep South tending to patients, most of whom are poor women of color, at clinics in Alabama and Mississippi.

That was only part of it. Parker posted himself up at the movement's front line with the same zeal with which he had once handed out religious pamphlets as a born-again teenage preacher. At one event after another, he cast abortion as a moral imperative that ensures a woman's human right to lead the life she wants to live. This message refashioned the most controversial medical procedure of our time as the Christian thing to do—and gave the abortion-rights community a language

it sorely needed. The abortion storytellers' organization Shout Your Abortion sold T-shirts bearing Parker's face. The novelist Jodi Picoult modeled a character on him. In 2017, Parker would publish his own book, a memoir called *Life's Work: A Moral Argument for Choice*.

One reason Parker was so beloved is that he never acted superior. Exalted as he became, he never lost his easy affability or his appetite for conversation; even in the procedure room, he's known for keeping up a steady stream of comforting small talk. That day in Hartford, he offered to save Russell a seat on the plane—he was in boarding group A; she was in C—which was not unusual. It was Parker being Parker. But to Russell it was a big deal. On the plane, she shared a story she'd written for *HuffPost*; he compared it to the work of James Baldwin. (She had to Google the name in the airplane bathroom.) Parker told her he was working on his memoir—maybe he could send her some chapters to read? When we met in a Tuscaloosa hotel's conference room in September, about six months after she posted her essay, Russell relived the thrill of the request: Here was “the Gloria Steinem of the movement, and he wants to be writing partners?” she recalled thinking. “This is awesome.”

Russell's own come-to-Jesus moment—though she'd never describe it as such—had occurred a couple of years earlier, after she finished a bartending shift at a place she calls “Ye Olde Irish Hooters.” When she got into her car and turned on the radio, the news was all about the Texas legislation later known as H.B. 2, which proposed banning abortion after 20 weeks, among other restrictions. This was 2013. State Senator Wendy Davis was soon to become famous for filibustering the bill in her hot-pink Mizunos. Sitting in her car listening, Russell thought, “They're talking about abortion like it's this horrible thing. They don't know what they're talking about.”

She drove straight to Austin, 200 miles south, changed into a dress that was in her trunk, and marched into the capitol rotunda, where she waited in line for hours to testify about her abortion before the state Senate. Russell had gotten pregnant after dating her then-boyfriend for only a month and a half and, at 21, had had an abortion without regret—she views the procedure as the key to her future, and her personal freedom. Making her story more powerful, Russell is what anti-abortion activists call an “abortion survivor.” When her mother was 14 and about to have what would have been her third abortion, she decided at the last minute to keep her baby, Candice. Russell's narrative flipped the pro-life assumption that no one who'd almost been aborted would ever terminate her own pregnancy.

Eventually, telling this story—and that of her second abortion, which she had at age 30—became a sort of job for Russell. As a member of the advocacy group We Testify (an arm of the National Network of Abortion Funds), she shared her account with reporters at *The New York Times*, *The Guardian*, and CNN.

But in 2015, when she met Parker, Russell was still looking for a way into the movement, volunteering at local Texas organizations without gaining much traction, she told me. Curled up in an armchair, Russell looked dramatically different from the bright-eyed, sprightly woman in Facebook photos taken back

then. She seemed deeply fatigued, with dark circles under her eyes, and she was noticeably heavier: Russell had had gastric-bypass surgery in 2009, shedding almost 180 pounds to become, at 5 foot 2, a petit size 4. But since the night with Parker, she said, she'd gained some 80 pounds, which she attributed mostly to alcohol. Still, a certain dorm-room girlishness remained, with her chipped black nail polish and black floral dress; flashes of wit and charisma made it easy to imagine the funny, “boisterous” woman Parker says he was initially charmed by.

After that flight together, Russell said, Parker became a “very close and personal friend,” thanks to a bond based on shared childhood trauma. As he wrote in his memoir, Parker and his five siblings grew up on food stamps. Their mother was twice hospitalized after psychotic breaks and eventually was diagnosed with manic depression.

Russell's own mother was a stripper and sometime sex worker, and was addicted to meth and heroin, she says. By the time Russell was a preteen, she had been abandoned to live with her stepfather and two half-siblings. But during a brief reappearance, her mother sold her 12-year-old daughter for sex—one of multiple incidences of sexual abuse in her childhood, Russell says.

Russell herself struggles with mental illness, she told me, and in the months leading up to her October 2016 get-together with Parker, she'd been diagnosed with severe PTSD due to childhood trauma. She'd been looking forward to confiding in Parker about this at dinner that night, in fact. On the handful of occasions when they'd met in person, the two had had hours-long conversations, she said, in which she told him “things I hadn't even told my [ex-]husband.”

LISTENING TO PARKER describe his relationship with Russell is like listening to a record played backwards: A completely different sound comes out. At 5 foot 11, Parker is barrel-chested and physically imposing, a presence that is offset by his signature collection of professorial bow ties and ascots. But the day we met, at a Manhattan sidewalk café, the city was sweltering, and he wore a crisp button-down, no tie. As he talked, in long blocks of uninterrupted speech, he frequently removed his glasses to mop his brow.

What Parker said he knew about Russell, you could learn at a cocktail party: She was from Seattle, had been married, had a stepson she was still in contact with. Their conversations, he said, covered music, the Seattle Seahawks, their activism, Russell's various jobs—over time, she was appointed to the board of NARAL Pro-Choice Texas and hired as an executive assistant by the National Network of Abortion Funds. She “absolutely” never opened up to him about her childhood trauma or mental-health problems, he said. If she *had* talked about her mother, he likely would have shared about his own, he added, “but we didn't have that kind of fluency.” Their interactions were “too inconsistent for me to become a close confidant to her,” and he said he never asked her to read his book-in-progress.

Parker got married for the first time in August 2018, seven months before Russell posted her story, to a 54-year-old flight attendant with whom he now lives in Charlotte, North Carolina.

But until then he'd been an object in motion, always on the road for his advocacy or abortion work, finding connection where he could—people he'd grab a bite with when he happened to land in their town. In his mind, the only thing that differentiated Russell from those friends is the fact that on one occasion they'd had sex.

Both Parker's and Russell's recollections of the night of October 8, 2016, are fragmented—hers, she says, because of alcohol; his, he says, because of the erasure of time. They agree on this: They had dinner at a Cajun restaurant in Dallas, where he'd come for a conference, before heading to a rooftop bar called Happiest Hour. Around midnight, they returned to his hotel and had sex.

Parker's version of the story hinges on a moment—maybe at the bar, he's not certain—when Russell looked at him and said something along the lines of “There's this undeniable chemistry between us. It's mutual. What are we going to do about it?” This surprised him, he said. He'd found Russell attractive, but they hadn't seemed destined for anything more than friendship. Still, to him, this was the moment not just of consent but of initiation: She made the first move.

In Tuscaloosa, when I repeated this part of Parker's story to Russell, she practically doubled over in pain. “That's not how I talk,” she said, spitting out the words. And even if she had come on to him—which she doesn't remember doing—she said she was drunk enough that any indication of consent was irrelevant. “I don't care if I said ‘Let's go fuck in the bathroom.’”

In some ways, Russell's and Parker's conflicting views of the night all boil down to this. Russell said Parker could not have missed that she was plastered: She drank a few martinis at dinner, at least one more at the bar, and a whole bottle of wine in his hotel room, and she describes herself as “clumsy” when she drinks. “I sway a lot, fall a lot. I slur. If I'm brownout drunk—so drunk, I'm not remembering—I'm sloppy at that point.”

But Parker, a lifetime teetotaler, said that he didn't count Russell's drinks, never saw a bottle of wine in his room, and didn't witness Russell act as she describes. Removing his glasses to rub his eyes, he recalled her condition using a physician's parlance: “There were no slurs, no incoherent thoughts, no motor-function impairment.”

Below and opposite page: Protesters outside the Supreme Court on the eve of the *Whole Woman's Health v. Hellerstedt* oral arguments, in March 2016. The case challenged a Texas law that regulated abortion-providing facilities.



Until the Medium post, Russell hadn't given him an inkling that she thought their night together was anything other than consensual, he said, and the two continued to text periodically. At some point, Russell must have “decided to feel some other kind of way about” sex she'd agreed to and so reframed it as an “exploitative, predatory thing”—the kind of thing “nobody would question.”

With at least part of this analysis, Russell would concur: She did change her mind. For a long time, she described the encounter to herself and others as “problematic.” But the more she thought about it, the more that idea began to break apart and reassemble into a different shape. If another woman had told Russell that she'd gotten “brownout” drunk and had sex, she says, “would I be calling it ‘problematic’? No, I would call it rape.”

THE DAY AFTER Russell's March 25 letter, Parker took to Medium to post a point-by-point rebuttal of her allegations, but that did not keep him from being swiftly disappeared from the movement. On the 26th, he stepped down, under duress, from his position as chair of the board of Physicians for Reproductive Health. He says he was disinvited from four upcoming academic talks and lost his seat on the boards of the Religious Coalition for Reproductive Choice and the Abortion Access Front (formerly Lady Parts Justice League), an organization led by the comedian and activist Lizz Winstead, who until then had been one of his closest allies. The National Network of Abortion Funds declared solidarity with accusers, and said it already had been in the process of dropping Parker's name from one of its two national funds. NARAL Pro-Choice America President Ilyse Hogue, perhaps the most powerful abortion-rights leader in the country after Cecile Richards resigned in 2018 from the top post at Planned Parenthood, tweeted: “We #believesurvivors and we believe Candice Russell. Sexual assault does occur in movement spaces, and we should have no tolerance for it.”

The fierce constituency that rose up around Russell demanded no proof. None was necessary. She was one of their own, clearly the David to Parker's Goliath, the older, richer, more powerful male—the movement “rock star” 20 years her senior. To these ardent, instant supporters, the thinking was: Why would anyone do what she did—reveal a humiliating experience, including her own hard drinking, and risk being ostracized by the abortion-rights community for tarring its MVP—unless it was true? What could she possibly have to gain by lying about such a thing?

“That is literally an option of last resort,” says Amanda Reyes, the founder and executive director of Alabama's Yellowhammer Fund, a reproductive-justice organization that helps pay for abortions in that state. After reading Russell's Medium post, Reyes wrote to Russell—whom she'd never met—to say *I believe you*. In recent years, Reyes told me, groups such as Planned Parenthood and NARAL have leaned hard on hashtags like #trustwomen, meaning that we should trust women to make their own decisions about whether to terminate a pregnancy. “If I do not extend that [same trust] to survivors,” Reyes said, “then who am I?”

As it happens, Reyes's belief led to one of the more unlikely plot twists in this story. In June, Reyes offered Russell a job as the deputy director of Yellowhammer, which practically overnight had

gone from a shoestring operation to a force to be reckoned with. After Alabama passed the country's most restrictive abortion ban in May, the group's bank balance leaped from \$5,000 to more than \$2 million in just two months, enriched by the online activism of celebrities like Rihanna and Reese Witherspoon.

For Russell, the job meant moving to Tuscaloosa to work for an organization whose primary mission is funding abortions in Alabama—including those Parker performs. But she was undeterred: This was a chance to do important work at a level she'd only dreamed of. And her supporters had her back; all summer, the fire Russell had lit continued to rage online, and with increasing vitriol. Why was Parker, "a serial rapist," even allowed to perform abortions anymore? one activist asked on a Facebook page called #IbelieveCandice. "I wouldn't feel safe under his care."

For all his eloquence on the subject of a woman's right to choose, Parker is not deft at expressing the emotional impact of his exile, or of such invective. He uses phrases like *profound disappointment* and *moments of pain*. But he once offered, piercingly, that the way Russell had written on Medium of his hands all over her had made him sound "animalistic," like the stereotypical sexualized black man.

While Parker says he prefers not to dwell on the racial dimensions of this story—a black man accused of a crime and condemned with no recourse—one of his close friends, the social-justice advocate Wyndi Anderson, believes that on some level he had been steeling himself against this possibility. "If you grew up in the South, this is what we think black men do—rape women," says Anderson, who is white and was raised in South Carolina. "As a black man who has been putting his hands on and in white women and [other] women, he has been waiting for this fucking thing, this charge, since the day he started doing this work."

The few who did publicly take issue with Russell's denunciation of Parker were lambasted for victim-blaming, or written off as "rape apologists." The documentary-film maker Dawn Porter, who spent three years in Parker's orbit while shooting her 2016 film, *Trapped*, about the diminishing number of abortion clinics in the Deep South, uncorked her outrage on Twitter: "What did i miss? You



drank 4 martinis and a bottle of wine on your own. Did he force you to do that? You slept with him and you regret it? That makes him a PREDATOR?" Mallory McMaster, one of Russell's fellow abortion storytellers, fired back: "Dawn, your next documentary should follow your abrupt departure from the movement after showing us all that you don't share our values."

The notion that a woman who drinks too much is at all responsible for unwanted sex has become verboten in recent years—understandably, because it risks reopening an old window, allowing back in the creeping suspicion that women are in some way to blame when they're assaulted. But in reality, things get messy. In her Medium post, Russell herself wrote, "If I had done the right thing, left at the appropriate time, stopped after two drinks like I should have, none of this would have ever happened." By the time we met six months later she was free of any ambiguity. The fact that Parker was sober figured prominently in her thinking. If they'd both been drunk, the sex would have been "not great, but not predatory," in Russell's estimation. But because he'd had his wits about him and she hadn't, she said to me, as if addressing Parker directly, "That's your bad. You're a feminist leader and a physician, and you are choosing to count that as consent. That is your mistake. *That* makes you a predator."

The law draws no such distinction. These days, we all know that a person cannot consent to sex when incapacitated by drugs or alcohol, but what constitutes incapacitated, exactly? In most states, including Texas, an accuser who drinks of her own volition (versus, say, being roofied) must be fully unconscious—literally unable to resist—to qualify as such. So legally, it doesn't matter how wasted Russell was—as long as she wasn't passed-out. Cynthia Godsoe, a professor at Brooklyn Law School who specializes in gender and sexuality, says the standards in this area are beginning to shift: Under Title IX rules, which govern how colleges address sexual assault on campus, people who are visibly drunk are sometimes considered past the point of consent. And coincidentally, a bill is now pending in the Texas statehouse to expand the definition of sexual assault to include cases of what Godsoe calls "serious drunkenness," or, in the language of the legislation, cases in which "the actor knows the other person is intoxicated" to the point that he or she can't "appraise the nature of the act."

Russell's drinking, her spotty memory, and her troubled past make her exactly the kind of woman whose account of sexual assault was for generations dismissed without a backwards glance.

Of course, defining that level of intoxication isn't necessarily straightforward, nor is proving that one person knew how drunk *another* person was. "Some people act sloppy; some don't," Godsoe says. "Someone could drink four martinis and be okay; someone else would not." The limits of the justice system are one reason the writer Tanya Selvaratnam—who told *The New Yorker* in 2018 about being domestically abused by then-New York Attorney General Eric Schneiderman—last April wrote an op-ed for *Glamour* backing Russell. For many victims of sexual assault and harassment, Selvaratnam contended, "the court of public opinion" is the best or only option available. (Schneiderman was never criminally charged.)

Post-#MeToo, many people have become comfortable trusting narratives that wouldn't have been credited before. Christine Blasey Ford recalled her alleged assault by Brett Kavanaugh with great specificity and also with occasional imprecision, more than 30 years after the fact—and polls showed that 45 percent of Americans believed her (versus 33 percent who believed Kavanaugh). Andrea Constand recalled an assault during which she had been only half-conscious, thanks to three little blue pills she'd been given by Bill Cosby—and the comedian was convicted of aggravated indecent assault. Russell's drinking, her spotty memory, and her troubled past make her exactly the kind of woman whose account of sexual harassment or assault was for generations disregarded, dismissed without a backwards glance. What is #believewomen, after all, if you don't believe *this* woman?

The mounting force of this duty to believe was apparent the week after Russell posted her essay, when two elder stateswomen of the reproductive-justice movement called for due process—and were roundly ignored. In an op-ed, Toni Bond Leonard and Loretta Ross exhorted the abortion-rights community not to rush to judgment, lest they violate Parker's human rights. "What is painfully evident," they wrote, "is that our lack of process is fracturing the movement, often along racial and generational lines, through a dangerous collision of #MeToo with reproductive justice." Six months later, not one activist I spoke with had been swayed by this sentiment: The generational divide Leonard and Ross had identified was real, they all told me, and the elders were on the wrong side of it.

Ross helped coin the phrase *reproductive justice*, which emphasizes the needs of marginalized communities (the poor, people of color) and has replaced *pro-choice* as the dominant framework for abortion-rights activism. From 1979 to 1982, she was the director of the first rape crisis center in the country, in Washington, D.C. "I'm pre-#MeToo," she told me last fall. No one who's seen what she has wants to undermine the credibility of survivors, Ross continued, but by the same token, "no reasonable veteran of the anti-rape movement is going to agree that every so-called survivor is absolutely telling the truth. That's just not true."

At this time in history, in the circles in which Ross operates, that is an extremely controversial statement, but she didn't hedge. "A lot of people tell stories through the lens of their trauma that are as real as can be to them. That doesn't make it the objective truth. While you want to hold that story for that person, you have to be very, very careful what you do with it. Because you have to have other evidence—something to back it up, other than their feelings."

RUSSELL MIGHT NEVER have gone public, based on her own telling, were it not for the stories she says she heard about Parker hitting on other drunk or vulnerable women—the "whispers [that] had become so loud they were more like shouts." Indeed, her essay reads as an invitation to those who suffered similar harm to join her in publicly naming Parker. That hasn't happened: No one else has come forward to say she has been sexually assaulted by the doctor.

One woman accused Parker of sexually *harassing* her: Yamani Hernandez, the executive director of the National Network of Abortion Funds, who happens to be Russell's former boss. In a series of tweets in August, Hernandez said that during a 2015 photo op, Parker leaned in and whispered in her ear that "he would tell his boys back home I was one of his new honeys." Later, when those pictures were posted on the group's Facebook page, and someone joked that they looked like wedding shots, he commented on the photo that he would "draw [Hernandez] a bath with oil and flowers and rub [her] feet." When Hernandez then texted him to ask if he wanted to say something to her privately, Parker replied (in communications he shared with me), "All just jokes, if I was interested in you, you'd have known by now"—a comment intended, she thought, to "knock me down a peg." (Parker wrote Hernandez in August to say that while he didn't remember their exchanges the same way she did, he was sorry for "ever" offending her. She thanked him for the "important step toward repair," adding that she hoped he would "seek education.")

Russell knew about Parker's sexually tinged comments to Hernandez, and she says they're one of the "whispers" that persuaded her to write her essay. As for the other stories that influenced Russell, I followed up on each, and, among those I could trace, her version had marked differences from the one offered by others.

The moment Russell said she was sure she "wasn't alone" came one evening when she was confiding in a female colleague about Parker. The woman stopped her. "She said she could finish my story, because it had happened to her best friend," Russell told me. Specifically, an activist younger than Parker had gotten drunk past the point of consent and had sex with him. When I spoke with this colleague, however, she said that while she believes Russell is telling the truth about her own experience, she'd told Russell only that she'd heard other "shady" things about Parker—and she'd been alluding only to inappropriate remarks he'd made to a friend.

Russell collected another piece of damning information, she said, at a 2017 conference called Let's Talk About Sex, held a year or so after her encounter with Parker. There, another higher-up in the movement (who declined to be interviewed) said to her, "Oh, you must be one of Willie's girls." To Russell, this suggested that reproductive-rights power players knew that Parker took advantage of young women and weren't doing anything about it. *How many other victims are out there?* she thought.

Cherisse Scott, the founder and CEO of a Memphis reproductive-justice organization called SisterReach, told me she made a "Willie's girls"-like comment in front of Russell at that conference, but her intention was close to the opposite of Russell's interpretation. Watching Parker and Russell sitting together at a table near the hotel bar—the pair's only in-person meeting after their encounter—Scott got the impression that Russell was





Left: Parker outside the Supreme Court in March 2016. Right: Russell speaking at a reproductive-justice event at the Texas capitol building in 2015.

irritated when other women tried to join them. (Russell, meanwhile, said she was just trying to be “cordial” with Parker because she “didn’t want to make a scene” in public.) At the time, Scott, who is African American, thought Russell was white, which to her put the *physician* at risk. In a country where black men have “historically been fetishized by white women,” she wrote in an email to me, “he could easily become ‘Native Son.’” Scott determined to intervene, with a light touch. “Dr. Parker,” she recalled exclaiming as she approached their table, “you are always holding court. The girls know they love them some Willie Parker!” After Russell left the table, Scott warned Parker to be careful—which at the time he considered unnecessary, he told me, because he was confident in his ability to handle himself with women.

Russell said she was finally moved to divulge her story by at least two people who mentioned that they’d seen, or heard tales of, Parker “sidling up” to unidentified young women at conferences. She wouldn’t disclose the name of one of those people, however, because the story was told to her in confidence. The second person, a board member of a reproductive-rights group, told me that while he believes and supports Russell, he didn’t remember telling her this—he wouldn’t have firsthand knowledge of such behavior anyway, he said, because he was never around Parker.

In Tuscaloosa, Russell showed me a video clip that someone had forwarded to her before she wrote her letter. It showed Parker dancing at a conference, “humping somebody to some stupid ‘90s slow jam,” as she described it—proof that he’d become “brazen, emboldened,” and had to be stopped. The video is 15 seconds long, and shot from a distance. In pink light, on a small platform in the middle of a dance floor, Parker is dancing surrounded by five women, maybe more; it’s hard to tell. He’s the outlier, older than the rest and, well, male. With his shirtsleeves rolled up and his bow tie undone, he looks exactly the way one activist described him to me: “like your fun uncle,” right before last call at a wedding.

At the eight-second mark, Russell jabbed a finger at the screen. “Do you see that?” Revulsion was thick in her voice. “His hand, it’s on her hip. He’s practically grinding on her.”

We replayed it, twice. I strained. I squinted. Did Parker’s hand graze the woman’s hip? Maybe. Though to me, it looked like he

was worried she was about to fall off the platform and was reaching out to catch her. I began to get the surreal sense that Russell and I were watching two different videos: Mine was benign; hers was evidence of predatory behavior.

Beyond trying to track down the leads Russell gave me, I contacted numerous members of the reproductive-rights field to ask: Was Parker’s bad behavior an open secret in their world? The overwhelming majority of people I spoke with, many of them Russell’s own allies, said they had never heard anything untoward about Parker before her Medium piece. There were two exceptions. Laurie Bertram Roberts, a co-founder of the Mississippi Reproductive Freedom Fund, told me that a year before Russell posted her story, another woman had disclosed that she’d had sex with Parker when she was too drunk to consent and considered it rape. Parker denied this, and Bertram Roberts would not ask the woman to speak with me; doing so, she argued, would only retraumatize her. In addition, Bertram Roberts said four women have told her Parker made comments that made them feel “uncomfortable,” along the lines of what he said to Hernandez; Bertram Roberts would not share their names or any specifics.

Separately, a former journalist who covers reproductive rights (and asked not to be identified because he didn’t think it was his place as a “cisgender man” to get too involved) said that before Russell’s Medium post, two female activists had mentioned to him that Parker “had a reputation” for taking advantage of young women at conferences. Both of his sources declined to be contacted, so it’s impossible to know whether they were talking about what happened with the two women already on the record—Russell and Hernandez—or other women. (Parker said that none of this is true.)

Before Russell’s story went live, Bertram Roberts said a rumor was widely circulating that an abortion provider had sexually assaulted someone in the movement. Later, she realized the gossip was about Russell. So again, were there many women with stories to tell about Willie Parker? Or were the stories of Russell and Hernandez gaining momentum as they reverberated in the tight-knit community?

Even if that’s the case, Bertram Roberts told me that she doesn’t think Parker should be let off the hook. Take Russell’s

rape allegation out of the equation—what’s a man like Parker doing in bed with a woman like Russell in the first place? she asked. A 41-year-old queer woman, Bertram Roberts is also something of a rock star in the movement; she knows what it’s like when these “18-, 19-, 20-, 21-year-olds” run up and ask to take a selfie. “They’ll be all doe-eyed,” she said. “*Can I just sit and talk to you? Can I come hang out in your room?*” Her answer, invariably, is “Hell no.” Refusing to bask in that kind of abject admiration, she says, “is an ethical choice.”

Parker considers this a false equivalency. When he and Russell met, she wasn’t 19; she was 32. “I’m still questioning what authority I had over Candice, even if she says ‘I looked up to you as a hero,’” Parker told me, shaking his head stubbornly. Such reasoning, he contended, strips women of sexual agency. Any woman who admires his work—or for that matter, any woman who admires a man who is richer, more successful, better-looking—“is unable to give consent?” If it’s a question of age, “how old would Candice have to be to assert herself toward me, and for me to be able to say yes without being regarded as [having] preyed upon her?”

TWO WEEKS AFTER I got home from Alabama, I learned that friends of Russell’s had become worried about her mental health. Increasingly anxious to provide proof for this story, and claiming that it was a hit piece on her, she had begun to lean on people to back up her narrative, including one woman who told me Russell had asked her to say that she’d overheard conversations she had not. (After two days of interviews in Alabama, Russell did not answer any further questions from me or the magazine.)

What happened in the hotel room with Parker, we’ll never truly know. But in the course of reporting this story, I couldn’t help but think that Russell may have confabulated or exaggerated her version of the ensuing drama. The generous view is that, at an exceedingly vulnerable time, Russell heard what she needed to hear, mistaking, for instance, a comment about “shady” behavior as a sign of corroboration. The less generous view is that, out of either a growing sense of desperation or malevolence, she made up parts of the story.

Coming forward has clearly been painful and destabilizing for Russell, as it has been for many women who have alleged sexual harassment or assault.

When pieces of a story are not true, what does that mean for the whole? I’ve wondered what would have happened if, from the beginning, Russell had simply stuck to her own account of her experience with Parker and left out the rumors about other women. Whatever you believe about the truth of it, it’s at least, in the vernacular of #MeToo, “her story to tell.” Of course, Russell may have written about many women being harmed by Parker because she thought there were many. But also, maybe, she did not think it was enough to talk about a single, relatively powerless woman: Candice Russell.

Coming forward has clearly been painful and destabilizing for Russell, as it has been for many women who have alleged sexual harassment or assault. Although the online chorus was mostly on her side, she took the doubt expressed by revered leaders such as Ross as a hostile attack. But it was when she described other blowback to her Medium piece that her inability to support her claims became most conspicuous. Russell told me that her website was flooded with “hundreds and hundreds” of emails declaring that the blood of the women of Alabama and Mississippi would be on her hands. But when I asked to see some of them, she said they’d been lost after her website was hacked. Russell said Ross called her a “whore” and “a stripper with a \$75,000-a-year salary” on social media, but she couldn’t show me the posts because they’d been eliminated—perhaps by an internet “scrub” company, she added darkly. (Ross denies harassing Russell online, dismissing her claims as “delusional and self-serving.”)

Russell did show me screenshots of three threatening text messages—“Nobody will ever believe the daughter of a \$2 crack whore,” one reads—but they looked somehow off to me, so I showed them to a digital-forensics expert. He said that the font didn’t look like a standard Apple one, and the file had been saved in an unusual format, using the now-defunct software Picasa—which raises questions: If Russell had captured these on her phone, why would they have gone through extra editing and storage software? It’s extremely difficult to tell when a text has been doctored, and I have no way of knowing whether these were, but the expert told me that he’d be “concerned about the authenticity of the images.”

ONE FRIEND OF RUSSELL’S, Robin Marty, the author of *Handbook for a Post-Roe America*, believes it was Parker’s own Medium essay that led him to be so completely ostracized from the movement. Had Parker recognized the power disparity between himself and Russell; had he said something like “I did not realize at the time how those actions were perceived by you—I am going to look at how I have done things and see if there are things that I can change within my own life,” the outcome might have been different. Instead, he indulged in textbook “gaslighting,” she says, treating a woman as if it was all in her head.

When I shared Marty’s language with Parker, however, he was unmoved. Russell was blatantly fabricating, he said. So, on principle, he could not accept responsibility for harm—not even if doing so would somehow restore him to his former prominence. “Not even to make this go away,” he told me firmly.

Even if Parker had managed to sound more humble—or more evolved, as Marty might put it—he probably wouldn’t have

“I would prefer to have been accused of murder,” Parker says, “because there would have been some effort at due process.”

helped himself much. Grassroots activists told me that the stain of doubt Russell’s charges put on Parker immediately rendered his presence untenable at meetings and conferences, particularly because they’re valued as “safe spaces” for people who are regularly subject to ugly threats. These female activists, many of them volunteers, many of them young, arguably keep the fight for reproductive rights afloat. Who could risk alienating them?

Jodi Magee, the longtime president of Physicians for Reproductive Health, whose board Parker chaired, refused to disclose details of confidential deliberations about him. But she did say that, in the Trump-Pence era, with “state legislators coming after us every single day,” her job is to keep the wheels on the bus, so to speak. I took that to mean: Keep the organization above reproach, so that it can stay on task and avoid throwing red meat to anti-abortion forces.

This past fall, when no one else had accused Parker of sexual violence, Tanya Selvaratnam told me she felt compelled to revise her post for *Glamour*. It weighed on her that the doctor had been banished seemingly with no “due process.” She wrote: “I believe in investigating allegations. If we don’t establish the veracity of the allegations and the credibility of the accuser, if we don’t distinguish between men behaving badly versus men committing horrific acts against women and causing lifelong trauma, we do the #metoo movement a great disservice.”

Such calls for due process, though, give rise to the question: Due process administered by whom, exactly, and how? In June, the leaders of some 30 abortion-rights organizations gathered in Washington, D.C., to discuss, in part, how the movement might handle complaints of sexual misconduct in the future. Though the deliberations were off the record, Fatima Goss Graves, the president and CEO of the National Women’s Law Center, which helped convene the meeting, told me that the overarching goal wasn’t “due process,” a criminal-law standard established to protect the accused, but “fair processes” for the accused *and* the accuser, like those used in workplaces. What this means practically for a movement made up of interwoven but independent groups is hard to fathom, but Goss Graves said it was unlikely that a central entity might be formed to resolve complaints. All she would say is that the first step is to make sure that every organization, large or small, informs its employees and volunteers

that if they’re harassed—whether at the office or at a meeting or an event—“we want to know about it.”

THERE IS NO EVIDENCE that the conflict over Parker, or his sidelining, seriously damaged the abortion-rights cause. But it did open up one more rift in a movement that some see as already full of them, at an extremely risky time for the future of abortion access. At Planned Parenthood, Cecile Richards’s successor, Leana Wen, was pushed out in July because, Wen has said, she wanted to focus more on health-care delivery than politics; the organization blames her “leadership and management style.” According to an investigation published by *The New York Times* in December, amid record-breaking fundraising stoked by states’ passage of stringent anti-abortion bills, various factions in the movement are clashing over issues such as how to allocate resources to ensure that poor women get the services they need.

When Parker published his memoir in 2017, it was praised by feminist luminaries from Gloria Steinem to Lena Dunham to bell hooks. Richards, then still at the helm of Planned Parenthood, called it “a beacon of hope” that would “change lives,” writing: “At Planned Parenthood, our motto is ‘Care, no matter what’—words that might as well have been written with Dr. Willie Parker in mind.” In November, when I asked Richards to talk about the fate of the man who for two and a half years was employed as the medical director of Planned Parenthood of Metropolitan Washington, D.C., she declined to comment.

That day in New York Parker told me, “I would prefer to have been accused of murder, because there would have been some effort at due process.” While Russell’s allies argue that Parker emerged from the scandal relatively unscathed—he can still practice medicine, after all—to him the loss of his advocacy role has been crushing. That is what “allowed me to live my core values,” he said, “to be a person of integrity.”

Russell, too, has lost the work she loved. In mid-October, Yellowhammer released a statement that praised her work and dedication but announced that she had resigned “to pursue other interests outside of the reproductive rights and justice” arena. Russell had predicted this outcome when we talked. Because of the controversy around her, Russell believed that Yellowhammer was being shut out of important conversations in the movement. Leaving, she said, “will break my heart, but at some point it’s going to be a choice I have to make.”

The same month Russell resigned, Parker flew to Los Angeles to attend a reproductive-medicine conference he’d been invited to by a fellow physician, a gathering at which he’d spoken several times in the past. He hadn’t preregistered, and when he showed up at the hotel where the event was taking place, he was told to wait—someone would be down shortly to check him in. He waited in the lobby for three and a half hours. Friends, passing through, expressed sympathy, but none took on the task of fighting to get him in. Eventually, he gave up and returned to his hotel room. The next morning, he flew home. *A*

Maggie Bullock is a freelance writer based in Amherst, Massachusetts.

SMALLER. FASTER. STRONGER.

Meet the all new SimpliSafe.

It's smaller, faster, stronger than ever.

Engineered with a single focus: to protect.

With sensors so small they're practically invisible.

Designed to disappear into your home

And blanket it with protection.

More than easy to use—downright delightful.

All at prices that are fair and honest.

It's home security. Done right.

"The best home
security system"

WIRECUTTER

APRIL 2018

"...SimpliSafe belongs at
the top of your list..."

CNET EDITORS' CHOICE

3/28/18

"A seamless system"

PCMAG EDITORS' CHOICE

4/2/18



Free shipping for a limited time
at [SimpliSafe.com/atlantic](https://www.simplisafe.com/atlantic)

SimpliSafe™



⊥

— *The* —

N U C L E A R

F A M I L Y

— *Was a* —

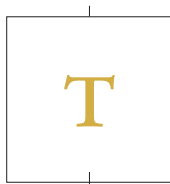
M I S T A K E

⊥

*The family structure
we've held up as the cultural
ideal for the past half century
has been a catastrophe for
many. It's time to figure out
better ways to live together.*

— *By* —

DAVID BROOKS



The scene is one many of us have somewhere in our family history: Dozens of people celebrating Thanksgiving or some other holiday around a makeshift stretch of family tables—siblings, cousins, aunts, uncles, great-aunts. The grandparents are telling the old family stories for the 37th time. “It was the most beautiful place you’ve ever seen in your life,” says one, remembering his first day in America. “There were lights everywhere ... It was a celebration of light! I thought they were for me.”

The oldsters start squabbling about whose memory is better. “It was cold that day,” one says about some faraway memory. “What are you talking about? It was May, late May,” says another. The young children sit wide-eyed, absorbing family lore and trying to piece together the plotline of the generations.

After the meal, there are piles of plates in the sink, squads of children conspiring mischievously in the basement. Groups of young parents huddle in a hallway, making plans. The old men nap on couches, waiting for dessert. It’s the extended family in all its tangled, loving, exhausting glory.

This particular family is the one depicted in Barry Levinson’s 1990 film, *Avalon*, based on his own childhood in Baltimore. Five brothers came to America from Eastern Europe around the time of World War I and built a wallpaper business. For a while they did everything together, like in the old country. But as the movie goes along, the extended family begins to split apart. Some members move to the suburbs for more privacy and space. One leaves for a job in a different state. The big blowup comes over something that seems trivial but isn’t: The eldest of the brothers arrives late to a Thanksgiving dinner to find that the family has begun the meal without him.

“You cut the turkey without me?” he cries. “Your own flesh and blood! ... You cut the turkey?” The pace of life is speeding up. Convenience, privacy, and mobility are more important than family loyalty. “The idea that they would eat before the brother arrived was a sign of disrespect,” Levinson told me recently when I asked him about that scene. “That was the real crack in the family. When you violate the protocol, the whole family structure begins to collapse.”

As the years go by in the movie, the extended family plays a smaller and smaller role. By the 1960s, there’s no extended family at Thanksgiving. It’s just a young father and mother and their son and daughter, eating turkey off trays in front of the television. In the final scene, the main character is living alone in a nursing home, wondering what happened. “In the end, you spend everything you’ve ever saved, sell everything you’ve ever owned, just to exist in a place like this.”

“In my childhood,” Levinson told me, “you’d gather around the grandparents and they would tell the family stories ... Now individuals sit around the TV, watching other families’ stories.”

The main theme of *Avalon*, he said, is “the decentralization of the family. And that has continued even further today. Once, families at least gathered around the television. Now each person has their own screen.”

This is the story of our times—the story of the family, once a dense cluster of many siblings and extended kin, fragmenting into ever smaller and more fragile forms. The initial result of that fragmentation, the nuclear family, didn’t seem so bad. But then, because the nuclear family is so brittle, the fragmentation continued. In many sectors of society, nuclear families fragmented into single-parent families, single-parent families into chaotic families or no families.

If you want to summarize the changes in family structure over the past century, the truest thing to say is this: We’ve made life freer for individuals and more unstable for families. We’ve made life better for adults but worse for children. We’ve moved from big, interconnected, and extended families, which helped protect the most vulnerable people in society from the shocks of life, to smaller, detached nuclear families (a married couple and their children), which give the most privileged people in society room to maximize their talents and expand their options. The shift from bigger and interconnected extended families to smaller and detached nuclear families ultimately led to a familial system that liberates the rich and ravages the working-class and the poor.

This article is about that process, and the devastation it has wrought—and about how Americans are now groping to build new kinds of family and find better ways to live.

Part I

The Era of Extended Clans

Through the early parts of American history, most people lived in what, by today’s standards, were big, sprawling households. In 1800, three-quarters of American workers were farmers. Most of the other quarter worked in small family businesses, like dry-goods stores. People needed a lot of labor to run these enterprises. It was not uncommon for married couples to have seven or eight children. In addition, there might be stray aunts, uncles, and cousins, as well as unrelated servants, apprentices, and farmhands. (On some southern farms, of course, enslaved African Americans were also an integral part of production and work life.)

Steven Ruggles, a professor of history and population studies at the University of Minnesota, calls these “corporate families”—social units organized around a family business. According to Ruggles, in 1800, 90 percent of American families

were corporate families. Until 1850, roughly three-quarters of Americans older than 65 lived with their kids and grandkids. Nuclear families existed, but they were surrounded by extended or corporate families.

Extended families have two great strengths. The first is resilience. An extended family is one or more families in a supporting web. Your spouse and children come first, but there are also cousins, in-laws, grandparents—a complex web of relationships among, say, seven, 10, or 20 people. If a mother dies, siblings, uncles, aunts, and grandparents are there to step in. If a relationship between a father and a child ruptures, others can fill the breach. Extended families have more people to share the unexpected burdens—when a kid gets sick in the middle of the day or when an adult unexpectedly loses a job.

A detached nuclear family, by contrast, is an intense set of relationships among, say, four people. If one relationship breaks, there are no shock absorbers. In a nuclear family, the end of the marriage means the end of the family as it was previously understood.

The second great strength of extended families is their socializing force. Multiple adults teach children right from wrong, how to behave toward others, how to be kind. Over the course of the 18th and 19th centuries, industrialization and cultural change began to threaten traditional ways of life. Many people in Britain and the United States doubled down on the extended family in order to create a moral haven in a heartless world. According to Ruggles, the prevalence of extended families living together roughly doubled from 1750 to 1900, and this way of life was more common than at any time before or since.

During the Victorian era, the idea of “hearth and home” became a cultural ideal. The home “is a sacred place, a vestal temple, a temple of the hearth watched over by Household Gods, before whose faces none may come but those whom they can receive with love,” the great Victorian social critic John Ruskin wrote. This shift was led by the upper-middle class, which was coming to see the family less as an economic unit and more as an emotional and moral unit, a rectory for the formation of hearts and souls.

But while extended families have strengths, they can also be exhausting and stifling. They allow little privacy; you are forced to be in daily intimate contact with people you didn’t choose. There’s more stability but less mobility. Family bonds are thicker, but individual choice is diminished. You have less space to make your own way in life. In the Victorian era, families were patriarchal, favoring men in general and first-born sons in particular.

As factories opened in the big U.S. cities, in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, young men and women left their extended families to chase the American dream. These young people married as soon as they could. A young man on a farm might wait until 26 to get married; in the lonely city, men married at 22 or 23. From 1890 to 1960, the average age of first marriage dropped by 3.6 years for men and 2.2 years for women.

The families they started were nuclear families. The decline of multigenerational cohabiting families exactly mirrors the decline in farm employment. Children were no longer raised

to assume economic roles—they were raised so that at adolescence they could fly from the nest, become independent, and seek partners of their own. They were raised not for embeddedness but for autonomy. By the 1920s, the nuclear family with a male breadwinner had replaced the corporate family as the dominant family form. By 1960, 77.5 percent of all children were living with their two parents, who were married, and apart from their extended family.

The Short, Happy Life of the Nuclear Family

For a time, it all seemed to work. From 1950 to 1965, divorce rates dropped, fertility rates rose, and the American nuclear family seemed to be in wonderful shape. And most people seemed prosperous and happy. In these years, a kind of cult formed around this type of family—what *McCall’s*, the leading women’s magazine of the day, called “togetherness.” Healthy people lived in two-parent families. In a 1957 survey, more than half of the respondents said that unmarried people were “sick,” “immoral,” or “neurotic.”

During this period, a certain family ideal became engraved in our minds: a married couple with 2.5 kids. When we think of the American family, many of us still revert to this ideal. When we have debates about how to strengthen the family, we are thinking of the two-parent nuclear family, with one or two kids, probably living in some detached family home on some suburban street. We take it as the norm, even though this wasn’t the way most humans lived during the tens of thousands of years before 1950, and it isn’t the way most humans have lived during the 55 years since 1965.

Today, only a minority of American households are traditional two-parent nuclear families and only one-third of American individuals live in this kind of family. That 1950–65 window was not normal. It was a freakish historical moment when all of society conspired, wittingly and not, to obscure the essential fragility of the nuclear family.

For one thing, most women were relegated to the home. Many corporations, well into the mid-20th century, barred married women from employment: Companies would hire single women, but if those women got married, they would have to quit. Demeaning and disempowering treatment of women was rampant. Women spent enormous numbers of hours trapped inside the home under the headship of their husband, raising children.

For another thing, nuclear families in this era were much more connected to other nuclear families than they are today—constituting a “modified extended family,” as the sociologist Eugene Litwak calls it, “a coalition of nuclear families in a state of mutual dependence.” Even as late as the 1950s, before television

and air-conditioning had fully caught on, people continued to live on one another's front porches and were part of one another's lives. Friends felt free to discipline one another's children.

In his book *The Lost City*, the journalist Alan Ehrenhalt describes life in mid-century Chicago and its suburbs:

To be a young homeowner in a suburb like Elmhurst in the 1950s was to participate in a communal enterprise that only the most determined loner could escape: barbecues, coffee klatches, volleyball games, baby-sitting co-ops and constant bartering of household goods, child rearing by the nearest parents who happened to be around, neighbors wandering through the door at any hour without knocking—all these were devices by which young adults who had been set down in a wilderness of tract homes made a community. It was a life lived in public.

Finally, conditions in the wider society were ideal for family stability. The postwar period was a high-water mark of church attendance, unionization, social trust, and mass prosperity—all things that correlate with family cohesion. A man could relatively easily find a job that would allow him to be the breadwinner for a single-income family. By 1961, the median American man age 25 to 29 was earning nearly 400 percent more than his father had earned at about the same age.

In short, the period from 1950 to 1965 demonstrated that a stable society can be built around nuclear families—so long as women are relegated to the household, nuclear families are so intertwined that they are basically extended families by another name, and every economic and sociological condition in society is working together to support the institution.

Disintegration

But these conditions did not last. The constellation of forces that had briefly shored up the nuclear family began to fall

away, and the sheltered family of the 1950s was supplanted by the stressed family of every decade since. Some of the strains were economic. Starting in the mid-'70s, young men's wages declined, putting pressure on working-class families in particular. The major strains were cultural. Society became more

individualistic and more self-oriented. People put greater value on privacy and autonomy. A rising feminist movement helped endow women with greater freedom to live and work as they chose.

A study of women's magazines by the sociologists Francesca Cancian and Steven L. Gordon found that from 1900 to 1979, themes of putting family before self dominated in the 1950s: "Love means self-sacrifice and compromise." In the 1960s and '70s, putting self before family was prominent: "Love means self-expression and individuality." Men absorbed these cultural themes, too. The master trend in Baby Boomer culture generally was liberation—"Free Bird," "Born to Run," "Ramblin' Man."

Eli Finkel, a psychologist and marriage scholar at Northwestern University, has argued that since the 1960s, the dominant family culture has been the "self-expressive marriage." "Americans," he has written, "now look to marriage increasingly for self-discovery, self-esteem and personal growth." Marriage, according to the sociologists Kathryn Edin and Maria

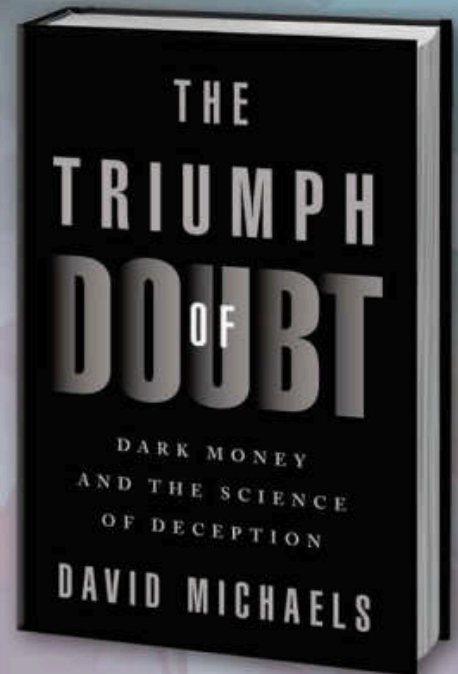
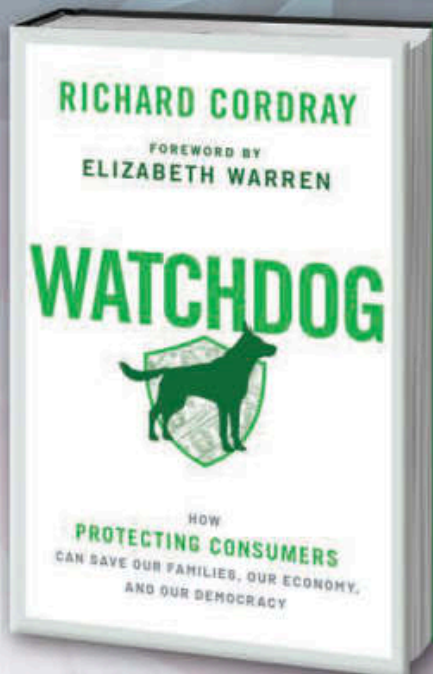
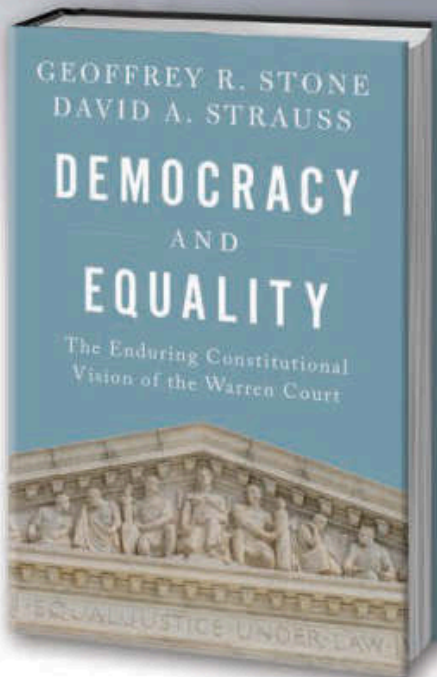
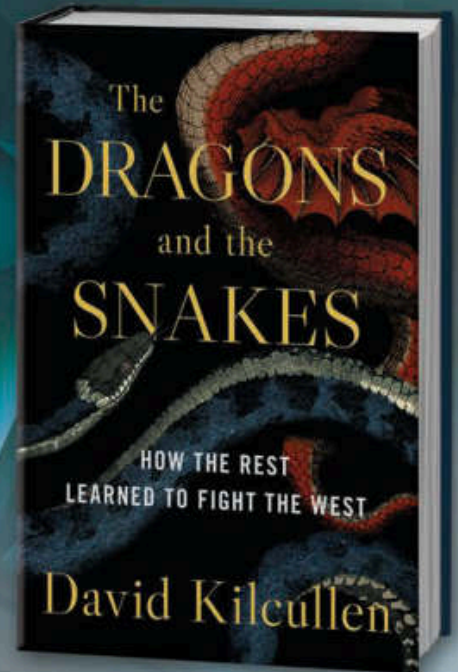
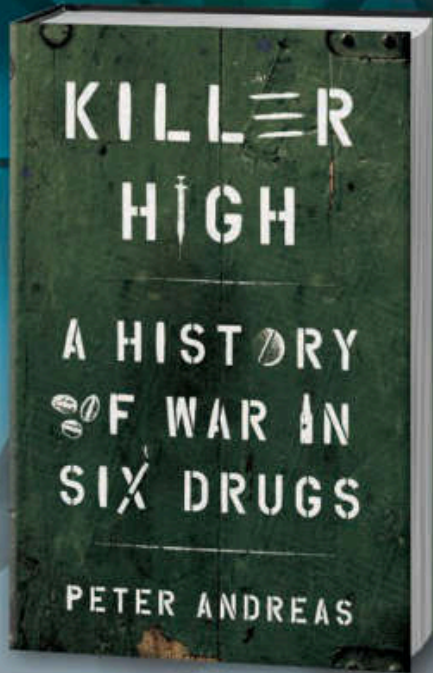
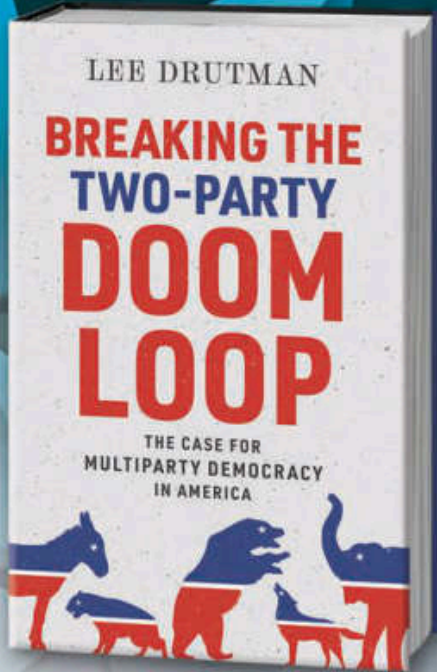
Kefalas, "is no longer primarily about childbearing and child-rearing. Now marriage is primarily about adult fulfillment."

This cultural shift was very good for some adults, but it was not so good for families generally. Fewer relatives are around in times of stress to help a couple work through them. If you married for love, staying together made less sense when the love died. This attenuation of marital ties may have begun during the late 1800s: The number of divorces increased about fifteen-fold from 1870 to 1920, and then climbed more or less continuously through the first several decades of the nuclear-family era. As the intellectual historian Christopher Lasch noted in the late 1970s, the American family didn't start coming apart in the 1960s; it had been "coming apart for more than 100 years."

Americans today have less family than ever before. From 1970 to 2012, the share of households consisting of married couples with kids has been cut in half. In 1960, according to census data, just 13 percent of all households were

WE'RE LIKELY LIVING
THROUGH THE MOST
RAPID CHANGE IN
FAMILY STRUCTURE
IN HUMAN HISTORY.
THE CAUSES ARE
ECONOMIC, CULTURAL,
AND INSTITUTIONAL
ALL AT ONCE.

BEHIND EVERY HEADLINE THERE'S A STORY



Available Now Wherever Books Are Sold
oup.com/academic

OXFORD
UNIVERSITY PRESS

single-person households. In 2018, that figure was 28 percent. In 1850, 75 percent of Americans older than 65 lived with relatives; by 1990, only 18 percent did.

Over the past two generations, people have spent less and less time in marriage—they are marrying later, if at all, and divorcing more. In 1950, 27 percent of marriages ended in divorce; today, about 45 percent do. In 1960, 72 percent of American adults were married. In 2017, nearly half of American adults were single. According to a 2014 report from the Urban Institute, roughly 90 percent of Baby Boomer women and 80 percent of Gen X women married by age 40, while only about 70 percent of late-Millennial women were expected to do so—the lowest rate in U.S. history. And while more than four-fifths of American adults in a 2019 Pew Research Center survey said that getting married is not essential to living a fulfilling life, it's not just the institution of marriage they're eschewing: In 2004, 33 percent of Americans ages 18 to 34 were living without a romantic partner, according to the General Social Survey; by 2018, that number was up to 51 percent.

Over the past two generations, families have also gotten a lot smaller. The general American birth rate is half of what it was in 1960. In 2012, most American family households had no children. There are more American homes with pets than with kids. In 1970, about 20 percent of households had five or more people. As of 2012, only 9.6 percent did.

Over the past two generations, the physical space separating nuclear families has widened. Before, sisters-in-law shouted greetings across the street at each other from their porches. Kids would dash from home to home and eat out of whoever's fridge was closest by. But lawns have grown more expansive and porch life has declined, creating a buffer of space that separates the house and family from anyone else. As Mandy Len Catron recently noted in *The Atlantic*, married people are less likely to visit parents and siblings, and less inclined to help them do chores or offer emotional support. A code of family self-sufficiency prevails: Mom, Dad, and the kids are on their own, with a barrier around their island home.

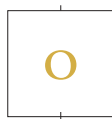
Finally, over the past two generations, families have grown more unequal. America now has two entirely different family regimes. Among the highly educated, family patterns are almost as stable as they were in the 1950s; among the less fortunate, family life is often utter chaos. There's a reason for that divide: Affluent people have the resources to effectively buy extended family, in order to shore themselves up. Think of all the child-rearing labor affluent parents now buy that used to be done by extended kin: babysitting, professional child care, tutoring, coaching, therapy, expensive after-school programs. (For that matter, think of how the affluent can hire therapists and life coaches for themselves, as replacement for kin or close friends.) These expensive tools and services not only support children's development and help prepare them to compete in the meritocracy; by reducing stress and time commitments for parents, they preserve the amity of marriage. Affluent conservatives often pat themselves on the back for having stable nuclear families. They preach that everybody else should build stable

families too. But then they ignore one of the main reasons their own families are stable: They can afford to purchase the support that extended family used to provide—and that the people they preach at, further down the income scale, cannot.

In 1970, the family structures of the rich and poor did not differ that greatly. Now there is a chasm between them. As of 2005, 85 percent of children born to upper-middle-class families were living with both biological parents when the mom was 40. Among working-class families, only 30 percent were. According to a 2012 report from the National Center for Health Statistics, college-educated women ages 22 to 44 have a 78 percent chance of having their first marriage last at least 20 years. Women in the same age range with a high-school degree or less have only about a 40 percent chance. Among Americans ages 18 to 55, only 26 percent of the poor and 39 percent of the working class are currently married. In her book *Generation Unbound*, Isabel Sawhill, an economist at the Brookings Institution, cited research indicating that differences in family structure have “increased income inequality by 25 percent.” If the U.S. returned to the marriage rates of 1970, child poverty would be 20 percent lower. As Andrew Cherlin, a sociologist at Johns Hopkins University, once put it, “It is the privileged Americans who are marrying, and marrying helps them stay privileged.”

When you put everything together, we're likely living through the most rapid change in family structure in human history. The causes are economic, cultural, and institutional all at once. People who grow up in a nuclear family tend to have a more individualistic mind-set than people who grow up in a multigenerational extended clan. People with an individualistic mind-set tend to be less willing to sacrifice self for the sake of the family, and the result is more family disruption. People who grow up in disrupted families have more trouble getting the education they need to have prosperous careers. People who don't have prosperous careers have trouble building stable families, because of financial challenges and other stressors. The children in those families become more isolated and more traumatized.

Many people growing up in this era have no secure base from which to launch themselves and no well-defined pathway to adulthood. For those who have the human capital to explore, fall down, and have their fall cushioned, that means great freedom and opportunity—and for those who lack those resources, it tends to mean great confusion, drift, and pain.



VER THE PAST 50 YEARS, federal and state governments have tried to mitigate the deleterious effects of these trends. They've tried to increase marriage rates, push down divorce rates, boost fertility, and all the rest. The focus has always been on strengthening the nuclear family, not the extended family. Occasionally, a discrete program will yield some positive results, but the widening of family inequality continues unabated.



The people who suffer the most from the decline in family support are the vulnerable—especially children. In 1960, roughly 5 percent of children were born to unmarried women. Now about 40 percent are. The Pew Research Center reported that 11 percent of children lived apart from their father in 1960. In 2010, 27 percent did. Now about half of American children will spend their childhood with both biological parents. Twenty percent of young adults have no contact at all with their father (though in some cases that’s because the father is deceased). American children are more likely to live in a single-parent household than children from any other country.

We all know stable and loving single-parent families. But on average, children of single parents or unmarried cohabiting parents tend to have worse health outcomes, worse mental-health outcomes, less academic success, more behavioral problems, and higher truancy rates than do children living with their two married biological parents. According to work by Richard V. Reeves, a co-director of the Center on Children and Families at the Brookings Institution, if you are born into poverty and raised by your married parents, you have an 80 percent chance of climbing out of it. If you are born into poverty and raised by an unmarried mother, you have a 50 percent chance of remaining stuck.

It’s not just the lack of relationships that hurts children; it’s the churn. According to a 2003 study that Andrew Cherlin cites, 12 percent of American kids had lived in at least three “parental partnerships” before they turned 15. The transition moments, when mom’s old partner moves out or her new partner moves in, are the hardest on kids, Cherlin shows.

While children are the vulnerable group most obviously affected by recent changes in family structure, they are not the only one.

Consider single men. Extended families provided men with the fortifying influences of male bonding and female companionship. Today many American males spend the first 20 years of their life without a father and the next 15 without a spouse. Kay Hymowitz of the Manhattan Institute has spent a good chunk of her career examining the wreckage caused by the decline of the American family, and cites evidence showing that, in the absence of the connection and meaning that

family provides, unmarried men are less healthy—alcohol and drug abuse are common—earn less, and die sooner than married men.

For women, the nuclear-family structure imposes different pressures. Though women have benefited greatly from the loosening of traditional family structures—they have more freedom to choose the lives they want—many mothers who decide to raise their young children without extended family nearby find that they have chosen a lifestyle that is brutally

hard and isolating. The situation is exacerbated by the fact that women still spend significantly more time on housework and child care than men do, according to recent data. Thus, the reality we see around us: stressed, tired mothers trying to balance work and parenting, and having to reschedule work when family life gets messy.

Without extended families, older Americans have also suffered. According to the AARP, 35 percent of Americans over 45 say they are chronically lonely. Many older people are now “elder orphans,” with no close relatives or friends to take care of them. In 2015, *The New York Times* ran an article called “The Lonely Death of George Bell,” about a family-less 72-year-old man who died alone and rotted in his Queens apartment for so long that by the time police found him, his body was unrecognizable.

Finally, because groups that have endured greater levels of discrimination tend to have more fragile families, African Americans have suffered disproportionately in the era of the detached nuclear family. Nearly half of black families are led by an unmarried single woman,

compared with less than one-sixth of white families. (The high rate of black incarceration guarantees a shortage of available men to be husbands or caretakers of children.) According to census data from 2010, 25 percent of black women over 35 have never been married, compared with 8 percent of white women. Two-thirds of African American children lived in single-parent families in 2018, compared with a quarter of white children. Black single-parent families are most concentrated in precisely those parts of the country in which slavery was most prevalent. Research by John Iceland, a professor of sociology and demography at Penn State, suggests that the differences between white and black family structure explain 30 percent of the affluence gap between the two groups.

THE PERIOD WHEN THE
NUCLEAR FAMILY
FLOURISHED WAS NOT
NORMAL. IT WAS A
FREAKISH HISTORICAL
MOMENT WHEN ALL OF
SOCIETY CONSPIRED
TO OBSCURE ITS
ESSENTIAL FRAGILITY.

CHARLES TYRWHITT

LIFE IS BETTER IN A PROPER SHIRT



3 SHIRTS
FOR ONLY
\$99.95

SAVE OVER \$200

PLUS
FREE
SHIPPING

A SPECIAL INTRODUCTORY OFFER, VISIT:

WWW.CTSHIRTS.COM/QUALITY

Mix and match between dress shirts, casual & polos. Products imported. See full T&Cs online.



N 2004, the journalist and urbanist Jane Jacobs published her final book, an assessment of North American society called *Dark Age Ahead*. At the core of her argument was the idea that families are “rigged to fail.” The structures

that once supported the family no longer exist, she wrote. Jacobs was too pessimistic about many things, but for millions of people, the shift from big and/or extended families to detached nuclear families has indeed been a disaster.

As the social structures that support the family have decayed, the debate about it has taken on a mythical quality. Social conservatives insist that we can bring the nuclear family back. But the conditions that made for stable nuclear families in the 1950s are never returning. Conservatives have nothing to say to the kid whose dad has split, whose mom has had three other kids with different dads; “go live in a nuclear family” is really not relevant advice. If only a minority of households are traditional nuclear families, that means the majority are something else: single parents, never-married parents, blended families, grandparent-headed families, serial partnerships, and so on. Conservative ideas have not caught up with this reality.

Progressives, meanwhile, still talk like self-expressive individualists of the 1970s: *People should have the freedom to pick whatever family form works for them*. And, of course, they should. But many of the new family forms do not work well for most people—and while progressive elites say that all family structures are fine, their own behavior suggests that they believe otherwise. As the sociologist W. Bradford Wilcox has pointed out, highly educated progressives may talk a tolerant game on family structure when speaking about society at large, but they have extremely strict expectations for their own families. When Wilcox asked his University of Virginia students if they thought having a child out of wedlock was wrong, 62 percent said it was not wrong. When he asked the students how their own parents would feel if they themselves had a child out of wedlock, 97 percent said their parents would “freak out.” In a recent survey by the Institute for Family Studies, college-educated Californians ages 18 to 50 were less likely than those who hadn’t graduated from college to say that having a baby out of wedlock is wrong. But they were *more* likely to say that personally they did not approve of having a baby out of wedlock.

In other words, while social conservatives have a philosophy of family life they can’t operationalize, because it no longer is relevant, progressives have no philosophy of family life at all, because they don’t want to seem judgmental. The sexual revolution has come and gone, and it’s left us with no governing norms of family life, no guiding values, no articulated ideals. On this most central issue, our shared culture often has nothing relevant to say—and so for decades things have been falling apart.

The good news is that human beings adapt, even if politics are slow to do so. When one family form stops working, people cast about for something new—sometimes finding it in something very old.

Part II

Redefining Kinship

In the beginning was the band. For tens of thousands of years, people commonly lived in small bands of, say, 25 people, which linked up with perhaps 20 other bands to form a tribe. People in the band went out foraging for food and brought it back to share. They hunted together, fought wars together, made clothing for one another, looked after one another’s kids. In every realm of life, they relied on their extended family and wider kin.

Except they didn’t define kin the way we do today. We think of kin as those biologically related to us. But throughout most of human history, kinship was something you could create.

Anthropologists have been arguing for decades about what exactly kinship is. Studying traditional societies, they have found wide varieties of created kinship among different cultures. For the Ilongot people of the Philippines, people who migrated somewhere together are kin. For the New Guineans of the Nebilyer Valley, kinship is created by sharing *grease*—the life force found in mother’s milk or sweet potatoes. The Chuukese people in Micronesia have a saying: “My sibling from the same canoe”; if two people survive a dangerous trial at sea, then they become kin. On the Alaskan North Slope, the Inupiat name their children after dead people, and those children are considered members of their namesake’s family.

In other words, for vast stretches of human history people lived in extended families consisting of not just people they were related to but people they chose to cooperate with. An international research team recently did a genetic analysis of people who were buried together—and therefore presumably lived together—34,000 years ago in what is now Russia. They found that the people who were buried together were not closely related to one another. In a study of 32 present-day foraging societies, primary kin—parents, siblings, and children—usually made up less than 10 percent of a residential band. Extended families in traditional societies may or may not have been genetically close, but they were probably emotionally closer than most of us can imagine. In a beautiful essay on kinship, Marshall Sahlins, an anthropologist at the University of Chicago, says that kin in many such societies share a “mutuality of being.” The late religion scholar J. Prytz-Johansen wrote that kinship is experienced as an “inner solidarity” of souls. The late South

African anthropologist Monica Wilson described kinsmen as “mystically dependent” on one another. Kinsmen belong to one another, Sahlins writes, because they see themselves as “members of one another.”

Back in the 17th and 18th centuries, when European Protestants came to North America, their relatively individualistic culture existed alongside Native Americans’ very communal culture. In his book *Tribe*, Sebastian Junger describes what happened next: While European settlers kept defecting to go live with Native American families, almost no Native Americans ever defected to go live with European families. Europeans occasionally captured Native Americans and forced them to come live with them. They taught them English and educated them in Western ways. But almost every time they were able, the indigenous Americans fled. European settlers were sometimes captured by Native Americans during wars and brought to live in Native communities. They rarely tried to run away. This bothered the Europeans. They had the superior civilization, so why were people voting with their feet to go live in another way?

When you read such accounts, you can’t help but wonder whether our civilization has somehow made a gigantic mistake.

We can’t go back, of course. Western individualists are no longer the kind of people who live in prehistoric bands. We may even no longer be the kind of people who were featured in the early scenes of *Avalon*. We value privacy and individual freedom too much.

Our culture is oddly stuck. We want stability and rootedness, but also mobility, dynamic capitalism, and the liberty to adopt the lifestyle we choose. We want close families, but not the legal, cultural, and sociological constraints that made them possible. We’ve seen the wreckage left behind by the collapse of the detached nuclear family. We’ve seen the rise of opioid addiction, of suicide, of depression, of inequality—all products, in part, of a family structure that is too fragile, and a society that is too detached, disconnected, and distrustful. And yet we can’t quite return to a more collective world. The words the historians Steven Mintz and Susan Kellogg wrote in 1988 are even truer today: “Many Americans are groping for a new paradigm of American family life, but in the meantime a profound sense of confusion and ambivalence reigns.”

From Nuclear Families to Forged Families

Yet recent signs suggest at least the possibility that a new family paradigm is emerging. Many of the statistics I’ve cited are dire. But they describe the past—what got us to where we are now. In reaction to family chaos, accumulating evidence suggests, the prioritization of family is beginning to make a comeback.

Americans are experimenting with new forms of kinship and extended family in search of stability.

Usually behavior changes before we realize that a new cultural paradigm has emerged. Imagine hundreds of millions of tiny arrows. In times of social transformation, they shift direction—a few at first, and then a lot. Nobody notices for a while, but then eventually people begin to recognize that a new pattern, and a new set of values, has emerged.

That may be happening now—in part out of necessity but in part by choice. Since the 1970s, and especially since the 2008 recession, economic pressures have pushed Americans toward greater reliance on family. Starting around 2012, the share of children living with married parents began to inch up. And college students have more contact with their parents than they did a generation ago. We tend to deride this as helicopter parenting or a failure to launch, and it has its excesses. But the educational process is longer and more expensive these days, so it makes sense that young adults rely on their parents for longer than they used to.

In 1980, only 12 percent of Americans lived in multigenerational households. But the financial crisis of 2008 prompted a sharp rise in multigenerational homes. Today 20 percent of Americans—64 million people, an all-time high—live in multigenerational homes.

The revival of the extended family has largely been driven by young adults moving back home. In 2014, 35 percent of American men ages 18 to 34 lived with their parents. In time this shift might show itself to be mostly healthy, impelled not just by economic necessity but by beneficent social impulses; polling data suggest that many young people are already looking ahead to helping their parents in old age.

Another chunk of the revival is attributable to seniors moving in with their children. The percentage of seniors who live alone peaked around 1990. Now more than a fifth of Americans 65 and over live in multigenerational homes. This doesn’t count the large share of seniors who are moving to be close to their grandkids but not into the same household.

Immigrants and people of color—many of whom face greater economic and social stress—are more likely to live in extended-family households. More than 20 percent of Asians, black people, and Latinos live in multigenerational households, compared with 16 percent of white people. As America becomes more diverse, extended families are becoming more common.

African Americans have always relied on extended family more than white Americans do. “Despite the forces working to separate us—slavery, Jim Crow, forced migration, the prison system, gentrification—we have maintained an incredible commitment to each other,” Mia Birdsong, the author of the forthcoming book *How We Show Up*, told me recently. “The reality is, black families are expansive, fluid, and brilliantly rely on the support, knowledge, and capacity of ‘the village’ to take care of each other. Here’s an illustration: The white researcher/social worker/whatever sees a child moving between their mother’s house, their grandparents’ house, and

their uncle's house and sees that as 'instability.' But what's actually happening is the family (extended and chosen) is leveraging all of its resources to raise that child."

The black extended family survived even under slavery, and all the forced family separations that involved. Family was essential in the Jim Crow South and in the inner cities of the North, as a way to cope with the stresses of mass migration and limited opportunities, and with structural racism. But government policy sometimes made it more difficult for this family form to thrive. I began my career as a police reporter in Chicago, writing about public-housing projects like Cabrini-Green. Guided by social-science research, politicians tore down neighborhoods of rickety low-rise buildings—uprooting the complex webs of social connection those buildings supported, despite high rates of violence and crime—and put up big apartment buildings. The result was a horror: violent crime, gangs taking over the elevators, the erosion of family and neighborly life. Fortunately, those buildings have since been torn down themselves, replaced by mixed-income communities that are more amenable to the profusion of family forms.

The return of multigenerational living arrangements is already changing the built landscape. A 2016 survey by a real-estate consulting firm found that 44 percent of home buyers were looking for a home that would accommodate their elderly parents, and 42 percent wanted one that would accommodate their returning adult children. Home builders have responded by putting up houses that are what the construction firm Lennar calls "two homes under one roof." These houses are carefully built so that family members can spend time together while also preserving their privacy. Many of these homes have a shared mudroom, laundry room, and common area. But the "in-law suite," the place for aging parents, has its own entrance, kitchenette, and dining area. The "Millennial suite," the place for boomeranging adult children, has its own driveway and entrance too. These developments, of course, cater to those who can afford houses in the first place—but they speak to a common realization: Family members of different generations need to do more to support one another.

T

THE MOST INTERESTING extended families are those that stretch across kinship lines. The past several years have seen the rise of new living arrangements that bring nonbiological kin into family or familylike relationships.

On the website CoAbode, single mothers can find other single mothers interested in sharing a home. All across the country, you can find co-housing projects, in which groups of adults live as members of an extended family, with separate sleeping

quarters and shared communal areas. Common, a real-estate-development company that launched in 2015, operates more than 25 co-housing communities, in six cities, where young singles can live this way. Common also recently teamed up with another developer, Tishman Speyer, to launch Kin, a co-housing community for young parents. Each young family has its own living quarters, but the facilities also have shared play spaces, child-care services, and family-oriented events and outings.

These experiments, and others like them, suggest that while people still want flexibility and some privacy, they are casting about for more communal ways of living, guided by a still-developing set of values. At a co-housing community in Oakland, California, called Temescal Commons, the 23 members, ranging in age from 1 to 83, live in a complex with nine housing units. This is not some rich Bay Area hipster commune. The apartments are small, and the residents are middle- and working-class. They have a shared courtyard and a shared industrial-size kitchen where residents prepare a communal dinner on Thursday and Sunday nights. Upkeep is a shared responsibility. The adults babysit one another's children, and members borrow sugar and milk from one another. The older parents counsel the younger ones. When members of this extended family have suffered bouts of unemployment or major health crises, the whole clan has rallied together.

Courtney E. Martin, a writer who focuses on how people are redefining the American dream, is a Temescal Commons resident. "I really love that our kids grow up with different versions of adulthood all around, especially different versions of masculinity," she told me. "We consider all of our kids all of our kids." Martin has a 3-year-old daughter, Stella, who has

I OFTEN ASK AFRICAN
FRIENDS WHO HAVE
IMMIGRATED TO
AMERICA WHAT MOST
STRUCK THEM WHEN
THEY ARRIVED. THEIR
ANSWER IS ALWAYS A
VARIATION ON A THEME—
THE LONELINESS.

a special bond with a young man in his 20s that never would have taken root outside this extended-family structure. “Stella makes him laugh, and David feels awesome that this 3-year-old adores him,” Martin said. This is the kind of magic, she concluded, that wealth can’t buy. You can only have it through time and commitment, by joining an extended family. This kind of community would fall apart if residents moved in and out. But at least in this case, they don’t.

As Martin was talking, I was struck by one crucial difference between the old extended families like those in *Avalon* and the new ones of today: the role of women. The extended family in *Avalon* thrived because all the women in the family were locked in the kitchen, feeding 25 people at a time. In 2008, a team of American and Japanese researchers found that women in multigenerational households in Japan were at greater risk of heart disease than women living with spouses only, likely because of stress. But today’s extended-family living arrangements have much more diverse gender roles.

And yet in at least one respect, the new families Americans are forming would look familiar to our hunter-gatherer ancestors from eons ago. That’s because they are chosen families—they transcend traditional kinship lines.

The modern chosen-family movement came to prominence in San Francisco in the 1980s among gay men and lesbians, many of whom had become estranged from their biological families and had only one another for support in coping with the trauma of the AIDS crisis. In her book, *Families We Choose: Lesbians, Gays, Kinship*, the anthropologist Kath Weston writes, “The families I saw gay men and lesbians creating in the Bay Area tended to have extremely fluid boundaries, not unlike kinship organization among sectors of the African-American, American Indian, and white working class.”

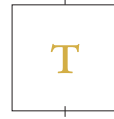
She continues:

Like their heterosexual counterparts, most gay men and lesbians insisted that family members are people who are “there for you,” people you can count on emotionally and materially. “They take care of me,” said one man, “I take care of them.”

These groups are what Daniel Burns, a political scientist at the University of Dallas, calls “forged families.” Tragedy and suffering have pushed people together in a way that goes deeper than just a convenient living arrangement. They become, as the anthropologists say, “fictive kin.”

Over the past several decades, the decline of the nuclear family has created an epidemic of trauma—millions have been set adrift because what should have been the most loving and secure relationship in their life broke. Slowly, but with increasing frequency, these drifting individuals are coming together to create forged families. These forged families have a feeling of determined commitment. The members of your chosen family are the people who will show up for you no matter what. On Pinterest you can find placards to hang on the kitchen wall where forged families gather: “Family isn’t always blood. It’s the people in your life who want you in theirs; the ones who

accept you for who you are. The ones who would do anything to see you smile & who love you no matter what.”



WO YEARS AGO, I started something called Weave: The Social Fabric Project. Weave exists to support and draw attention to people and organizations around the country who are building community. Over time, my colleagues and I have realized that one thing most of the Weavers have in common is this: They provide the kind of care to nonkin that many of us provide only to kin—the kind of support that used to be provided by the extended family.

Lisa Fitzpatrick, who was a health-care executive in New Orleans, is a Weaver. One day she was sitting in the passenger seat of a car when she noticed two young boys, 10 or 11, lifting something heavy. It was a gun. They used it to shoot her in the face. It was a gang-initiation ritual. When she recovered, she realized that she was just collateral damage. The real victims were the young boys who had to shoot somebody to get into a family, their gang.

She quit her job and began working with gang members. She opened her home to young kids who might otherwise join gangs. One Saturday afternoon, 35 kids were hanging around her house. She asked them why they were spending a lovely day at the home of a middle-aged woman. They replied, “You were the first person who ever opened the door.”

In Salt Lake City, an organization called the Other Side Academy provides serious felons with an extended family. Many of the men and women who are admitted into the program have been allowed to leave prison, where they were generally serving long sentences, but must live in a group home and work at shared businesses, a moving company and a thrift store. The goal is to transform the character of each family member. During the day they work as movers or cashiers. Then they dine together and gather several evenings a week for something called “Games”: They call one another out for any small moral failure—being sloppy with a move; not treating another family member with respect; being passive-aggressive, selfish, or avoidant.

Games is not polite. The residents scream at one another in order to break through the layers of armor that have built up in prison. Imagine two gigantic men covered in tattoos screaming “Fuck you! Fuck you! Fuck you!” At the session I attended, I thought they would come to blows. But after the anger, there’s a kind of closeness that didn’t exist before. Men and women who have never had a loving family suddenly have “relatives” who hold them accountable and demand a standard of moral excellence. Extreme integrity becomes a way of belonging to the clan. The Other Side Academy provides unwanted people with an opportunity to give care, and creates out of that care a ferocious forged family.

I could tell you hundreds of stories like this, about organizations that bring traumatized vets into extended-family settings, or nursing homes that house preschools so that senior citizens and young children can go through life together. In Baltimore,



a nonprofit called Thread surrounds underperforming students with volunteers, some of whom are called “grandparents.” In Chicago, *Becoming a Man* helps disadvantaged youth form family-type bonds with one another. In Washington, D.C., I recently met a group of middle-aged female scientists—one a celebrated cellular biologist at the National Institutes of Health, another an astrophysicist—who live together in a Catholic lay community, pooling their resources and sharing their lives. The variety of forged families in America today is endless.

You may be part of a forged family yourself. I am. In 2015, I was invited to the house of a couple named Kathy and David, who had created an extended-family-like group in D.C. called *All Our Kids*, or AOK-DC. Some years earlier, Kathy and David had had a kid in D.C. Public Schools who had a friend named James, who often had nothing to eat and no place to stay, so they suggested that he stay with them. That kid had a friend in similar circumstances, and those friends had friends. By the time I joined them, roughly 25 kids were having dinner every Thursday night, and several of them were sleeping in the basement.

I joined the community and never left—they became my chosen family. We have dinner together on Thursday nights, celebrate holidays together, and vacation together. The kids call Kathy and David Mom and Dad. In the early days, the adults in our clan

served as parental figures for the young people—replacing their broken cellphones, supporting them when depression struck, raising money for their college tuition. When a young woman in our group needed a new kidney, David gave her one of his.

We had our primary biological families, which came first, but we also had this family. Now the young people in this forged family are in their 20s and need us less. David and Kathy have left Washington, but they stay in constant contact. The dinners still happen. We still see one another and look after one another. The years of eating together and going through life together have created a bond. If a crisis hit anyone, we’d all show up. The experience has convinced me that everybody should have membership in a forged family with people completely unlike themselves.

E

VER SINCE I started working on this article, a chart has been haunting me. It plots the percentage of people living alone in a country against that nation’s GDP. There’s a strong correlation. Nations where a fifth of the people live alone, like Denmark and Finland, are a lot richer than nations where almost no one lives alone, like the ones in Latin America or Africa. Rich nations have smaller households than

poor nations. The average German lives in a household with 2.7 people. The average Gambian lives in a household with 13.8 people.

That chart suggests two things, especially in the American context. First, the market wants us to live alone or with just a few people. That way we are mobile, unattached, and uncommitted, able to devote an enormous number of hours to our jobs. Second, when people who are raised in developed countries get money, they buy privacy.

For the privileged, this sort of works. The arrangement enables the affluent to dedicate more hours to work and email, unencumbered by family commitments. They can afford to hire people who will do the work that extended family used to do. But a lingering sadness lurks, an awareness that life is emotionally vacant when family and close friends aren't physically present, when neighbors aren't geographically or metaphorically close enough for you to lean on them, or for them to lean on you. Today's crisis of connection flows from the impoverishment of family life.

I often ask African friends who have immigrated to America what most struck them when they arrived. Their answer is always a variation on a theme—the loneliness. It's the empty suburban street in the middle of the day, maybe with a lone mother pushing a baby carriage on the sidewalk but nobody else around.

For those who are not privileged, the era of the isolated nuclear family has been a catastrophe. It's led to broken families or no families; to merry-go-round families that leave children traumatized and isolated; to senior citizens dying alone in a room. All forms of inequality are cruel, but family inequality may be the cruelest. It damages the heart. Eventually family inequality even undermines the economy the nuclear family was meant to serve: Children who grow up in chaos have trouble becoming skilled, stable, and socially mobile employees later on.

When hyper-individualism kicked into gear in the 1960s, people experimented with new ways of living that embraced individualistic values. Today we are crawling out from the wreckage of that hyper-individualism—which left many families detached and unsupported—and people are

experimenting with more connected ways of living, with new shapes and varieties of extended families. Government support can help nurture this experimentation, particularly for the working-class and the poor, with things like child tax credits, coaching programs to improve parenting skills in struggling families, subsidized early education, and expanded parental leave. While the most important shifts will be cultural, and driven by individual

choices, family life is under so much social stress and economic pressure in the poorer reaches of American society that no recovery is likely without some government action.

The two-parent family, meanwhile, is not about to go extinct. For many people, especially those with financial and social resources, it is a great way to live and raise children. But a new and more communal ethos is emerging, one that is consistent with 21st-century reality and 21st-century values.

When we discuss the problems confronting the country, we don't talk about family enough. It feels too judgmental. Too uncomfortable. Maybe even too religious. But the blunt fact is that the nuclear family has been crumbling in slow motion for decades, and many of our other problems—with education, mental health, addiction, the quality of the labor force—stem from that crumbling. We've left behind the nuclear-family paradigm of 1955. For most people it's not coming back. Americans are hungering to live in extended and forged families, in ways that are new and ancient at

the same time. This is a significant opportunity, a chance to thicken and broaden family relationships, a chance to allow more adults and children to live and grow under the loving gaze of a dozen pairs of eyes, and be caught, when they fall, by a dozen pairs of arms. For decades we have been eating at smaller and smaller tables, with fewer and fewer kin.

It's time to find ways to bring back the big tables. *A*

David Brooks is a contributing writer at The Atlantic and a columnist for The New York Times. His most recent book is The Second Mountain: The Quest for a Moral Life.

Culture & Critics



The New Rules of Music Snobbery

Hulu's High Fidelity reboot captures the end of elitist condescension and the rise of fervent eclecticism.

By Spencer Kornhaber

Twenty-five years after Nick Hornby's novel *High Fidelity* psychoanalyzed fussy record-store clerks, and 20 years after the movie adaptation made John Cusack their avatar, the once-inescapable and now-obscure archetype of the music snob is being reissued. Hulu's charming *High Fidelity* reboot stars Zoë Kravitz in a 10-episode riff on the ways that music culture—and the preposterously learned, list-making taste cops intrinsic to it—has changed in the era of AirPods. The first law of post-snob snobbery: Speak before you Shazam.

A telling early scene in the old *High Fidelity* saw Barry, the bombastic employee of Cusack's Rob, repel a would-be customer searching for Stevie Wonder's "I Just Called to Say I Love You." Barry decreed the single "sentimental, tacky crap," saying the middle-aged man who asked for it "offended me with his terrible taste." The equivalent moment in the 2020 version arrives when Cherise, the Barry-update played with delicious verve by Da'Vine Joy Randolph, calls out an iced-coffee-drinking bro who has strolled into the Brooklyn record store owned by Kravitz's Robin. He holds up his phone to ID the song that's playing. "You do know there's an actual person standing right here in front of you?" Cherise says before launching into a semi-castigating, semi-flirtatious sermon that irritates its target so much, he leaves. She isn't out to shame the Shazamer so much as to connect with him. "The problem with these kids," Cherise yells afterward, "is that the generation has completely fucked off."

A less perceptive reboot would simply have made Ed Sheeran the new sentimental, tacky crap, but Hulu

has gone beyond grafting contemporary references onto Hornby's tale of 30-somethings who are more adept at sequencing mixtapes than at maintaining healthy relationships. The series captures a fundamental reorientation in listening these days: Elitist condescension about musical preferences isn't cool anymore, but maybe—die-hard fans fear—obsessing and connecting over music are no longer cool either. Barry-types once used their taste to prop themselves above the less erudite, mainstream-minded listeners they mocked. Cherise, by contrast, just wants to chat about a song—and the consumer, cozy in a private digital bubble, decidedly does not.

The much-discussed "death of the snob" in the internet era explains part of the shift on display. Even though some *High Fidelity*-style shops catering to vinyl collectors have survived the extinction of big-box retailers, streaming and downloads have chipped away at the super-listener's pretexts for arrogance: special knowledge (entire discographies are now explorable with a click), special access (few B sides can hide from Google), and curatorial chops (algorithms can DJ your life). Cloistered listening has become more common, as Spotify and the omnipresent earbud turn an entire art form into an on-demand, all-you-can-stream personal utility. Meanwhile, many of the remaining gatekeepers have mellowed into "poptimists" who say Taylor Swift and Radiohead can be equally worthy of praise and exegesis. Ideals of inclusivity—not exactly a trademark of the straight-white-male audiophiles of the original *High Fidelity*—have driven that change.

The 2020 record store's denizens—two women of color and a gay white man—seem to realize that hierarchical edicts are out. Certainly the staff is nicer than the old guard was. Barry and Rob squabbled so acridly that they nearly came to blows; their descendants banter with noticeable sensitivity and esprit de corps. Outsiders, in fact, are surprised at how agreeable the crew is. One guy Robin goes on a date with, upon learning that she owns a record store, asks if she'll walk out on him for enjoying Fleetwood Mac's "Dreams." Robin, as it happens, loves the song, though she's iffy on its album, *Rumours*. The tension and humor of the scene then turn on whether she's *too* voluble in her analysis of a band she was expected to disdain. Intensity, rather than pretension, defines her. She's a geek more than a snob.

Not that these characters aren't snobs in other cultural arenas. Generally they hate the superficial: overpriced coffee shops, selfie-taking influencers, and other lifestyle-as-branding trends. Cherise never says it, but you can guess that she worries the Shazamer will simply add the song—which she'd no doubt fastidiously selected—to some chill-out playlist, rather than engage more deeply. Such anxieties fit

A less perceptive reboot would simply have made Ed Sheeran the new sentimental, tacky crap.

with a commonly heard refrain from today's artists and critics that streaming devalues music economically and spiritually. Robin even seems a bit smug about her store's obsolescence. "Half the neighborhood thinks we're washed-up relics," she says. "The other half thinks we're nostalgic hipsters. They're both kind of right."

So how are we to think about the key motto—"What really matters is what you like, not what you *are* like"—referenced in all three versions of *High Fidelity*? Hornby's aphorism might sound outdated in the era of identity politics, when Twitter's brawls over art can make independent aesthetic judgments seem secondary to proudly lining up with one's tribe. Hulu's *High Fidelity* does, refreshingly, correct the exclusionary spirit that went with the original's lack of diversity. Yet crucially, the series retains the assurance that music preferences reflect something individual, ineffable, soul-deep, and in need of sharing. Kravitz's Robin—a brooding biracial and bisexual space cadet enamored of the Beastie Boys, Stevie Wonder's *Talking Book*, and the folk singer Nick Drake—eludes any image neatly tied to race, gender, or sexuality. In one hilarious subplot that highlights taste as an idiosyncratic proxy for identity, Cherise posts a flyer looking for bandmates in sync with her ideal sound: "Think Brian Eno producing Beyoncé fronting Soul Coughing but with Daniel Ash on guitar."

Such fervent eclecticism is countercultural in any era, because by definition it flouts paradigms. Here it represents another way in which the new *High Fidelity* audiophiles feel they have, as Cherise puts it at one point, "opted out" of their own algorithm-obedient generation. But they're not quite the oddballs they think they are. Genre boundaries have been melting in popular music lately, and the quest for self-definition through sound is no niche practice. As I write this, my social feeds are full of people sharing their personalized Spotify report on their most-listened-to songs of the year. Some users are LOLing at the quirkiness of their habits (one friend's top five artists of 2019 included ultra-glossy contemporary country, hard-edged underground rap, and the Barenaked Ladies). Others cheekily revel in the stereotypes it turns out they've fallen into ("so gay," texts someone whose No. 1 was Carly Rae Jepsen). I'm not seeing a lot of mockery; I am seeing a lot of curiosity, amusement, and discussion. The tools of *High Fidelity*'s rankers and curators have been democratized, and of course not everyone is going to use them for esoteric adventures. If you've got a problem with that, you might be a snob. *A*

Spencer Kornhaber is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

THE MULATTA UNMASKS HERSELF TO HER HUSBAND *Edinburgh, 1826*

By Shara McCallum

For all the faith in argument in principle in reason
for all the books you hand me bid me read
for all in the dark I pretend
for all the pursuit of equality of righteousness and good
for all the rights of man the vindication of woman
for all in the dark I pretend we are
for all the moral cause abolition the struggle for freedom
for all in the dark I pretend we are just
for all the history of heroes and foes the victors and
the vanquished
for all the talk and talk and talk
for all in the dark I pretend we are just one soul
what would it mean at last to see
not Love not Truth not Beauty but who
has been in your house who sleeping in your bed?

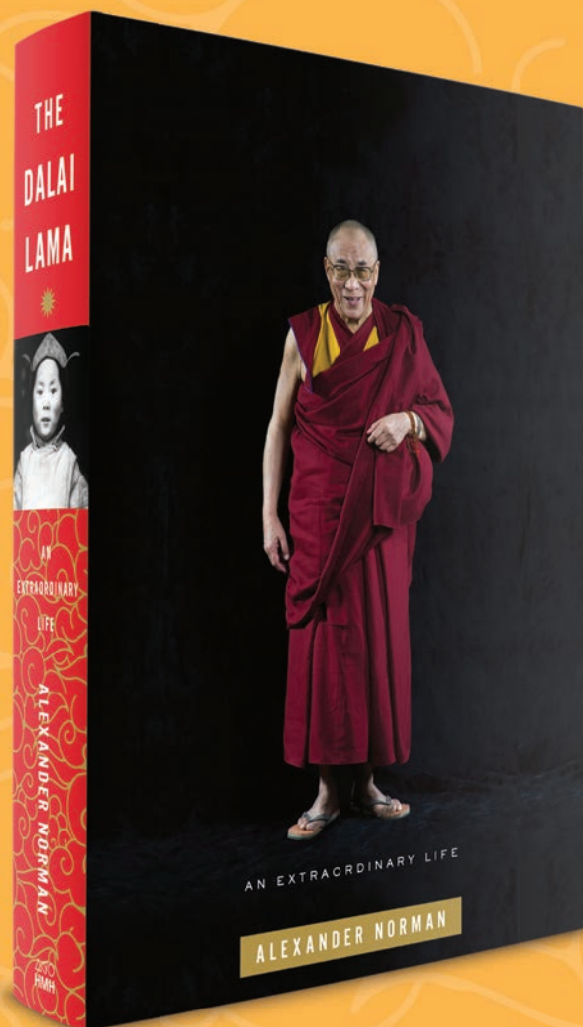
Shara McCallum's most recent book is Madwoman, which was the poetry winner of the 2018 OCM Bocas Prize for Caribbean Literature. This poem is from her forthcoming book No Ruined Stone, an imagined account of the Scottish poet Robert Burns's planned migration to Jamaica for a job that involved supervising enslaved Africans on a plantation.

THE DALAI LAMA

AN EXTRAORDINARY LIFE

“ALEXANDER NORMAN’S BOOK IS A REVELATION,
placing the Dalai Lama in a vividly told historical context while giving
the reader an intimate glimpse of the man himself.”

—JIM KELLY, *AIR MAIL*



THE FIRST AUTHORITATIVE BIOGRAPHY OF THE DALAI LAMA

A story by turns inspiring and shocking—from acclaimed
Tibetan scholar Alexander Norman

ON SALE FEBRUARY 25, 2020

HMHBOOKS.COM





BOOKS

The Supreme Court's Enduring Bias

Over the past half century, siding with the powerful against the vulnerable has been the rule in almost every area of the law.

By Michael O'Donnell

A template for popular books about the Supreme Court has emerged since Bob Woodward and Scott Armstrong's *The Brethren* was published in 1979. It goes like this: Interweave case histories with biographical material on the justices and add anecdotes about their unseemly horse-trading. Then pack in as much gossip as you can. Journalists including Jeffrey Toobin, Jan Crawford Greenburg, Marcia Coyle, and Joan Biskupic have mastered this form, producing books that are both entertaining and illuminating. Better still are judicial biographies that use the historical record to present seminal cases and the people—litigants and lawyers, as well as justices—who shaped them. Two outstanding examples are Linda Greenhouse's *Becoming Justice Blackmun* and Seth Stern and Stephen Wermiel's *Justice Brennan: Liberal Champion*. These books function like windows in a brick wall. The Court does its work in private, and the public understandably wants to know more.

Adam Cohen, a former member of the *New York Times* editorial board, has dispensed with these conventions and written a book that is almost pure law. *Supreme Inequality: The Supreme Court's Fifty-Year Battle for a More Unjust America* does not pander to readers or mug for their attention. Occasionally a justice will get a brief sketch, but it is little more than what you could find in his or her entry on the Supreme Court Historical Society's website. Cohen deals in cases and their impact on the country. He acknowledges the risk of a volume that is all medicine and no sugar, quoting a public-interest advocate who notes that the public has largely missed the harm the Court has been doing, because “issues like class-action rules and preemption and arbitration” can make “most people fall asleep.”

Yet in this age of the judge as celebrity, the decision to focus not on the personalities of the Court but rather on the ideas that fill its opinions has obvious allure. I admire Ruth Bader Ginsburg as much as the next feminist, but I have seen enough movies about her for now. The late Antonin Scalia developed such a cult of personality among Federalist Society members that he felt emboldened to make an obscene gesture to a reporter and did not recuse himself from a case in which his impartiality was in serious question. And most recently, Brett Kavanaugh's confirmation hearings caused some Court watchers to turn away in disgust. Given individual justices who can sometimes seem too big for their robes, Cohen's wonky emphasis on cases rather than characters offers a steady perspective. After all, the ideas at stake in Supreme Court decisions are what touch our daily lives.

Cohen takes as his subject the Supreme Court's trajectory, and its footprint, since Earl Warren's rights revolution of the 1950s and '60s. The Court, Cohen

suggests, is more influential in shaping national life than many Americans realize. Blockbuster decisions such as *Bush v. Gore* of course make headlines and attract widespread attention. But Cohen seeks to explore the Court's place in government in a coherent, structural sense—and the role it plays deeply troubles him:

The Supreme Court is more than a legal tribunal, ruling on disputes between parties—it is also an architect. The Court's interpretations of the Constitution and other laws become blueprints for the nation, helping to determine what form it will take and how it will continue to rise. For the past half-century, the Court has been drawing up plans for a more economically unequal nation, and that is the America that is now being built.

IN OUR CIVIC IMAGINATION, the Supreme Court protects the downtrodden and safeguards fairness. EQUAL JUSTICE UNDER LAW read the words over the Court's entrance; JUSTICE THE GUARDIAN OF LIBERTY proclaims the building's eastern facade. This is the noble dimension of the Court's identity, which the justices emphasize to the citizenry. Cohen disdains it as self-congratulatory cant, describing the Warren Court's egalitarianism as an exception rather than the rule. The modern Court has more frequently protected the interests of wealthy elites than of minorities and the vulnerable. Cohen writes that in the 50 years since Warren Burger replaced Earl Warren, "the Court has, with striking regularity, sided with the rich and powerful against the poor and weak, in virtually every area of the law."

As these lines suggest, *Supreme Inequality* is ambitious in scope. Cohen describes the erosion of individual protections and the amplification of corporate power in areas as diverse as criminal justice, business and employment law, and voting rights. He structures sections of the book as lessons in retrenchment: What the Warren Court hath given, the Burger, Rehnquist, and Roberts Courts hath taken away. For example, Cohen's chapters on poverty law trace the descent from Warren Court cases such as *King v. Smith*, which struck down a state rule that allowed authorities to terminate the welfare benefits of a single woman with children if a man regularly stayed with her, to Burger Court opinions such as *Dandridge v. Williams*, which upheld a Maryland rule that capped welfare payments regardless of the number of children in a family. Similarly, in his section on voting rights, Cohen shows how the Court regressed from the Warren Court's seminal *Baker v. Carr* decision, which asserted the Court's jurisdiction over political redistricting, to the

recent *Rucho v. Common Cause*, which ruled partisan-gerrymandering questions "nonjusticiable" and therefore beyond the justices' purview. A key factor in the poverty and voting case trends has been raw political power: whether Democrat- or Republican-appointed justices hold the majority.

One of *Supreme Inequality's* strengths is Cohen's ability to spot parallels and draw connections for readers over a range of legal disciplines. This signposting is essential for a book that covers so much ground. Take his discussion of the controversial 2010 decision *Citizens United v. FEC*, which famously invalidated a federal law prohibiting corporations from spending money to support or denounce political candidates (while still forbidding direct contributions to them). Cohen contrasts the Court's solicitude for corporate speech with its unwillingness to protect ordinary citizens wishing to post campaign signs or distribute political leaflets in public spaces:

When the wealthy and powerful wanted to use their money to influence elections, the Court swept aside an elaborate campaign finance regime that had been enacted by Congress and signed by the president, responding to strong popular demand, to help a nation heal after a scandal [Watergate] that went all the way to the White House. When poor and middle-class people challenged bans on their ability to hand out leaflets or post campaign signs, the Court suppressed their speech, out of deference to Postal Service mailbox rules and municipal concerns about clutter.

Another, more striking example of Cohen's cross-categorical trend-spotting compares the Court's Eighth Amendment case law on "cruel and unusual punishments" with its due-process decisions on excessive punitive-damages awards against large companies. In 2003, the Court refused to upset a 25-years-to-life sentence, under California's three-strikes law, for a man who shoplifted about \$150 worth of videotapes. However, just a month later, the Court overturned a \$145 million punitive-damages award against an insurance company for egregious conduct toward a customer, finding it disproportionate to the actual harm incurred. (The insurance company refused to allow a customer to settle a lawsuit with third parties on the promise that it would cover the bill if he lost at trial, but then, when he did, it refused to pay.) "The Court had two very different ideas about proportionality of punishment," Cohen writes: "one for corporations under the Fourteenth Amendment Due Process Clause and another for people under the Eighth Amendment."

This is a sobering juxtaposition, but in making it, Cohen risks populist overreach. Rather than arguing that both the three-strikes case and the

Cohen describes the erosion of individual protections and the amplification of corporate power.

punitive-damages case should have come out differently, Cohen might consider that only one of the cases was decided incorrectly. A 25-year sentence for shoplifting does seem grossly inequitable. But that does not make draconian punishments of companies just. As he concedes, the concerns animating the Court's punitive-damages decisions have attracted liberal justices as well as conservative ones. Justice John Paul Stevens, a great progressive who wrote one of the first decisions striking down an excessive award (it was 500 times the size of the actual damages), harbored legitimate misgivings about a result like that and what it says about due-process principles such as fairness and notice.

In addition to spotting trends, Cohen plays out the consequences of Supreme Court decisions beyond daily headlines. For example, he writes that with amplified political influence, corporations pursue policies that favor their interests, often at the expense of consumers and workers. He follows the line from *Citizens United* to the defeat of minimum-wage increases and the enactment of state right-to-work laws, which weaken unions by preventing them from requiring workers to pay dues. When a minimum-wage bill was voted down in the Senate in 2014, it was by all appearances a failure of the political branches. "No one thought to blame the Court," Cohen writes, "even though it was its decades of campaign finance rulings that made the billionaires' wishes count for so much and public opinion count for so little." This is a fair point, if somewhat stretched. Voters did, after all, elect the senators who failed to pass the minimum-wage bill, and unions have been shrinking in influence and political power for generations.

COHEN MAKES a respectable case that the Court has protected the powerful at the expense of the vulnerable, but he downplays lines of case law that undercut his thesis. The result is a book that is frequently persuasive but overly pessimistic. He devotes only a few paragraphs to watershed gender-equality and gay-rights decisions that future generations may someday view as the *Brown v. Boards* of our time. He also overlooks an enormously consequential series of cases from 2004 to 2008 that restrained the Bush administration's excesses at Guantánamo Bay. The question of the limits on executive power to protect national security during wartime is one the justices consider only rarely; the previous major precedent was issued in 1952. For a structuralist like Cohen, having opinions on the books that limit an overreaching president should be big news. Yet *Rasul v. Bush*, *Hamdan v. Rumsfeld*, and *Boumediene v. Bush* do not receive mention in *Supreme Inequality*.

This unevenness shows up in the book's rhetoric as well. Although Cohen is relentlessly substantive, his arguments can sometimes veer toward newsroom hot

takes and away from scholarly reflection. President Richard Nixon "killed off the liberal Warren Court." The Court "rescued another corporate bad actor from a jury's damage award." Its rulings "have saved corporations many billions of dollars that otherwise would have gone to people they had injured or cheated." It is even moving the country in the direction of "two distinct totalitarian nightmares" (complete surveillance and a prison state). Ultimately, Cohen writes, "the Court had not merely stopped its efforts to lift the boots of oppression off the necks of the poor; it had also gotten in some kicks of its own." With these strident lines and more like them, Cohen will put off many readers.

That last point, with its overheated language straight out of Orwell, reveals an ironic limitation of a book that declines to follow the justices into their conference room for a little backstage dish. Cohen's stridency occurs in a discussion of the Court's 2012 decision that upheld the Affordable Care Act's individual mandate. Along the way, seven members of the Court voted to strike down the ACA's expansion of Medicaid. That was one of the kicks against the poor that Cohen charges the Court with delivering. But as we learn more about the case, it appears that two of those seven votes, by the liberal justices Elena Kagan and Stephen Breyer, may have been cast in return for Chief Justice John Roberts's crucial vote to uphold the individual mandate. Kagan's and Breyer's pragmatism may well have bought enough goodwill from the chief justice to save health care for millions of Americans.

Was their decision a worthy trade-off—or should judges be doctrinal absolutists in the tradition of Ginsburg and Scalia? That is a discussion worth having, but Cohen closes off debate by resorting to the crude imagery of boots on necks. Moreover, by declining to examine the shifting allegiances and conflicting views of the justices as they grind out the Court's sausage, Cohen also eclipses hope. The Supreme Court is not returning to the crusading liberalism of the Warren Court anytime soon. That leaves the pragmatism of dealmakers like Kagan and Breyer as the best chance for legal progressives to eke out wins, one case at a time.

But strategy aside, the Court's central role in our politics and public life is beyond question, especially as dysfunction paralyzes Congress and the presidency. Renewing our focus on the substance of the Court's business—its individual decisions as well as their cumulative effect—is hard work, and more vital than ever. *A*

Michael O'Donnell is a lawyer in the Chicago area. His work has appeared in The New York Times, The Wall Street Journal, and The Economist.

SUPREME
INEQUALITY:
THE SUPREME
COURT'S FIFTY-
YEAR BATTLE FOR
A MORE UNJUST
AMERICA

Adam Cohen

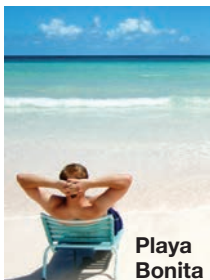
PENGUIN PRESS



Gamboa Rainforest Resort



Panama Canal, Gaillard Cut



Playa Bonita



Panama City



Red-Eyed Tree Frog



Pollera Dancer

It's Caravan's Panama Canal Cruise & Tour! 2020 Is Your Year to Go. Call Now for Choice Dates.

Panama 8-Day Tour \$1295

+ tax, fees. USD

Rainforests, Beaches, Panama Canal Cruise

You are invited to Panama on a fully guided tour with Caravan. Includes all hotels, all meals, and all activities, plus take two cruises on the Panama Canal. **caravan**

Day 1 Panama City, Panama

Welcome to fun, vibrant Panama. Caravan provides airport transfers.

Day 2 Old Panama, Miraflores

Visit the ruins of Panama Viejo (Old Panama), the city founded by the Spanish in 1519. Visit the Canal Museum at Miraflores, overlooking the Panama Canal locks. Learn about the Canal construction and operation.

Day 3 Panama Canal Cruise

Boat ride on Gatun Lake. See the lush jungle watershed region of the Panama Canal. Cruise through jungle canals and by hilltop islands. Look for monkeys. Enjoy a relaxing two night stay at your resort located in the rainforest.

Day 4 Panama Canal Cruise

Today an unforgettable adventure as you cruise more of the Panama Canal. Cruise by the Bridge of the Americas, pass through Miraflores and Pedro Miguel Locks, and cross the Continental Divide. Get up-close views of the canal locks.

Day 5 Embera Tribe, Playa Bonita

Cruise on the Chagres River to visit an Embera tribal village. The Embera inhabit the rainforests of Panama. Then, visit a live jungle sloth exhibition. Continue to your beach hotel for a relaxing two night stay on the Pacific Coast.

Day 6 Playa Bonita

Entire day at leisure to enjoy your beach resort. Swim in your hotel's infinity pool. Time to beachcomb and enjoy your resort's amenities.

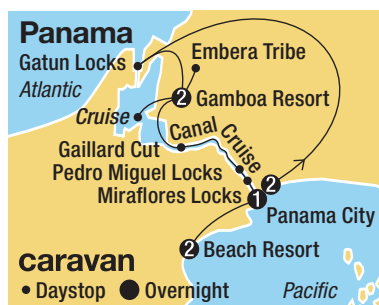
Day 7 Handicrafts, Museum

Visit a Kuna tribal marketplace. Shop for colorful mola embroidery and handicrafts. Visit the Museum of Biodiversity, designed by Frank Gehry. Enjoy a farewell dinner.

Day 8 Panama City

Tour ends after breakfast at your hotel. Caravan provides airport transfers. Hasta la Vista—Thanks for vacationing with Caravan!

Full Itinerary at caravan.com



Hotels - listed by day

- 1, 2 **Panama City** Marriott Courtyard
- 3, 4 **Gamboa** Rainforest Resort
- 5, 6 **Playa Bonita** Westin Resort
- 7 **Panama City** InterContinental Miramar

Dear Vacation Traveler.

Welcome to a great vacation at an affordable price. These quality tours feature complete sightseeing, professional tour directors, and great itineraries. Discover for yourself why smart shoppers and experienced travelers choose Caravan. Happy Travels! **caravan**

About Caravan Tours

Caravan began selling fully guided tours in 1952. We have been under the same family management and ownership ever since.



The Golden Frog, Panama's National Animal, Brings You Good Luck

TM

Choose An Affordable Tour

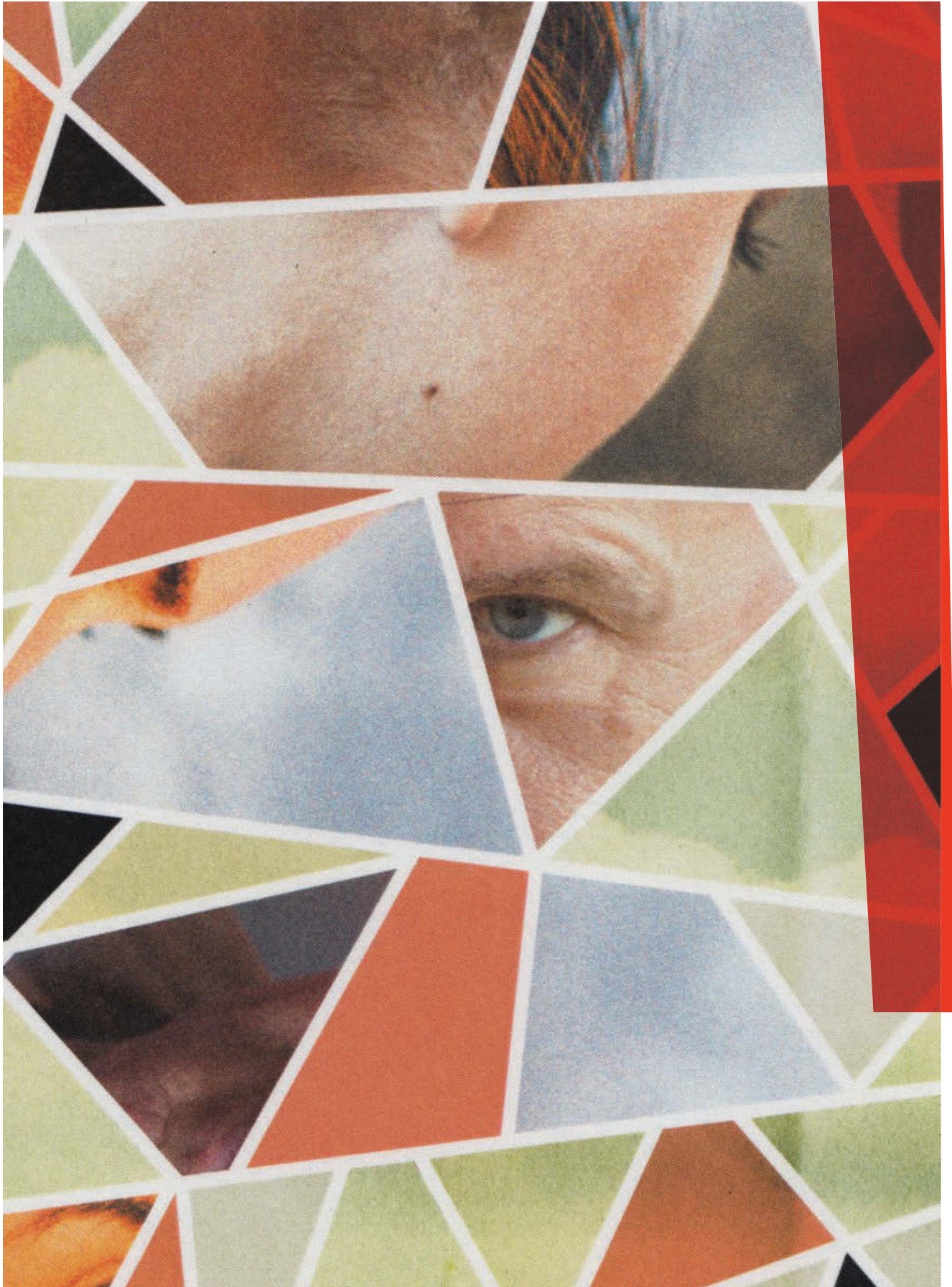
Costa Rica	9 days	\$1295
Panama & Canal	8 days	\$1295
Guatemala w/ Tikal	10 days	\$1395
Yellowstone	8 days	\$1495
Grand Canyon	8 days	\$1595
California Coast	9 days	\$1995
New England	8 days	\$1595
Canadian Rockies	9 days	\$1995
Nova Scotia & PEI	10 days	\$1695
Per Person U.S. Dollars, + tax, fees, airfare		

FREE 24 Page Brochure
1-800-caravan
caravan.com



caravan

FULLY GUIDED TOURS SINCE 1952



The Art of Second Chances

In Emily St. John Mandel's disaster-steeped fiction, a derailed life can take multiple forms.

By Ruth Franklin

Writing in *The New York Times* in June 2003, less than two years after the events of September 11 shattered the complacency with which many Americans conducted their lives, the British critic Michael Pye lamented an unlikely casualty of the new era: the ability to occupy ourselves with a superficial novel while sitting in an airport lounge or drifting at 30,000 feet. With tanks now standing guard at London's Heathrow Airport, what was once an ordinary plane trip had acquired "an element of thoroughly unwanted suspense." The usual reading material, Pye argued, would no longer do. "We stand in need of something stronger now: the travel book you can read while making your way through this new, alarming world."

The Canadian writer Emily St. John Mandel used these lines as an epigraph to her second novel, *The Singer's Gun* (2010), a book haunted by 9/11. But her entire body of work—her new novel, *The Glass Hotel*, is her fifth—can be read as a response to Pye's demand. Mandel's deeply imagined, philosophically profound reckonings with life in an age of disaster would indeed be appropriate companions alongside a plastic cup of wine and a tray of reheated food (if we're lucky). But they are equally welcome at home during anxious days of following the news cycle or insomniac nights of worrying about the future. "You can make an argument that the world's become more bleak, but I feel like we always think we're living at the end of the world," Mandel said in a recent interview at the University of Central Florida. "When have we ever felt like it wasn't going to be catastrophic?"

That sense of cataclysm most dramatically pervades *Station Eleven*, Mandel's breakout 2014 novel about a vicious pandemic known as the Georgia Flu that sweeps the globe with astonishing speed (most of those infected are dead within a day or two), killing more than 99 percent of the Earth's population. With so few people left to keep systems running, civilization collapses. Mandel offers an "incomplete list" of modern essentials that quickly cease to exist: electricity, countries with borders, the internet, fire departments. "No more diving into pools of chlorinated water lit green from below. No more ball games played out under floodlights. No more porch lights with moths fluttering on summer nights. No more trains running under the surface of cities on the dazzling power of the electric third rail. No more cities." The novel proceeds with its own impeccable, funereal logic. A nearsighted man who loses his glasses is unable to replace them; after the world's gasoline supply goes stale, pickup trucks, retrofitted with wheels of metal and wood, are pulled by horses. The immersion in Mandel's fictional world is so complete that more than once while reading *Station Eleven*, I found myself looking around to make sure life as I knew it still continued.

Although the details of the pandemic are sketched in a few heartbreaking scenes, Mandel is less interested in the unfolding of the catastrophe itself than in its impact on the survivors and their descendants, who are still trying to make sense of it 20 years later. Dystopic discontinuity, though, turns out not to be her theme at all. Twenty-eight-year-old Kirsten, one of the book's multiple protagonists—their nonlinear narratives appear in shards that the reader pieces together—is an actor with the Traveling Symphony, a troupe that makes its way between towns with names like New Phoenix, performing Shakespeare's plays and classical music, because "people want what was best about the world." An older businessman named Clark, who gets stranded in an airport during the crisis and builds an encampment there with a group of fellow passengers, transforms an airline lounge into the "Museum of Civilization," filled with artifacts of the old world that no longer have use: a driver's license, a credit card, a pair of high-heeled shoes. Everyone in the post-disaster world is tormented by the ever present reminders of luxuries and conveniences they no longer enjoy, even people who are too young to remember them. (Kirsten, whose memories of her childhood are hazy, at one point wonders whether refrigerators had light bulbs inside.) But the book ultimately makes a beautiful argument for the endurance of art—music, theater, literature—in drastic times. "Because survival is insufficient," the quote painted on the Traveling Symphony's caravan proclaims. (Yes, it's from *Star Trek*.)

A finalist for a National Book Award, *Station Eleven* is one of the most imaginatively coherent novels I have read in recent years, skipping among characters and time periods with complete authorial control as it builds its own fully realized universe. For this reason, I was initially astonished, several chapters into *The Glass Hotel*, to recognize a minor character from that novel: Leon Prevant, the shipping executive who employs as his assistant the young Miranda, an artist who spends her downtime in the office drawing the graphic novel about a castaway in outer space that gives *Station Eleven* its title. Later he is joined by Miranda herself, whom Mandel's readers will remember last encountering on a beach in Malaysia, succumbing to the delirium of the Georgia Flu. Yet here she is, alive and well, her destiny altered but all her other characteristics intact. What are they doing in this new novel? The answer, it emerges, is essential to Mandel's fictional project, which *The Glass Hotel* expands in surprising and powerful ways.

IF *STATION ELEVEN* is a mosaic—we see the outlines of the picture nearly at once, but precisely how the pieces fit together appears later—*The Glass Hotel* is a jigsaw puzzle missing its box. At the book's start, what exactly it is about or even who the major figures are is unclear. The novel opens with a mysterious, fragmented monologue dated 2018 and titled "Vincent in the Ocean," spoken by someone of indeterminate gender who could be either dreaming or drowning; the first line is "Begin at the end." That section breaks off abruptly and the next jumps nearly two decades earlier, to late December 1999, with the focus on Vincent's half brother, Paul. At age 23, he's finally made it to the University of Toronto after years of trouble with drugs, but he's on the cusp of flunking out in his first semester. One night at a club, he accidentally slips an acquaintance a bad pill, and the boy dies on the dance floor, sending Paul into free fall.

Five years later, Paul seems to have his life back together. He and Vincent are on the night staff of a luxury hotel newly constructed on a remote British Columbia island where they spent their early childhood—a traumatic interlude, in different ways, for both of them. (We learn that Vincent, the product of an affair that ruptured the marriage of Paul's parents, is female—she was named after Edna St. Vincent Millay—and was sent away at age 13, after her mother disappeared one afternoon while canoeing, either by accident or by suicide.) Now, after the half-siblings have been reunited, someone scrawls a threatening message late one night on one of the hotel's huge glass windows with an acid marker. That the culprit is Paul is immediately obvious, both to the others at the hotel and to the reader. But the meaning of the

*How many
reinventions
are possible
for any given
person?*

THE GLASS
HOTEL

Emily St. John
Mandel

KNOPF

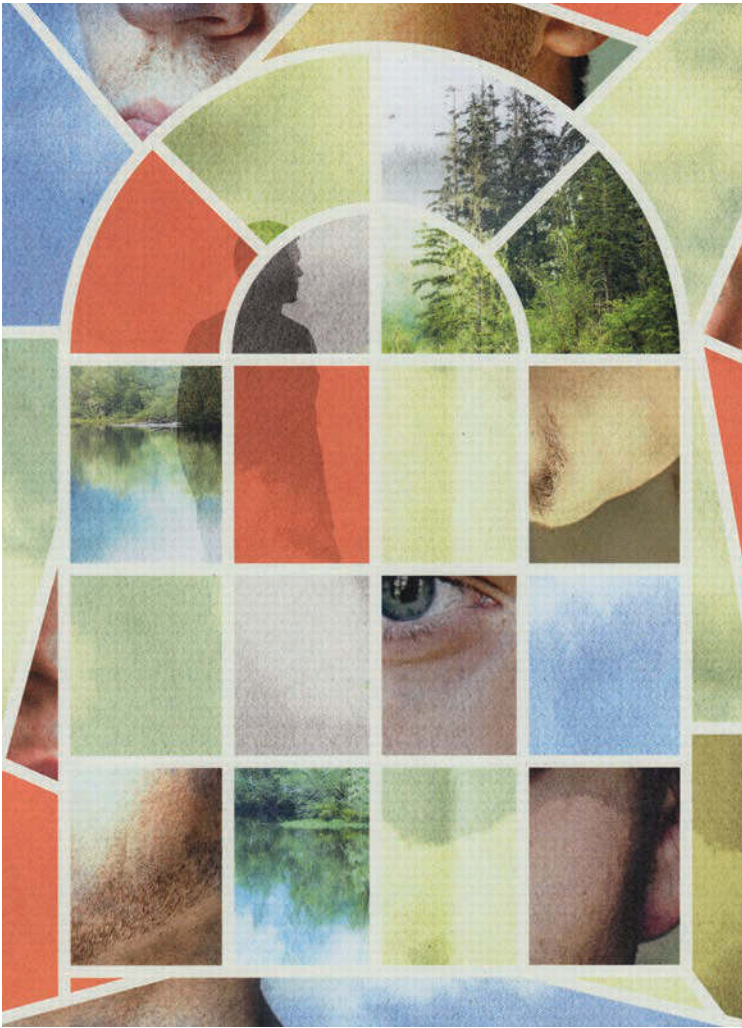
message Paul wrote, and the reason he wrote it, will remain obscure until nearly the novel's end.

How many second chances, how many reinventions, how many transformations are possible for any given person? What are the forces that keep us moving along our current path and not a different one? In *Station Eleven*, in which the course of everyone's life is altered by the disaster, a violinist with the Traveling Symphony contemplates the idea that an infinite number of parallel universes could exist, including ones in which the pandemic was less fatal or never took place, and in which he might have grown up to be a physicist, as he had planned. In *The Glass Hotel*, the forces that catapult characters from one possible life into another are the more usual ones: crime, tragedy, marriage. Sometimes we choose to plunge into a different world; sometimes a different world chooses us.

The night Paul defaces the window, Vincent meets the hotel's owner, Jonathan Alkaitis—an obscenely rich financier, recently widowed—and the once rebellious teenager slips into a new life with him almost as easily as putting on a new pair of shoes. She thinks of the world he inhabits as "the kingdom of money," and the two chapters chronicling her relationship with Alkaitis are titled "A Fairy Tale." But all fairy tales come to an end. Vincent's stay in the kingdom will be temporary. (Alkaitis works in the Gradia Building, a name that readers of *Station Eleven* will recognize as a sign that something terrible is taking place inside.) Leon Prevant, the shipping executive from *Station Eleven*, will find his circumstances utterly altered by the loss of his life savings. Instead of retiring in contentment to Florida, he and his wife abandon their home and take to the road in an RV, joining a "shadow country" inhabited by transients like themselves.

And Alkaitis, after committing crimes that earn him a lifetime prison sentence and the contempt of everyone he was once close to, finds respite from his daily existence in elaborate fantasies about how things might have gone differently—fantasies that occupy more and more of his waking hours and ultimately threaten his grip on reality. He comes to view the line between memory and imagination as a "permeable border"; he can exist simultaneously in one world and another. Other characters similarly wrestle with the notion that two contradictory ideas can coexist, if uncomfortably. Oskar, one of Alkaitis's employees, will testify in court that "it's possible to both know and not know something." As a defense for what Alkaitis did, that is inadequate, but in some ways it is also true.

IN CONTRAST to the elegiac mood of *Station Eleven*, with its longing for a never-to-be-recovered past,



The Glass Hotel moves forward propulsively, its characters continually on the run. Still, the harder they try to escape their histories, the more persistently they are pulled back, often by visions of the people they've wronged. These ghosts are not emissaries come to do malice or wreak vengeance, as we usually imagine them to be; they are physical manifestations of guilty consciences. (*Station Eleven* dealt almost humorously with the idea of a spirit world: "Are you asking if I believe in ghosts?" one character says. "Of course not. Imagine how many there'd be" is the response.) They are also an anchor to the past, however unwanted that may be, especially for those who have left behind a life they would be happier forgetting.

Oskar, Alkatis's employee, calls his own fantasies of how things might have gone differently a "ghost version" of his life. Alkatis calls his alternative version a "counterlife," which Mandel also uses as a title for the latter parts of his story. It's an explicit reference to Philip Roth's novel of the same title, in which multiple characters experience different versions of their own lives, some of which are chronicled in a

manuscript-within-the-book. Among other things, the device functions to poke fun at some readers' assumptions that Roth's books are autobiographical—an alternative version of his own life.

Mandel's purpose, as I understand it, is different. "We move through this world so lightly," Leon's wife says at one point, a remark that could refer both to how unencumbered the two of them are (few possessions, no family) and to the human condition more generally, each individual life ever able to alter its orbit in an unpredictable direction. If anything can happen in life, if anything is possible, then the novel form—which takes those possibilities and multiplies them on a metaphysical scale—becomes the ultimate way to express those variations. That's precisely why Mandel has brought back characters from her previous novel and spun them in a new direction: to demonstrate the infinite possibilities available to a writer of fiction. (David Mitchell is another contemporary novelist who has used this technique to similar effect.)

The structure of *The Glass Hotel* is virtuosic, as the fragments of the story coalesce by the end of the narrative into a richly satisfying shape. There are wonderful moments of lyricism, such as the monologue by Vincent that both opens and closes the novel, and another section titled "The Office Chorus," narrated by a group of Alkatis's employees—an especially brilliant touch. But for the most part Mandel's language is understated, fading almost invisibly to serve the familiar pleasures of character and plot. Despite the initial disorientation of its kaleidoscopic form, *The Glass Hotel* is ultimately as immersive a reading experience as its predecessor, finding all the necessary imaginative depth within the more realistic confines of its world.

In the first scene of *Station Eleven*, an actor playing King Lear dies onstage during the production, collapsing art into life. As the novel reminds us, many of Shakespeare's plays were originally performed against the backdrop of plague outbreaks, in which he likely lost members of his own family. One can imagine that his audiences came to the theater seeking distraction from their moment of catastrophe as well as insight into how to understand it. In our own fractured times, omniscient narrators have come to be viewed with suspicion, and an experimental minimalism often seems to be the only way to describe our lives now. Mandel's affirmation that a somewhat old-fashioned fictional model is not only relevant to our alarming new world but also deeply appropriate for it manages, remarkably, to feel both consoling and revolutionary. *A*

Ruth Franklin is the author, most recently, of Shirley Jackson: A Rather Haunted Life.

BOOKS

Abraham Lincoln's Radical Moderation

What the president understood that the zealous Republican reformers in Congress didn't

By Andrew Ferguson



In the opening days of the Civil War, long before *Saturday Night Live* appropriated the idea, Louis Trezevant Wigfall earned the distinction in Washington, D.C., of being the Thing That Wouldn't Leave. Elected to the United States Senate from Texas to fill a vacancy in 1859, Wigfall wasted no time in making himself obnoxious to his colleagues and the public alike. He was lavish in his disdain for the legislative body in which he had sought a seat. On the Senate floor, he said of the flag and, especially, the Union for which it stood, "It should be torn down and trampled upon." As the southern states broke away, Wigfall gleefully announced, "The federal government is dead. The only question is whether we will give it a decent, peaceable, Protestant burial."

By then Wigfall had been appointed to the *Confederate* congress, and the only question that occurred to many of his colleagues was why he was still bloviating from the floor of the U.S. Senate. Wigfall was worse than a mere gasbag. As Fergus M. Bordewich points out in his provocative new book, *Congress at War*, he "passed on military information to his southern friends, bought arms for the Confederacy, and swaggered around encouraging men to enlist in the secessionist forces." At last, in March 1861, Wigfall quit the U.S. capital and showed up a few weeks later in South Carolina. Commandeering a skiff after Confederate batteries opened fire on Fort Sumter, in Charleston Harbor, he rowed out to present terms for the fort's surrender. He had no authorization to do such a thing; he was simply following his passion to make trouble and get attention. He went down in history as a triple threat: a traitor, a blowhard, and a shameless buttinsky.

Wigfall, one of the many strange and colorful characters tossed up by the politics of the Civil War, typifies the time in important respects. The years leading to the Civil War, and the war itself, were political intensifiers; radicalism was rewarded and could be made to pay. This was as true of the Republican reformers who are the heroes of Bordewich's book as it is of secessionists like Wigfall.

Bordewich's ungainly subtitle—*How Republican Reformers Fought the Civil War, Defied Lincoln, Ended Slavery, and Remade America*—telegraphs the grand claims he sets out to make for a group of congressmen who mostly styled themselves as Radical Republicans. In his account, it is they who pressed for aggressive military campaigns when the will for war flagged among Abraham Lincoln's generals; who invented the financial mechanisms that funded the war; who pushed for punitive measures against the southern slaveholders; and who deserve credit (or blame!) for the birth of big government—achievements more commonly attributed to their far less radical president. A popular historian and journalist blessedly free

of academic affiliations, Bordewich is a master of the character sketch, summarizing complicated figures in a few swift phrases. But Lincoln himself never comes alive in his pages. Indeed, he scarcely appears. He lurks just offstage, stepping forward now and then to try, briefly and usually without success, to stymie the righteous zeal that propels the Radicals. The last line of the book declares that “a whole generation of politically heroic Republicans . . . led Congress to victory in the Civil War.” It’s an odd formulation—you probably thought the North won the war.

BORDEWICH HAS CHOSEN to tell his sprawling story of legislative activism and ascendancy mainly through four members of Congress: Senators Benjamin Wade of Ohio and William Pitt Fessenden of Maine, and Representatives Thaddeus Stevens of Pennsylvania and Clement Vallandigham of Ohio. Vallandigham is the only Democrat, a leader of an anti-war faction whose preference for the Union was complicated by his pro-slavery sympathies. The rest are Republicans, and two of them, Stevens and Wade, proudly called themselves Radicals and behaved accordingly. Fessenden, at one time a conservative, grew more sympathetic to the Radicals’ aims as the war dragged on.

Congressional power fell in the lap of Republicans, thanks to the departure of Wigfall and his southern colleagues; their seizing of it seems, in retrospect, less a matter of superior gamesmanship than a law of political gravity. Calling for stronger prosecution of the war, immediate liberation of the enslaved, and confiscation of all property owned by the southern belligerents, Radicals quickly took control of the Republican caucus. Perhaps, Bordewich writes, the Radicals “have something to teach us about how our government can function at its best in challenging times, and how crisis may even make it stronger.” Lesson No. 1: Get most of your opponents to leave town before you try anything.

The Radicals were quick on their feet, exploiting national turmoil to break a legislative logjam. For decades Southern Democrats, their numbers swollen by the Constitution’s infamous three-fifths clause, had blocked a series of domestic programs proposed first by the Whigs and then by their Republican successors. Here was the chance to neutralize the Democratic aversion to centralized power and advance a collectivist vision of the commercial republic, laying the foundation, Bordewich writes, “for the strong activist central government that came fully into being in the twentieth century.”

The flurry of legislating was indeed “transformative,” as Bordewich says. He points in particular to four pieces of legislation as landmarks. The Homestead Act promised 160 acres of federal land to any

citizen willing to live on it and farm it for five years. The Pacific Railway Act financed the transcontinental railroad and further opened up the western territories to white settlement. The third bill created the federal Department of Agriculture. And the Morrill Land Grant College Act would distribute federal land to states and localities for the purpose of building public institutions of higher learning dedicated to teaching agriculture and other practical arts—a miracle of democratization in the history of American education.

Yet in Bordewich’s telling, Lincoln had little to do with the ambitious measures, as if the bills were signed by autopen during coffee breaks. In fact, two of them were explicitly endorsed in the Republican platform that Lincoln ran on in 1860; he made a special plea for the Department of Agriculture in his first annual message to Congress. Bordewich also downplays the inevitable unintended consequences that accompany government expansion, even what seem to be the most benign reforms. The railway act, with its crony capitalism and funny-money bond issues, led straight to the Gilded Age and the creation of half a dozen robber-baron fortunes. Those “federal lands” that Washington gave away in the railway and homestead acts were not, except in the sneakiest sense, the federal government’s to give away; the land rush they touched off may have guaranteed the otherwise merely predictable genocide of the Native Americans already living there.

In the name of designating the Radicals as the fore-runners of contemporary liberalism, Bordewich tries to draw a continuous line from the Civil War Congress to the New Deal and the Great Society. Yet the line has too many zigs and zags and ups and downs to clinch a causal connection. And in fact, many of the features of big government (19th-century style) fell away before long. Calvin Coolidge, for instance, 60 years after the Civil War and a few years before the New Deal, oversaw a federal government that was in most respects closer in size and scope to the antebellum government than to the modern state that was soon to emerge.

IF BORDEWICH oversells the legacy of the Radicals in Congress, his more fundamental misapprehension lies elsewhere: His version of events shortchanges the greatness that humanists of all stripes—not only historians—have found in Lincoln. The problem is partly a failure to appreciate that the Radicals were kibitzers, as many legislators are. But misjudging Lincoln’s role as executive and his commitment to larger obligations is Bordewich’s more telling mistake. Lincoln the executive shouldered the responsibility to lead an entire government and, just as important, an unstable political coalition. From Radicals to reactionaries, Republicans were held together by a single strand: a hostility, varying in degree, to slavery. A

*Radicalism
is more than
a packet
of views or
policies. It is
a disposition.*

collapse of this delicate alliance—brought on by a sudden call for immediate, nationwide abolition, for instance—would have doomed the war effort.

Lincoln was required to be more cautious than a Radical congressman had to be—more *serious*, in a word. Bordewich credits the Radicals with forcing Lincoln year by year to pursue the war more savagely, culminating in the elevation of General Ulysses S. Grant in 1864. But his evidence is thin that Lincoln paid anything more than lip service to the Radicals' pleas for bloodshed. Bordewich is a particular admirer of the Joint Committee on the Conduct of the War—"this improvised vigilante committee," Lincoln called it, "to watch my movements and keep me straight." It was put together by Benjamin Wade and stocked with his fellow Radicals.

The committee researched and rushed into print massive reports after failed and sometimes catastrophic military engagements. The accounts totaled millions of words and accused officers and bureaucrats of horrifying lapses in military judgment and execution. Some of the accusations were implausible; others were all too real. Historically, the reports are invaluable. At the time, however, their primary effect was to second-guess generals disliked by the committee's majority and to advance the generals with whom the majority was politically aligned. The committee's "greatest purpose," Lincoln told a friend, "seems to be to hamper my action and obstruct military operations."

Shelby Foote, in his history of the Civil War, tells a story that illustrates why Lincoln and the Radicals were destined to be so often at odds. One evening Wade rushed to the White House to demand that Lincoln fire a weak-willed general who had failed to press the Union advantage. Lincoln asked Wade whom he should enlist to take the general's place. "Anybody!" Wade cried. "Anybody will do for you," Lincoln replied, "but I must have somebody." Lincoln had to be serious.

As Bordewich concedes, the Radicals were as bloody-minded as the Wigfalls of the world. "Nothing but actual extermination or exile or starvation will ever induce [southern rebels] to surrender," Stevens once said, in a speech Bordewich doesn't quote. There can, of course, be no moral equivalence between Stevens and a slavery apologist like Wigfall. One of them was on the side of the angels, and it wasn't Wigfall. But both were radicals.

RADICALISM IS more than a packet of views or policies. The contents of the packet will change with circumstances and over time. (One reason Bordewich admires the Radical Republicans is that their views on race are so close to current mainstream attitudes; today's radicals, valorizing group identity above all else, will likely find both the views and the politicians who held

them hopelessly retrograde.) Radicalism is a disposition. The same is true of its contrary, moderation. Lincoln's moderation was so infuriating to the Radicals because it reflected a hierarchy of values different from theirs.

The ultimate concerns for Stevens and his fellows were the liberation of the enslaved, the punishment of the enslavers, and the reorganization of southern society. The ultimate concern for Lincoln was the survival of the Union, to which he had an almost mystical attachment. The old question—was the war fought to preserve the Union or to free the slaves?—underestimates how closely the two causes were entwined in his mind. Lincoln's goal was to uphold the kind of government under which slavery could not in the end survive. This was a government, as Lincoln said, dedicated to a proposition.

In a hectoring letter written at a low point in 1863, a Radical senator insisted that Lincoln "stand firm" against conservatives in his government. It was a common complaint of the Radical Republicans that Lincoln was hesitant, easily led, timid—weak. "I hope to 'stand firm' enough to not go backward," Lincoln replied, "and yet not go forward fast enough to wreck the country's cause." Lincoln struck this balance with unmatched skill and sensitivity.

It was a feat of leadership peculiar to self-government, captured most famously by the only 19th-century American who could rival him as a prose artist and a statesman. Frederick Douglass was an enthusiastic admirer of Lincoln, once calling him, not long after the assassination, "emphatically the black man's president: the first to show any respect for their rights as men." Years later, Douglass's enthusiasm had cooled—and ripened.

Lincoln "was preeminently the white man's President, entirely devoted to the welfare of white men," Douglass now said. "Viewed from the genuine abolition ground"—the ground, that is, from which Bordewich and many of today's historians want to judge him, and the ground from which the Radicals did judge him—"Mr. Lincoln seemed tardy, cold, dull, and indifferent." Douglass knew, though, that Lincoln never claimed to govern as an abolitionist, and Douglass knew why. "But measuring him by the sentiment of his country, *a sentiment he was bound as a statesman to consult*, he was swift, zealous, radical, and determined."

The italics are mine, but the insight belongs to Douglass. Lincoln was radical without being a Radical—and never more radical than a leader can afford to be when he leads a government of, by, and for the people. *A*

Andrew Ferguson is a staff writer at The Atlantic and the author of Land of Lincoln: Adventures in Abe's America.

CONGRESS
AT WAR: HOW
REPUBLICAN
REFORMERS
FOUGHT THE
CIVIL WAR, DEFIED
LINCOLN, ENDED
SLAVERY, AND
REMADE AMERICA

Fergus M.
Bordewich

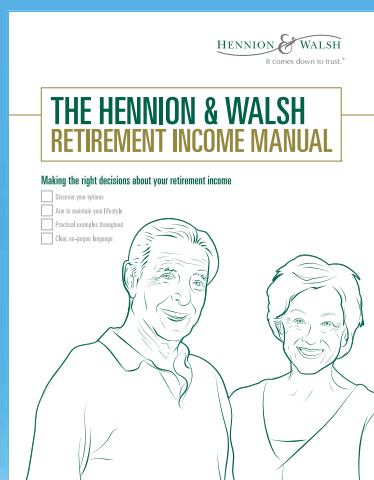
KNOPF

KEEP GETTING YOUR KICKS

Retirement Income Advice from Hennion & Walsh

The journey doesn't end with retirement – for many of us it begins. But if you want to keep getting your kicks and really enjoy those golden years, your money needs to go further than ever before. That's where Hennion & Walsh can help with our decades of experience helping clients invest for retirement income.

We've built our business on the classic American values of integrity and one-to-one service. Getting under the hood of what you really need. We'll use our decades of experience with retirement income investments, such as government, corporate and municipal bonds, preferred stock, annuities and a wide range of other investment choices to help you generate retirement income and plan the best route for your journey – whether you're already in retirement or just looking ahead.



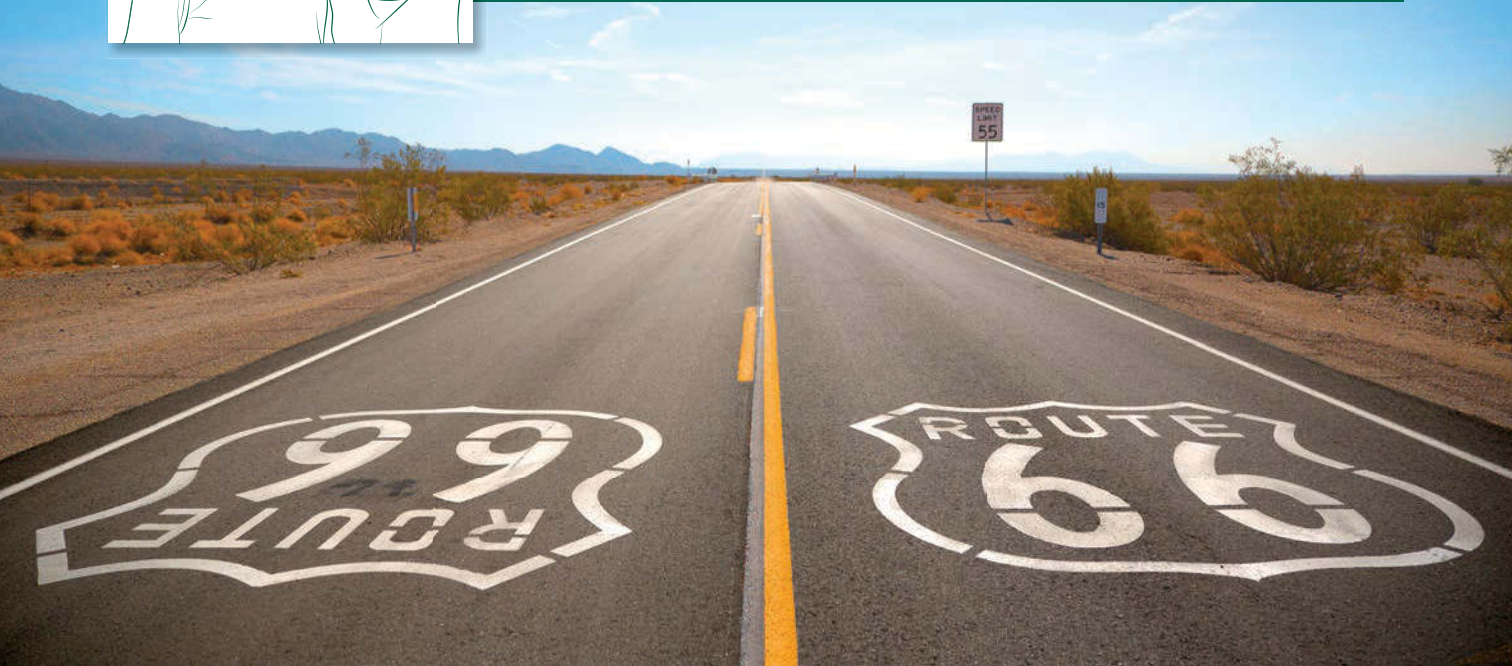
CALL (800) 804-6931 TODAY

to get your copy of the Hennion & Walsh Retirement Income Manual.

It's **FREE** and **WITHOUT OBLIGATION**.

In the Retirement Income Manual, you'll learn:

- Income investing options to consider for you and your family
- Ways to minimize the risk of running out of money in retirement
- Worksheets to help you assess how much investment income you need





Go, Team

By Samantha Hunt

“There was a woman, and everyone watched. Including me. We were at the fields where the kids play soccer. You know?”

“I’m there three times a week.”

“The place is surrounded by woods.”

“I know. Three days a week. No joke. Were the kids playing?”

“That’s why we noticed her. She walked across the field mid-game like she didn’t even see the rest of us and disappeared into the woods. The fireflies had started. Maybe 40 minutes before dark? The game must’ve been close to ending. In fact, it did end soon after.”



"I was there," another mother says. "I saw her go."

We're in L's kitchen waiting for our kids. Any minute now, goody bags and farewells, then L's kid will be one year older and alone with a new crop of toys.

"Who won?"

"Won what?"

"The game."

"I have no idea." J has two kids, two part-time jobs. She's looking for something better but hasn't found it yet. Others here work full time, or nights. The fathers are also working, jobs that we hear are less permeable than our jobs. Really our jobs are not permeable, but we lie to our employers, pretending we are not mothers, or that mothering is simple. Then, like an intricate, silent network from the natural world—say, a creek flowing to a stream, to a river, to the ocean, to the clouds, to return as rain—we rely on other mothers. Systems, delicately complex and ever-changing, carry and care for our young. "I don't remember the score. I was distracted by the woman."

"What'd she do?"

"You weren't there?"

"No."

"But you heard about it?"

"Bits."

"She crossed the field as if she didn't even see the game, like she was chasing a stray ball. Sudden and straight across. The way an animal would go. Some of the kids stopped playing. Maybe they thought she was a referee, or that there was an injury. But she ignored the kids, walked right through them and into the woods."

"What'd the kids do?"

"Started playing again. And the people watching went back to watching the game. And you know the dad?"

"The screamer?"

"Pass! Pass! Man on!" Ugh.

The worst. He went back to screaming. He knows sideline coaching's prohibited. The fucker even signed a form saying he wouldn't do it anymore."

The mothers look. Did the kids hear J curse? A secret swear among mothers feels so good—a dirty-word pressure valve and a wormhole to other lives.

"Did you say anything to him?"

"Do not talk to that man. He's nuts. I got into it with him once. Big mistake. I was like, 'Wait, do you actually care which team wins? They're 8 years old.' And he's all like, 'I love this team! I love my country!' Holy crap. He's fucking nuts. He was stomping his foot. 'It's Us versus Them!' Screaming it. 'Us versus Them!' I honestly had no idea who he was even talking about. Who's 'Us'?"

"His poor kids."

"Who's 'Them'?"

"Does he have kids?"

"I didn't talk to him," J says.

"I was watching the woman. Or I was watching the place where she'd disappeared."

"No one stopped her?"

"She's an adult."

"I'd almost say no one saw her. I mean, I saw her and others saw her, but it was like most of us didn't wonder what she meant. At least at first. You saw her."

"Yeah, but I didn't give it much thought. I had the little ones with me."

"Who is she?"

"I don't know."

"You mean you don't know her or you didn't see who it was?"

"I didn't see. I might know her."

"She could be anyone?"

"Sure."

"One of us?"

"Sure."

"Was it you?"

"No. Was it you?"

Our chatter pauses long enough for us to look at each face, to see if one of us here might walk into the woods. Dead mom, cheating spouse, raped at 14, Down's kid, nearly broke, alcoholic husband, bankrupt business, Alzheimer's dad, raped at 22, colon cancer, barely hanging on to sobriety. Each of us looks like a person who might walk into the woods and not come back.

"Ask K if she knows. She knows everyone."

"Who was it, K?"

K is eating cheesy popcorn. "Was what?"

"At the game, in the woods. You hear about this?"

"Oh yeah. Somebody told me."

"Who was she?"

"I don't know. Who?"

K is no help. We turn back to J.

"When was this?"

"Last week."

"What happened after she was gone?"

"The game was ending. I told you that. Then the game did end and, you know, folding up chairs, collecting water bottles. One of the children had to remind us. Kid says, 'That woman never came back.' And someone asked, 'How do you know she never came back?' And the kid said, 'I watched for her. She never came.' It was that midfielder. Daydreamer, you know. The kids were the only people thinking clearly. They said, 'We need to go find her. Maybe she's hurt. Maybe she's lost.' And all the adults, thinking about dinner, a bottle of wine, were like, 'Right, kids. Oh my God, the kids are totally right.' So we went into the woods. Or some of us did."

"Who didn't?"

"Not saying. But you know who."

"She's such an ass. Not you, hon. You had the little ones."

"I'm not going to drag them into the forest at night."

"No one expects you to."

"It was kind of awkward at first in the woods. Some of us were strangers. And, you know, only moments before our teams had been enemies."

"Opponents. Not enemies."

"Right. Opponents. But that changed. We had questions, like: Should we split up? Is that poison ivy? Who is she, anyway? And, you know, other questions. Some of us used the lights on our phones to see. Some had more woods experience and wanted the others to appreciate their superior scouting skills. They were, like, trying to track her. You know, the guys who grew up hunting. They were, like, looking for scat. I swear to God."

"I do not think she went into the woods to poop."

"We decided to split up, even though it was dark. But right before we split up, a mom from the other team asked very quietly, not wanting the others to hear, 'Which way did she go?' She only asked me, as if I knew or as if she wanted to go too."

"Did you find her?"

"Some lookers plunged in. Some stayed near the edge, by the fields. Maybe they were scared they'd also get lost. Or annoyed that in order to look like a good person, they'd have to help out and be late for dinner. Some people probably slipped back out to the field, to their cars. Some were calling out, 'Hello? Are you here?'"

"Was she?"

"I had the little ones."

"We know. We know. For Christ's sake."

"I mean, I'd seen her enter the forest, but we got no answer. The woods are big. I can't actually think of where those woods end."

"Do the woods end?"

"I've never seen the end. Anyway. Forget it." J looks around the kitchen, taking in the cabinetry for a moment. She places her hand flat on the table. "Yeah. Anyway. That's it. A woman walked into the woods. We looked for her and eventually we gave up. We came back. Did you cut your bangs?"

"You like?"

"Super cute. I need a haircut too." J pats the table again.

J KNOWS a woman who's a famous artist. She and the woman had grown up together, childhood friends, but now it's been years. J follows the woman's career from a distance. It's easy to, since the woman is often featured in fancy magazines or photographed wearing her uniform of gold-lamé shorts; wild, unwashed hair; leather straps; hairy pits; work boots; and makeup applied in surprising ways—say, three yellow lines across her forehead or a turquoise streak down each cheek. Sometimes the woman wears a soiled bridal veil with her gold shorts, though from what J can gather, the woman is not married.

The woman bought an abandoned house in Detroit for \$4,000. She moved into the crumbling manor with her posse. Yes, the woman has a posse, a jangly bunch of generally free spirits. Free until the woman issues a command, Fagin-style, as in: "Go get me a carved-oak dresser, an armful of red-berry branches, a petticoat, and a set of champagne

stemware. And remember, I love you, babies." A shopping list for the raw material of her art-making. The posse heads out to raid one of Detroit's other fallen beauties that, because of various downturns in the economy, have been left unpeopled, unguarded, ostensibly abandoned. The posse slips into these homes under cover of darkness and makes short work of collecting treasures that belong to the families who own these decaying homes, or used to

*She crossed the field as if she
didn't even see the game,
like she was chasing a stray ball . . .
She ignored the kids,
walked right through them
and into the woods.*

own them before the bank repossessed. It's fuzzy. The woman's posse, foragers of this misfortune, throw open attic chests, giddy with delight—thrilled with the beautiful trashlike detritus of the universe. They pile up old photo albums, yearbooks, and quilts. They return home laden with crystal dishes, phonograph cabinets, clarinets, cloches, cloaks, gold chains, religious icons, feathers, music boxes, jewels, lamps, and lipsticks. They return home with a sense that they are recycling items that would have gone to the landfill. They present these intimate signifiers of someone else's life to their queen. Bees with knees full of pollen.

On one hand, J thinks the woman's project is cool. Property, after all, is a crime. But on the other hand, what the woman does is theft, plain and simple. No one says that. None of the articles mention that. In one of the houses, they found a check signed by Martin Luther King Jr. They brought the check home and the woman posted a picture of it on Instagram. J saw it. Maybe the check would have been destroyed if the posse hadn't grabbed it. But still, there's the grabbing.

Or else, maybe J is just jealous of the woman. Maybe J wants a posse too. One that's not made up of 8-year-olds, 4-year-olds. Maybe J would also like to be recognized for the things that make her totally wild.

"DID YOU guys watch last night's—"

"Oh my God. So good. Love that show." K's picking the popcorn from her teeth.

"Could you even believe it? She's like, 'Mister, I don't even—'"

"Shut up. I had to work late. Don't spoil it."

"Oh, hon. You're in for a treat."

"Don't."

"Okay, okay."

"But I just couldn't even believe when she—"

"Wait. Can we get back to the woman?"

"Who?"

"The woman in the woods. You never found her? There's, like, a woman at large in the woods somewhere and no one cares?"

J looks reluctant, or guilty. "I walked farther into that forest than anyone."

"Were you scared?"

"It was beautiful. Green and dark blue. I'd go back. There were some briars here and there but it smelled so good, I didn't mind. That dirt smell. And there was something. The woods kept opening up more, like, *Oh, there's a clearing just over there*, and then at the clearing, *Oh, look, a small path*, and then, *Oh, what's that up ahead?* I kept walking and the woods kept opening."

"How long did you look?"

"I'm not really sure."

"Well, I'd be pissed if I were you," P says. "What the hell, right? She endangered all of you, leading you into the woods at night." P is often angry. She has her reasons.

We turn to look at her.

"What about the woods scares you?"

"I don't know," P says.

"Trees?"

"No."

"Dirt?"

"No."

"Animals."

"Quit it."

"I'm more scared of an overwhelmed mom behind the wheel of a minivan."

P pinches her mouth. L tries to defuse any conflict. "Come on. We've all been there. Right? Late for something; no food in the house; tired, bratty kids; and you



think, *Maybe I should just 60-miles-an-hour into that tree.* Right? You've all been there." L laughs.

Everyone looks at L. No one says a thing.

THE NIGHT after the woods, J fell into bed at nine. The artist and her posse were probably just waking up, ready to begin their bacchanals. Fire and costumes and sex. Dancing, touching, making something new from the possessions of the dispossessed. Is that wild? J wondered. Cities in decline? Postapocalypse? Humans behaving badly with lots of drugs? That doesn't really seem wild, but maybe J would enjoy smearing her cheeks with odd colors and sneaking into her neighbors' houses at night to steal their belongings and have sex with multiple partners, sometimes even multiple partners at the same time on a pile of stolen loot.

It was wild growing humans inside her body. That was the most wildness J ever felt. And a posse of kids is wild. The other night J's 4-year-old said, "Mama, my vagina's singing." And J asked, "What's it singing about?" Her daughter didn't miss a beat. "Pee."

Still, J is worried that wild mostly has nothing to do with humans, especially the grown-up ones.

"**THE WOODS** didn't feel dangerous," J says. "I liked it in the woods."

"You really weren't scared?"

"No. I even shut off my light and stood in the dark."

"What?"

"Not me. No way."

"Everything felt soft. The trees were black. The sky had some blue left, like a painting, and it got quiet. People gave up

and went home. People stopped calling for her. I mean, it's not like she's the sort of woman who'd come just because someone called her anyway."

"How do you know?"

J shrugs.

"Where were the kids?"

"At the field. They were fine. They had a ball."

"How do you know? You were in the woods."

J smiles. "It got quieter the farther I went, and I liked it even more." J looks like a person who's telling a joke or a scary story, a person who knows something but won't

*We've all been there. Right?
Late for something; no food
in the house; tired, bratty kids;
and you think, Maybe I
should just 60-miles-an-hour
into that tree.*

say it plainly. "I was like a girl with an excellent hiding place. You know that feeling?"

"Yeah."

"Yeah."

"Yeah."

"Does she have children?"

"Everyone asks that question. Why does that matter?"

"It changes things. If her kids were there. If her kids were looking for her."

"She should behave because she's a mother?"

"She should be brave because she's a mother."

"Walking into the woods is not brave?"

"J."

"I really just want to know. I'm asking for real."

"Does she have a husband?"

"I don't know. We never found the woman."

"What?"

"What happened to her?"

"I don't know. Eventually I made my way back to the fields. My kids were in the car. They didn't even notice I'd been gone so long. We were the last to leave. Then there was no news about the woman, nothing in the papers. So I don't know."

"Did you imagine her?"

"Do 10, 12 people have the same dream?"

"You can go back."

"Also, I'm jealous thinking that she might still be there."

"Jealous? She'd be dead."

"The woods are better off without us in them."

"Well, that night I thought I might belong there. Or I wanted to belong there."

"You can't live in the woods. It rains. It snows. No coffee. The woods don't want you."

"But I felt something there."

"Ah, you were scared."

"No. Something—sorry—divine."

"Divine like good?"

"No. Divine like God."

The liberal mothers who hate religion look pained. "Jesus, J."

"Not him." She smiles.

"I just mean, holy crap. You felt God in the woods? What the fuck, girl?"

"That's not what I mean."

"Then what?"

J shrugs. "I felt unhuman. After a while, I lay down."

"On the ground?"

"The soil was so soft. I dug my fingers into it and it was like plugging into a socket. It was electrical. I don't know what's underneath that ground—microbes, mushrooms. But something crazy's there."

"What do you mean unhuman?"

"What'd the mushroom say, J?"

"Is that a joke?"

"I wondered how long before a body would disintegrate."

"I'm a real fungi. Get it?" K belches. Some mothers giggle. Some don't.

"You know D started microdosing?"

"Everyone's started microdosing."

"It wouldn't take long for a body to become forest again," J says.

"Ick."

"I don't know. What a way to go. Or to not go. To stay forever."

For the second time, the mothers look to see if the children can hear what's being said. No curses, but a conversation that skirts precariously close to the most taboo topic: mother death.

"Had you been drinking?" L tries to lighten things up again.

"Not even a sip, hon."

"You sat down?"

"I lay down. And to be honest," J says, "it was hot. It was sexual. Like the way giving birth is sexual. An animal."

"Birth is sexual? I think I missed something."

"Oh Christ."

Now the conservative moms get to look pained.

"You're funny, J."

"I don't mean to be."

"Then you shouldn't tell people that about the trees. I mean, you can tell us, but—"

"But no one wants to hear about a middle-aged mom having sex with a tree?"

"Wait. You had sex with a tree?"

"Maybe *sex* is the wrong word. Or else maybe the tree just wasn't that into me."

"Huh?"

"I think I mean decomposing."

"Rotting; the new sexy."

J smiles. "It's definitely more intense than screwing. Rotting is wild."

"Is wild the point?"

"I think so?"

"Not me. I like baking cupcakes and watching Netflix."

"Me too."

"My cousin has a cabin in the mountains. You should rent it from her, J."

"I like hot baths."

"So do I," J says. "I love hot baths."

"The woman disintegrated?"

"I don't know."

"I know you don't know, but what do you think happened?"

"Maybe she needed a hiding place. Maybe she did just need to poop. Or else the woods beckoned her. Maybe the woods needed her. She was watching the game and a leaf caught her eye and waved. Then suddenly a thousand new paths she'd never considered before seemed possible."

"Like what?"

"I don't know, but imagine this woman at Career Day." J's

I became part of the forest.' Then at least they'd know their options for real." J pauses, takes a measure of the room.

The mothers say nothing for a moment.

"Are you the woman, J?"

J shakes her head no.

"I'm sorry?" A is uptight. Insecure. Righteous. She's a fitness instructor. Also, she's a Career Day presenter. Also, she's a soccer coach. "Are you making a joke of this? This woman might have died. She might have been somebody's mother."

We pause our chatter again. We have already lost some

*She was watching the game
and a leaf caught her eye
and waved. Then suddenly
a thousand new paths
she'd never considered before
seemed possible.*

mothers here, and it is bad. The only thing worse than that is when we lose one of the children.

"You think she harmed herself?"

"There'd be a body if she had."

"Unless it disintegrated."

"It couldn't do it that fast."

"It?" A is really upset.

"Please. Please," J says. "I'm telling you something wonderful. Don't make it dreary. Please. Come on."

"It sounds like you're saying death is great. And I don't think it is. It's bleak and cold and it hurts us."

"It hurts the living."

"Yeah."

"Plus it sucks."

"Well, I just want to know if the woman is safe." A's got her hands on her hips. That sort of righteousness.

"Safe? What the fuck is that?"

"I want to know she's alive."

"Alive is safe?"

"I just want her to stay a mom," A says.

"We all want that. I mean if she even was—is—a mom."

"You're not thinking of hurting yourself, are you, J?"

"I'm telling you something strange and beautiful is in the woods. God is in the forest. No. Wait. God *is* the forest. Or not God. Silence. Or—"

"What the fuck, hon?"

"I don't know. Forget it. Forget I said anything. Please. I'll be embarrassed tomorrow."

"No. I get it, J. No offense, L, nice party, but how many of these have you already been to this year?"

J remains neutral, unsummarized. "I didn't come back from the forest because my kids were waiting. I came back because look: cabinets, doors, floors. You don't have to walk into the woods to know the forest. IKEA, motherfuckers."

"But this wood's dead."

"Yeah. And you're not scared of it. You don't hate it for dying. We should be more like the wood."

"More dead?"

"Less separate with life and death. I feel like I'm keeping a dirty little secret all the time, trying to hide something. Then, someone gets sick and it's like, oh shit, it's her fault she's going to die. She did something wrong. Not enough moisturizer or exercise or something."

The mothers look stricken.

"Are you sick, J?"

"No. I don't know."

"Then what are you talking about?"

J nods. "Forget it," she says again. "Forget it."

Some of the mothers pull their phones from their purses to have a look at the news of the world. The kitchen's quiet. The dead wood of the cabinets and tables just sits there. Finally, one woman puts down her phone and speaks up. "I'm going to root for being alive over being dead. Sorry, J. I like it here. I want to stay here, as a human. Soccer, dinner, cupcakes, all of it."

"Yeah."

"Yeah."

"Yeah. Go, team."

"You guys, I'm not rooting for death," J says. "I want to stay alive so much, I can't sleep at night trying to hold on to it. I'm just telling you that in the forest, the dead stuff in the ground wasn't dead. It was living. It was both. Dead and alive at the same time. It was making the trees grow and it was—"

"Wait. Wait." L, hostess without end, tries to make nice again. Smooth, sane, polite, safe gossip. "But what happened to the woman? Does anyone know? Should we go look? Maybe she's there, hurt. Maybe we just—"

"Oh wait. I know what happened to her," P says, a new thought dawning across her face.

"You do?"

"Were you there?"

"No. But I know what happened."

"You weren't even there, P?"

"You saw a ghost, J."

"Huh."

"Or a zombie. Like on the show last night. For real."

"Don't tell me. I haven't watched it yet."

"I'm serious. It's the only explanation that makes sense. You saw a woman go into the woods and never come out. Why did she have no car? Why did she have no kids?"

"Why?"

"Because she's dead."

"Or maybe she just likes the woods. Maybe she didn't want to have kids."

"Stop."

"And you were walking right into her trap, J. How do we know you're not dead too?"

"I am dead too. That's what I'm trying to tell you, dead and alive."

"So she got you? She bit you? That's why you're acting so weird."

"No. I never even saw her in the woods. Are you listening?"

"Oh God."

"Stop."

"I'm serious. Maybe J just hasn't started to decay yet. When did you say this happened?"

"Stop. You're scaring me."

"I've definitely started to decay. You have too, P."

"You're scaring me."

"Well maybe we should be scared." P grabs J's wrist, trying to feel for a pulse.

"Really?" J asks.

"It's just like the show. No one knew she was a zombie until she ate all their brains."

"Fuck! You just ruined the one highlight of my week. She ate them all?"

"Or maybe the woman did come out of the woods again."

Came out of the woods dead. She could be anywhere. She could be walking among all of the kids right now, coming to Career—"

The doorbell rings.

"Shit!" The mothers jump.

"It's just the door," L says.

"Don't answer it."

"Are you serious?"

"Didn't you watch?"

"Don't answer the door, L."

Then a firm knock. The mothers listen from the kitchen. L tries to crane her neck to see through the window. "It might be the new girl's mom. I have to let her in."

"No you don't."

"Yeah you do."

"What if she's dead?"

"Open the door, L. This is absurd."

"Yeah."

"Stop."

"Please don't." One mother unwraps a cupcake, takes a large bite. "Don't."

"Are you kidding me?"

"Please."

"Open the door."

"You have to."

"Yeah, you do," J says.

"Even if she is dead."

"Jesus, J! Stop it. I'm not going to sleep for weeks. Please."

L approaches the door. A handful of the mothers shrink in their seats.

"Open the door," J says.

"Open all the doors."

"Shit. Hold up. Hold up,"

A says. "The kids are coming."

"The kids are coming? Fuck. Don't open the door."

"Are you okay, J? Everybody good?"

"I'm fine. Yeah."

"You sure?"

"I'm fine."

"Don't open that door."

"Here come the kids. Ah, Christ. Goody bags. Sorry, L."

L slows her approach toward the door. Her hand nears the knob. "I swear I only put in healthy snacks and some erasers. Oh, and a Ring Pop. And Tootsie Rolls. And a water pistol. Everybody all right?"

"Don't open the door."

L pauses in the foyer. "Hello?" She lifts her hand to the door as if to touch the thing on the other side, to know it without having to open to it. Only it doesn't work that way. The wood of the door reveals nothing. And L, inside the house, knows nothing of outsides. L touches the knob.

"I'm fine," J says in the kitchen. "I probably have the story wrong, anyway. The sun set so no one saw the woman come back, find her things—you know, her keys, her phone, her kids. No one saw her drive home in the dark. That's how you want the story to end, right?"

The mothers watch L at the door.

"Right," one of them says.

"Sure. Shhh. Here come the kids."

"Right. Shut the fuck up. Here come the kids." *A*

Samantha Hunt is the author of three novels and a collection of stories. She has won the National Book Foundation's 5 Under 35 award, the Bard Fiction Prize, and the St. Francis College Literary Prize.

ATHENA PHEROMONES™ INCREASE AFFECTION



Created by
Winnifred Cutler,
Ph.D. in biology
from U. of Penn,
post-doc Stanford.
Co-discovered
human pheromones
in 1986
Author of 8 books
on wellness
**SAVE \$100 with our
6-Pak special offer**

**PROVEN EFFECTIVE IN 3 DOUBLE BLIND
STUDIES IN PEER REVIEW JOURNALS**



INCREASES YOUR ATTRACTIVENESS

Athena 10X™ For Men \$99.50
10:13™ For Women \$98.50
Cosmetics **Free U.S. Shipping**

♥ **Donna (OR)** "Athena 1013 makes a difference in the way people treat you. They want to be around you. I am in medical school, the pheromone makes such a difference in my work."

♥ **Jacques (LA)** "I am a physician, read about your study in the Medical Tribune, and have been buying ever since. 10X is a really fine product."



Not in stores 610-827-2200
Athenainstitute.com

Athena Institute, 1211 Braefield Rd., Chester Spgs, PA 19425 ATM

Light & Easy Kayak

Sea Eagle® RazorLite™ 393rl



- 12'10" x 28"
- Patented Design
- Packs Small To Go Anywhere
- Inflates in 7 minutes • 35 lbs.

The inflatable **Sea Eagle RazorLite 393rl** is so light it can be carried in a backpack to remote waters or checked as baggage. So easy you will glide through the water with minimal effort. The patented design allows the kayak to cut through wind, waves and current at up to 6 mph. Packs small to fit in a car trunk and inflates in minutes.



**Fits in a bag!
Deflates to
22"x22"x12"**

Call 800-944-7496 for a
free catalog or visit:

SEA EAGLE.com

Dept AT030B
19 N. Columbia St
Port Jefferson, NY 11777

Happy Labrador

STERLING
SILVER
pendant \$85
pin \$65

14K GOLD
pendant \$550
pin \$450

S/H \$8.95

*Velvet Box
Pendant Includes
Chain*



Actual
Size

ROGER NICHOLS studios
354 NE Dekalb Ave., Ste. 100 • Bend, OR 97701
800-235-0471 • www.rnstudios.com

BERT AND I...

Find our podcasts, listen & laugh!

Get the new CD & all ORIGINAL albums on CD
plus Bert and I books, hats & T-shirts at
www.bertandi.ME • 207-230-9570



MODERN MEMOIRS, INC.

As-told-to memoirs &
self-publishing services
~since 1994

413-253-2353



**YOUR WALL
YOUR IDEAS
YOUR STORIES**

WhiteWalls®

Magnetic Dry-Erase
Whiteboard Panels

WhiteWalls.com | 800-624-4154 | sales@magnatag.com

MAGNATAG
Visible Systems



VisuGlass®
Premium Glass Whiteboards
**NO GREEN TINT—
NO CLOUDY LOOK**
We use **optically clear low lead** tempered glass for **brighter whites** and the **highest definition prints.**

Raise
THE AESTHETICS
OF YOUR OFFICE

magnatag.com/VIG | 800-624-4154




Banjo Paterson

Rain or shine the Banjo Paterson is your perfect crossover hat, at home in the city or country. Long lasting fur felt, Barramundi hat band, roan leather sweat band. 4½" crown, 2¾" brim.

Sizes 6 ¾ - 8, Heritage Fawn or Charcoal
#1622 Banjo Paterson \$184 delivered

order via davidmorgan.com
or request our print catalog

#KB-336-SC



#1746

#1632

David Morgan

800-324-4934 davidmorgan.com

11812 N Creek Pkwy N, Ste 103 • Bothell, WA 98011

World's Finest Eye Cream

a "selections" product in Oprah magazine



**20%
Off**

AIRBRUSH

Eye Refining Treatment

Airbrush Eye Cream reduces puffiness right away, especially when cold. Promotes new collagen which reduces fine lines and wrinkles. Reduces dark circles, is soothing, hydrating and promotes a youthful healthy glow!

Reg \$68

Now only \$54.40

Compare to:

La Mer Eye Balm @ \$200
Shiseido Solution LX @ \$130
La Prairie Swiss @ \$240

Hypo-allergenic and natural containing emu oil serum, green tea extract, aloe vera, collagen and elastin.

Use am & pm for best results and the jar will last about 3 months!

Use 20% discount code: **ATX** at

..... www.dremu.com

or call 800-542-0026 and get free shipping.

Open 7 Days

AN EDGE ABOVE THE REST.



The legendary Lansky Controlled-Angle System ensures that your knife edge is sharpened to the exact bevel you specify.

Learn more at lansky.com

LANSKY
SHARPENERS

Sharpen your skills | Find us on 

*Here's
what used
to happen.*

I'd wake up, smoldering and sighing, reel out of bed and into the kitchen, and put the kettle on. Then I'd think: *Well, now what?* Time would go granular, like in a Jack Reacher novel, but less exciting. Five minutes at least until the kettle boils. Make a decision. Crack the laptop, read the news. Or stare murkily out the window. Unload the dishwasher? Oh dear. Is this life, this sour weight, this baggage of consciousness? What's that smell? It's futility, rising in fumes around me. And all this before 7 a.m.

Here's what happens now.

I wake up, smoldering and sighing, reel out of bed and into the kitchen, and put the kettle on. And then I have a cold shower.

I don't want to go overboard here, reader. Life-changing, neurosis-canceling, enlightenment at the twist of a tap—I don't want to make these claims for the early-morning cold shower. But if like me you have a sluggish seam of depression in your nature, and a somewhat cramped brain, and a powerful need, throughout the day, for quasi-electrical interventions of one sort or another, reboots and renewals—or if you just want to wake up a little faster—can I most devoutly recommend that you give it a shot?

Do it first thing. As soon as you get up. Don't torture

yourself with postponement. And don't muck around with hot-to-cold transitions, temperature tweakings, etc. Fling wide the plastic curtain, crank the tap to its coldest, take a breath, and step right in. Not grimly or penitentially, but with slapstick defiance: *Holy Mother of God! Cowabunga! Here I go!* (If it's too early in the day for slapstick defiance, try a headshake of weary amazement.)

The water hits, and biology asserts itself. You are not a tired balloon of cerebral activity; you are a body, and you are being challenged. You gulp air; your pulse thumps. Your brain, meanwhile, your lovely, furry old brain, goes glacier-blue with shock. Thought is abolished. Personality is abolished. You're a nameless mammal under a ravening jet of cold water. It's a kind of accelerated mindfulness, really: In two seconds, you're at the sweet spot between nonentity and total presence. It's the cold behind the cold; the beautiful, immobile zero; a flame of numbness bending you to its will. Also—this is important—you can still lather up in a cold shower, and get all your washing done: hair, body, everything.

Then you get out, and you're different. Things have happened to your neurotransmitters that may be associated, say the scientists, with elevated mood and increased alertness. You're wide awake, at any rate. Your epidermis is cool and seal-like. Your nervous system is jangling—but melodically, like tiny bells. And from the kitchen, you can hear the kettle starting to whistle. *A*

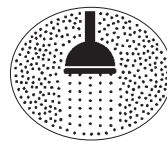
James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

ODE

— to —

COLD SHOWERS

By James Parker





“The ultimate prize will be when we defeat you, ~~cancer~~”

Dr. Jim Allison | Cancer Researcher & Nobel Laureate

Dr. Jim Allison's breakthrough in immunotherapy earned him the 2018 Nobel Prize and transformed cancer care. Groundbreaking research like this allows our world-renowned team of experts to offer the most innovative clinical trials and leading-edge treatments – giving more hope to patients and families.

Choose MD Anderson first. Call 1-855-894-0145 or visit MakingCancerHistory.com.



Ranked number one in the
nation for cancer care by
U.S. News & World Report.

THE UNIVERSITY OF TEXAS
**MD Anderson
~~Cancer~~ Center**

Making Cancer History®

A man with dark hair and blue eyes, wearing a black Balenciaga suit, stands against a solid blue background. He is looking directly at the camera with a serious expression. A small red Balenciaga logo is visible on his left lapel.

BLCG

POWER OF DREAMS

BALENCIAGA